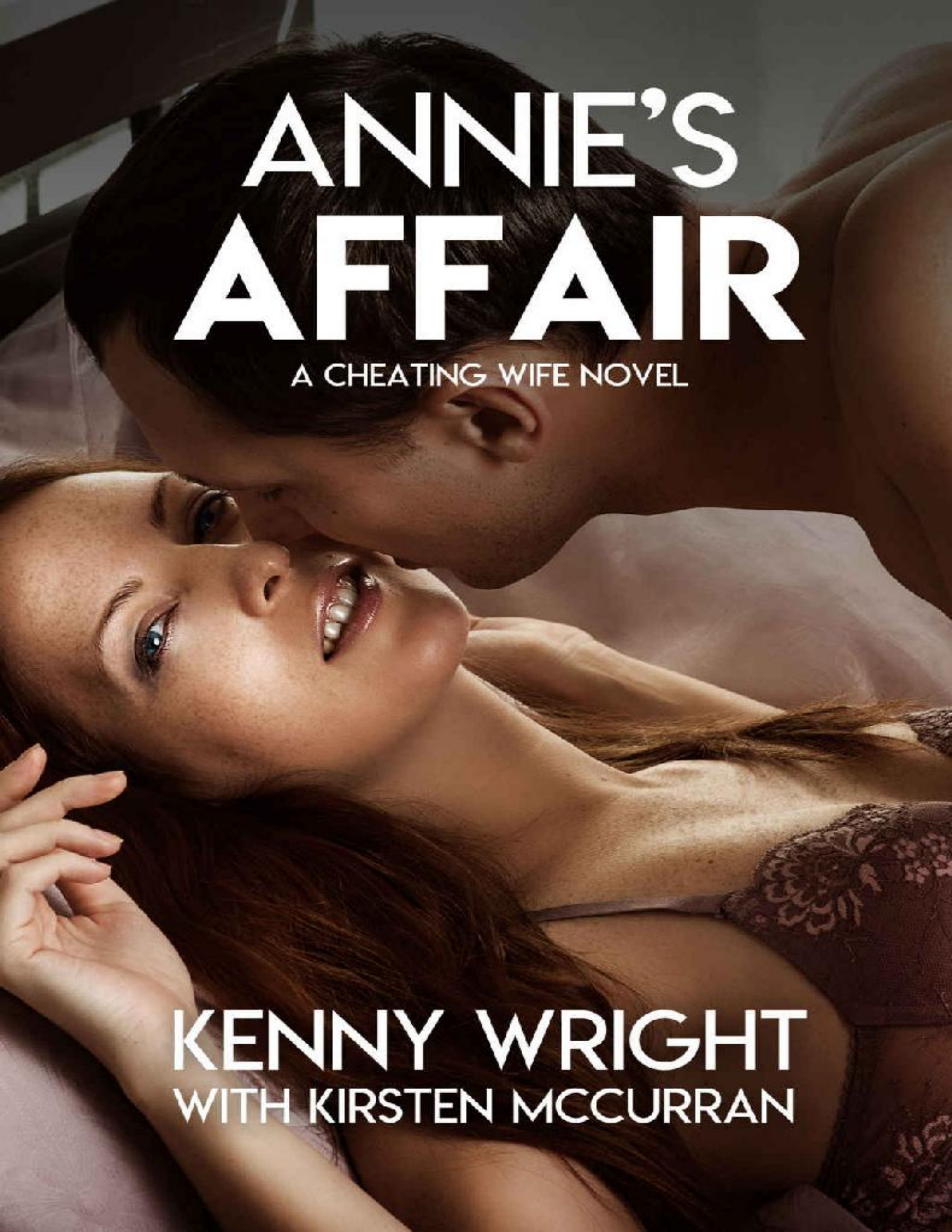


A close-up photograph of a man and a woman in a romantic embrace. The man, with dark hair, is leaning over the woman, his face partially visible as he looks down at her. The woman, with long brown hair and blue eyes, is lying back, looking up at him with a slight smile. She is wearing a dark, lace-trimmed top. The background is softly blurred, suggesting an indoor setting like a bedroom.

ANNIE'S AFFAIR

A CHEATING WIFE NOVEL

KENNY WRIGHT
WITH KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

Foreword

This is not a hotwife book. It is a cheating wife book, about a wife who cheats on her husband. Behind his back. I want to set expectations, because I know this kind of storyline can offend. This book is also not a burn the bitch (BTB) book. Anyone who knows me and the things I write should know that I don't go in for that kind of thing.

This is a book about a couple of flawed individuals who've grown apart after nearly twenty years of marriage. Both make mistakes, big and small. They don't talk, they don't communicate, they don't share their feelings anymore, and this gets them into trouble.

I wrote this book for a number of reasons. For one, I wanted to try something truly different. One that doesn't take the standard arc of mutual discovery and exploration. But that's not the only reason. I'll admit—somewhat reluctantly—that the idea of an affair titillates me in a way that's wrong and messed up and irrational. Annie, the wife, being so bad and doing it all for herself and for no one else is hot. In real life, this would be devastating. But this is fiction and fantasy, as safe a place as any to explore the tough, complicated emotions behind an affair—and the cuckold experiences that come with it.

I could not have done this without the help of my dear friend, Kirsten McCurran. So much so that she gets her name on the cover. She wrote all of Annie's diaries. In some sense, she knows Annie better than I do, and even the parts that Kirsten didn't write, I frequently consulted with her just to nail Annie's reactions.

But Kirsten's not the only person I have to thank. Thanks to Stephen and Gary for going through and editing it. I've looked at this thing for so long that I don't see any of that anymore. Thanks to Arnica Butler for letting me use her fictitious dating app, DeBauch. If you want to read more about that, check out her sexy novel, *Body of Research*.

Thanks to Max Sebastian, Sean Geist, and ABF for beta reading the book and giving me their feedback. I think the end product is so much stronger for your honest words. Thanks to my wife, as always, for putting up with this hobby and giving me the space to write. And thanks to all of you, dear readers. Your feedback, comments, and support keep me going.

Enjoy!

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Prologue

“So Travis, are you ready to talk about it?” Dr. Caroline sits across from me, her notebook in her lap and that always neutral smile on her lips.

“Sure, I guess. I’m here.” I feel like a teenager dragged into the principal’s office, not a middle aged man voluntarily visiting his therapist. “Where do you want me to start?”

“Where would you like to?” Typical therapist response. I should have anticipated it, and frown at myself more than at Caroline. She misinterprets my frown, hastily suggesting, “Why not start at the beginning.”

Maybe this is a mistake. Do I really need a therapist to intervene, when I am one myself? More, so is my wife, Annie? By training, anyway. But we haven’t been doing so well on our own, either. We need someone else. We need someone to mediate, at the very least, and from what I can tell from the few meetings we’ve had, Caroline is good. I sigh.

She sits patiently, watching as I work this out in my head without interrupting. She knows that I’ll speak when ready.

My heartbeat speeds up. I’m really going to do this, aren’t I? Say this story out loud. To other human beings. “The beginning, as in when I learned about Annie’s affair? Or when I discovered her diary? Or, like, the *beginning* beginning.”

“The beginning,” Caroline simply says.

I groan, but can’t help but smile. It’s like talking to myself. “Okay, the beginning.”

Chapter 1

I guess one way to start is to talk about Paris. That's probably when I noticed that something was up. Or maybe I just noticed Annie, for the first time in years.

But actually, maybe I should really start at the very beginning, when we first met in grad school at Michigan. That was over twenty years ago. Man, I feel old. We were both in the Psyche program, although different concentrations. I still remember seeing her for the first time and being blown away by her eyes.

In fact, at the time, it was only her eyes that I could see. It had been unusually cold, even for Michigan, the first day of the new semester. She came in bundled up, a blue knit hat pulled down over her forehead, a handwoven scarf wrapped around her neck and lower face, covering her nose. Only her eyes were visible, deep blue, rimmed with dark lashes, in the center of paperwhite skin and dark auburn brows.

Her eyes drew me to her, but it was her smart yet quiet demeanor that I fell for. Hard. I'd never met anyone quite like her. She was from the Midwest. Grew up on an actual farm, although the family had stopped farming it before she'd been born. She was the oldest child of three, and as such took on a maturity beyond her years. She carried that long into her later years.

Oh, and she was attractive—albeit in a softer, sweeter way than many of the girls I dated. She rarely wore makeup back then. She didn't need to. Her pale, freckled skin and rich, copper hair were alluring enough, in a natural way.

I remember the first time I saw her without her clothes on. I was floored by the beautiful body she'd been hiding, and I distinctly recall thinking, 'Quiet girl who's smart and funny and attractive but doesn't realize it? Travis, my friend, you hit the jackpot.' She was soft in all the right ways, curvy and sensual with full breasts and wide, rolling hips. Embarrassingly, that first night was kind of a bust because I'd been unable to, um, contain myself. But she kept me anyway.

So that was Annie for so many years. The more I got to know her, the more in love I became. She was a big board game enthusiast. She loved

horseback riding. She never liked living in the city, even though she agreed to give it a try shortly after we got married. We liked to travel—in the couple of years before our daughter was born, anyway. She loved the rolling hills of Ireland, where her grandparents still lived, and the castles of Bavaria. She loved Belgian-style beer, although never drank too much of it.

We had our daughter, Olivia, early on. Annie didn't want to wait, and my career was taking off. We moved to the suburbs. She stayed home with Olivia, joined the PTA and got very involved in the neighborhood.

Time passed. Olivia grew up and things between me and Annie settled into something comfortable and familiar. We still had a good time together. We could still make each other laugh. We went out on dates. We made love. We would host board game nights with our other married friends, and on the weekends, Annie would go out to the countryside to ride horses.

I thought it was a picture perfect life, albeit predictable. This is how we'd grow old together. I could see the trajectory of the rest of our lives like a jet's contrails across a blue and cloudless sky.

And then, Paris happened.

*

"Sorry I'm late," I said, sliding into the chair across the table from Annie. She'd already finished most of her first glass of wine. "Got caught up after the last round of talks."

Annie put her phone away and smiled. "It's okay. You're not that late."

She wasn't mad or frustrated. She didn't even tease me for arriving at the restaurant thirty minutes late on our nineteenth anniversary. It was worse—she was desensitized. After nineteen years of marriage, she knew punctuality wasn't my strong suit, so she no longer put energy into being upset.

"You look nice," I said. "Get your hair done?"

Annie brushed her rich, red hair over her shoulders. She'd put earrings on, I noticed, little diamond studs I'd given her on our fifteenth anniversary—I think.

"I took a shower?" she said. "And I even used shampoo *and* conditioner."

I laughed. It was an old joke, one that I couldn't even remember the origin of. "Fancy."

“So how was your day?”

“Not bad. Making some headway on the sanctuary city story, although I may need to do a late interview tonight. After dinner, I mean, if that’s okay.”

“Hmm?” I asked, distracted by the menu and my grumbling stomach. “Oh, yes, that’s fine. Wish you didn’t have to work, though. Don’t they know it’s your anniversary?”

“Somehow my anniversary in Paris didn’t come up when we were trying to work within the schedule of this particular immigrant family afraid of getting split up without notice. Just couldn’t work it into the screener.”

“Fair enough,” I said. “What time?”

“Two their time, so about eleven here.”

“Wow. Late.”

We talked about some of the details as we waited to put our orders in. Then we talked about my day and how the Paris Symposium was going. I’d been invited to do the closing day keynote, and since the symposium coincided with our anniversary, Annie had tagged along so we could celebrate in style.

Not that there was a ton of romance, despite being in Paris. We went to some great restaurants, did the Eiffel tower thing, walked through Montmartre and got some crepes or whatever. But we did Paris like we were friends, rather than lovers. We didn’t even have sex in the first few days of our trip, despite the fancy room at the boutique, Parisian hotel. Even our anniversary dinner got consumed with mundane chatter.

After nineteen years, the times of being swept off our feet, of feeling my heart race at the thought of seeing her again, were behind us. Or so I thought, anyway.

Annie looked great, though, even if she played it down. She may have said she only washed her hair, but it still looked good, falling in rich, glossy waves around her shoulders. Her dress was a new one, an elegant wrap of champagne-colored silk. Annie possessed the kind of natural beauty that didn’t require makeup, but when she did wear it, she always looked stunning. Tonight, she was stunning.

As she talked about her current assignment—the psychological impact of sanctuary city laws on both immigrant families and law enforcement—I couldn’t help but stare at her and wonder how I could ever take her for

granted. There was a time when we would have been all over each other the moment we stepped into our hotel room.

“What?” she asked, seeing me staring at her.

“Nothing. Just... you’re beautiful, that’s all.”

“Thank you,” she said brightly. “You’re not so bad yourself, handsome.”

“No, I’m serious. You really didn’t something with your hair?”

“Actually, I did have my eyebrows done,” she offered. “And I put on some makeup.”

“It looks great.”

She suddenly looked suspicious. “You’re not trying to get out of the Louvre tour, are you? We’ve got tickets already—”

I laughed. “No, no. I just...” I sighed. “You look great.”

I let it go. Forgot about it, even, with the good food and even better wine. Talk turned from our professional lives to Olivia and how we thought she was doing at school. She’d just finished up her freshman year, and had liked it so much that she’d opted to stay through the summer. We missed her, but she seemed to be thriving.

That led to talk of the past, of our good memories of her growing up, even a few experiences we’d shared before having her. We walked home from the restaurant, leaning on each other, enjoying the warm, Paris night air. She even slipped her hand inside mine, which felt intimate in a way we hadn’t been in awhile.

“Nineteen years,” Annie said as we stumbled into our hotel room at last. “I can hardly believe it.”

“Makes me feel old.”

She smirked. “You’re only as old as you feel.”

“Then I’m *old*,” I groaned. I sat on the edge of the bed, pulled my shoes off, and rubbed my feet. I was winded, despite the walk only being less than a mile.

Annie giggled. She must have been tipsy, because she only giggled when she was tipsy.

“You know what’ll make you feel younger?” She started toward the bathroom. “A shower...” She shrugged out of her champagne-colored dress and looked over her shoulder. “With me.”

Now I knew she was tipsy. We *never* had showers together. Not in a long time.

I followed, drinking in her matching bra and panties, constructed of satin and lace. That was definitely new. I ran my hand along the strap, kissing the smattering of freckles on her shoulder as she reached into the shower to start the water.

When I unsnapped her bra in one fluid motion, releasing her full breasts, she looked back and said, “You’ve still got the touch.”

Her panties weren’t exactly a thong—I would have *died* if Annie actually wore a thong—but the lacy underwear still clung to her heart shaped ass in all the right ways.

Annie turned, going to work on my shirt as I wrapped my arms around her. I felt giddy being with her. When she had my shirt off, she pulled me in for a deep hug, her full tits pressing against my bare chest.

“Nineteen years,” I said. “You know, I think you’re sexier now than when I first met you.”

“Oh, please.” She rolled her eyes, but blushed as the complement landed.

Truth was, in many ways, she *was* sexier, and she carried that beauty with more confidence. I wondered, at the time, if she knew she was.

We kissed, slowly and passionately. It wasn’t the familiar kiss we shared in the mornings, saying goodbye, or in the evenings before bed. It was a lover’s kiss.

Annie reached down and wrapped her hand around my cock. “You’re so hard,” she whispered.

“Your fault.”

“Come on.” She shimmied out of her panties and slinked backwards into the shower. “Water’s nice and warm.”

I quickly stepped out of my pants, stealing looks at her naked body like it was the first time. She has a pinup model’s body, softer than she probably preferred, but glorious because of that softness. From her ripe, teardrop-shaped breasts and their dark nipples to her narrow waist and flaring hips to her long, runner’s legs, she was voluptuous. A perfect hourglass.

My breath caught at the sight of something I’d never seen before. Her normally wild, auburn bush had been reduced to a narrow stripe of hair above her clit, and beneath, her pussy was shockingly bare. I stared as the water of the shower enveloped her, running rivulets across her flat stomach and her strange and sexy pussy.

“My eyebrows aren’t the only thing I had done. Happy anniversary, baby.”

“That’s so sexy,” I said, almost to myself, as I joined her beneath the spray. “You got a...wax? All I got you were a pair of earrings.”

She put her hands on my shoulders and laughed. “Well, there’s always next year.”

We shared another uncharacteristically passionate kiss as I slid my hand down between her thighs. The skin around her landing strip was impossibly soft, tender and slick, as smooth as the nape of her neck. I found her clit easily, brushing my fingers across it. Annie broke the kiss, gasping.

I knew how I could make it up to her, although I hadn’t done so in years. Kissing her neck and sliding my fingers inside of her, I warmed her up. I worshipped her. I filled my free hand with the soft weight of her tit, tweaking her nipples—drawing more gasps. She groped at me, rubbing my cock, pressing it against my abdomen as her lips once again sought mine.

I pulled back, denying her the kiss, and when her eyes fluttered open, I just grinned, kissed her shoulder, and sank down to my knees.

“What are you—oh!”

I lifted one of her feet up onto the soap shelf, her pussy opening for me, swollen and wet and as pale as the rest of her. My fingers glided along her bare skin, covered in a sheen of her tangy excitement.

“You don’t have to...” she said, but her fingers, digging into my scalp, betrayed her true thoughts.

“I want to.” I leaned forward, my lips kissing her pussy as my fingers traced up along her landing strip.

My cock was so hard. This was so unbelievable.

“Oh, Trav!”

I spread her open as I lapped at the soft and sensitive skin. With the warm water rushing across her body and flooding my mouth, breathing became a challenge—but one worth fighting for. Annie’s moans inspired. The hand she rested in my hair encouraged. The way she pushed her hips against my face felt as new and refreshing as her waxed mound.

“That feels...so good,” she gasped.

I rubbed her clit with my thumb as I looked up at her, my heart skipping at the sight of her clutching her tit and squeezing her nipple. Her eyes were shut, her head tilted and her back resting against the wall.

I buried my tongue between those smooth folds, bringing Annie to a swift orgasm, high-pitched and straining. She clamped her thighs around my head and held me against her. Shower water flooded around me, drowning me as I continued to drive my tongue in and out of her cunt. I ate her until it was too much—for her, for me. The water rushed on, and suddenly I was inhaling it.

Coughing, I tore myself out of the vise of her thighs, sputtering and coughing.

Concern filled Annie at once. “Are you okay?” she asked, dropping to a crouch and reaching for me.

I laughed. “Yeah, just give me a minute.”

She kissed me softly. “Thanks for doing that.”

It was a weird thing, when a woman I’d known for so long still had to thank me for oral sex. I wished that she didn’t feel that way, but that was Annie.

I ran my fingers across her waxed pussy. She shivered. “Thanks for doing this. Sensitive?”

“Oh yeah.”

“You should keep it that way. It’s sexy.”

“It hurt. A lot.”

“Sometimes pain is worth it.”

She smiled shyly. “You may be right about that.”

“So you went to a salon...when? This afternoon?” I asked, then held my breath.

“Yesterday, actually.”

“So you were like this last night? Why didn’t you tell me?”

“Then what would I do for our anniversary?” she teased.

“There’s still some more you could take off.”

“Now you’re pushing it, mister.”

“So you were like that all day? Must have been distracting.”

“Um, I guess so.”

“Walking all over Paris with this naughty surprise.” I touched her face. “A sexy little secret.”

I stood, my cock bouncing before me. Annie reached out and wrapped her hand around it.

“This guy approves.”

“He’s not very picky, but yeah. He does.”

She stroked my cock, watching it throb in her hand. For a second, I thought she might give me a blowjob. When was the last time she'd actually done that?

Then she stood up, joined me. We kissed again, maneuvering beneath the spray of the shower. It wasn't huge in here, but we attempted something that we hadn't done since we were younger and more flexible—shower sex.

"How should I—"

"Turn around and face the...yeah, just like that."

I bent my legs and pressed my cock against her pussy. It glanced off her sex at first, the angle wrong. Annie reached between her legs, guiding me into her.

The rubbery texture of her waxed lips yielded to the slicker embrace of her pussy. When I pulled back to thrust, though, I slipped free. We both groaned in frustration.

"This is trickier than I remember," I said, trying again.

"You going to be okay?"

"Yeah." Sort of. When I began to pump her, I felt the burn in my legs after the first minute. After the second minute, my thighs and calves were screaming.

I held her by the hips as she thrust her ass out, her chest mashed against the wall. With each thrust, I watched her ass jiggle, tantalizing me. Spurring me on. I dug my thumbs into her cheeks, fucking her harder, knowing I wouldn't be able to hold out for long.

She didn't beg me to fuck her. Annie didn't talk dirty. But she moaned like she hadn't in years, pushing her hips back to meet my driving cock. I was overcome by the strange urge to spank her—I had never done that before, and didn't then—but it still set me off. I buried myself one last time into her, feeling her tight, smooth pussy close around the root of my shaft, and exploded deep. Her own cries built to a crescendo, whether her orgasm was real or not, I didn't know. Didn't care. She gasped, I grunted, and we melted into one another beneath the hiss of the shower and stifling steam.

I pulled out of her, my heart racing, my dick still semi-erect. Annie sank to the floor of the shower, pushed her hair out of her face, and smiled up at me.

We didn't do this. We didn't have spontaneous sex. We didn't have much sex at all, for that matter. Annie had never been much of one to need it—she was one of those women who claimed that she had no fantasies, and

never really showed signs of craving sex—and I was just getting old...er. I wasn't old yet. But as I looked down at her, demure and sexy and nude, I wondered why we didn't.

Annie seemed to read my thoughts. "If this is nineteen years, I can't wait for twenty."

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Chapter 2

After the shower sex, Annie got ready for her late night conference call, throwing on a pair of yoga leggings and a loose and comfortable top. Little things like that put our jobs in stark contrast. I always found it interesting how differently we'd put our PhDs to work. Where I'd taken the more traditional route—private practice, then eventually to a think tank—Annie had turned toward social good.

Before the internet, she wrote an advice column in a newspaper while working as a social worker. Once blogs became a thing, she broadened her scope to help anyone needing help, moving from publication to publication—the world is fluid that way these days. A few months back, she started her most recent contract with the International Herald, a weekly magazine-turned-online news site.

I'll confess, I can't really tell you exactly the details of the new contract. She'd told me at one point, but it was while I'd been preparing for this trip and I just can't remember any of the specifics. After all these years of marriage, this was where we were—living almost separate lives, half-listening to the other as we got consumed by our own.

I didn't even fully understand the story she was working on—one that was so time-sensitive that the lead would vanish if she didn't take a phone call at eleven at night. Something about sanctuary cities and the psychological impact our changing world had on both immigrant families and the families of law enforcement. Who she was interviewing, though, escaped me, but whatever it was, she was passionate about it.

"You all set?" I asked as she gathered her laptop and notebook.

"For sure. This one's going to be tricky, you know?" I didn't, but nodded like I did. "But I'm prepared. I'm good."

"Of course you are." The banality of my response made me cringe. I kissed her to cover it up.

"Don't wait up, this could go on for a few hours, and you've got a full day tomorrow."

"How am I going to sleep without you at my side."

"Ah, so sweet. Well, try."

I watched her go, checking her out in those yoga pants one last time before turning to my notes. I was still jetlagged enough that I wouldn't be getting to sleep just yet, even at 10:45, so I pulled up my keynote speech and went over it again.

Two hours passed in the blink of an eye. I thought I'd fall asleep, but after going over my speech, making tweaks, and reworking some of the slides, it was suddenly almost one in the morning and Annie still wasn't back.

I'm not sure why I went downstairs, looking for her. I wasn't worried about her or what she was up to. Just wanted to say goodnight, I guess. I pulled on a pair of pants and went down in the t-shirt I wore to bed. Everyone was asleep other than the concierge, who looked up at me with an air of disapproval for my state of undress.

"*Monsieur?*"

"Sorry, I'm looking for my wife, Annie." When he looked at me blankly, I added, "She said something about a conference room?"

"Ah, *Madam* Belmont. *Oi*, she is just down the hall." He pointed toward the back. "Where we serve breakfast."

The hall into the back was short. There was a small sitting alcove and a couple halls that broke off into the backrooms, where the employees worked. All was dark and silent now. The late hour created an air of something illicit, like I was trespassing or something, and because of that, I moved silently along the carpeted floor.

The hall turned, opening up into the dining space that we'd had scones and pastries that morning. Annie sat at a table at the far end of the room, speaking into her laptop. Her loose top hung over the back of her chair, leaving her in a black tank top that, while pretty form fitting, was more casual than sexy. Coupled with her glasses, she looked like a sexy nerd girl—my sexy nerd girl. Funny how I'd not looked at her like that in a long time.

She laughed into the computer, brightening her face, and nodded.

"Thank you so much for your time. I know this is hard, but your story is exactly what we're looking for.

"*Oh, it's my pleasure,*" came a woman's voice over the tinny speakers of Annie's laptop. "*Thank you for letting me tell it.*"

I kept quiet, hearing that the interview was still on. Kept back in the recesses of the hall.

“We’ll be in touch when the story goes up. It should be about a week, I hope. Rick controls the editorial schedule.”

“Next week’s what we’re shooting for.” A man’s voice. Presumably Rick’s. *“Annie’s stuff is good. Hardly needs an editor.”*

“Oh, stop,” Annie said, her voice rising an octave. She *giggled*. Something shifted uncomfortably inside of me.

The call wrapped up. Or, at least, the woman they were interviewing hung up. Annie, however, kept talking.

“That was *amazing*. She was great.”

“You’re amazing,” the man, Rick, said. *“You never cease to impress me, Annie. The way you get people to open up is like some kind of sorcery.”*

Annie giggled again. She adjusted her glasses, and I swear her face started to flush. I slowly took a step back, receding further into the darkness of the hall, my ears open. Out of nowhere, I started feeling a clammy, feverish feeling, like the onset of the flu.

“I’ve been doing this a long time.”

“Oh, please. Couldn’t be doing it that long. You’re what? Thirty...four?”

“Oh, Rick, flattering, but not even close.”

“Impossible. Thirty-eight?”

“We are so not talking about my age.”

“You’re right. Doesn’t matter. You’re a good looking woman...especially for a sixty-year-old.”

Annie laughed, covering her mouth. “I swear I’m going to log a complaint with Danielle.”

“You know I’m just teasing.”

I rolled my eyes.

“Besides, we both know you like it.”

It was a throwaway line except for how Annie received it. She stiffened, shifting in her chair. What was he talking about? I tried to remember who this Rick was, but I’d been so bad about listening to Annie these days that I drew a blank.

“I’m going now.” She didn’t sound completely upset, although at least she was no longer giggling. “And go to bed with my *husband*. Whom I love.”

Rick didn’t miss a beat. *“So jealous of that man.”*

“Goodnight. I’ll see you next week.”

“Can’t wait.”

“Good night, Rick.”

“Night, Annie.”

Annie carefully closed the laptop, although she didn’t immediately pack up her things. Instead, she sat there, staring at the powered down machine. A smile spread across her face. Her fingers slowly moved to her lips, touching them, her thoughts a million miles away.

Then she released a breath and shook her head. *Enough*, she seemed to say—if not in word, then in action.

With that, I snapped out of it, too. I should have just stepped into the room, said hello, but that felt wrong. I shouldn’t have been eavesdropping, and now my place in the shadows felt shameful.

I snuck back, happy that the hall was carpeted, and even happier that the concierge was nowhere to be seen.

I calmly walked through the lobby, just in case he materialized, reaching the doors to the stairs. I made a break for it as soon as the door shut behind me, taking the steps two or three at a time. Good thing we were only on the third floor, but still, I was out of breath and covered with a sheen of sweat that I could feel build along my spine by the time I reached our room.

Crawling into bed, I grabbed my laptop and pulled up my presentation, starting it somewhere in the middle to make it look like I’d been doing this all along. I needn’t have worried about that, though, because Annie didn’t make it up for another ten minutes.

It gave me time to think, which wasn’t the best thing in that circumstance. I kept replaying the conversation between Rick and my wife. *You’re a good looking woman... We both know you like it... So jealous of that man...* But what really stuck with me was the way Annie had looked after he was gone. Her wistful, happy, guilty look. It was uncomfortable and troubling and sexy all at once.

For the first time in a long, *long* time, I thought of Annie not just as my wife, but as a *woman*. An attractive, sexy woman. Who others found attractive and sexy. But no, that’s not quite right. It wasn’t just how she looked, or how others looked at her. Annie, perfect, mature-to-a-fault Annie, was having inappropriate thoughts. Sexual thoughts. About some guy named Rick.

That realization, along with having something as concrete as a name and a voice attached to it, changed everything, if ever so slightly.

When she came back, for example, and I noticed she was lost in thought, I wondered what she was thinking, and if it had to do with all the compliments this Rick had given her. Or the way he'd flirted. Or how she'd flirted and giggled back.

Seeing I was still awake for the first time, she blinked at me. "You're still awake."

I tapped the computer in my lap, like that gave them more legitimacy. "Still going over this speech."

"You'll do wonderfully, honey." She glided to the dresser, where she'd unpacked her clothing for this trip.

"I know, but you know how I get before a big speaking thing."

I was distracted as she pulled her knit top off, then wiggled out of her yoga pants. I'd seen her do this countless times before. She wasn't moving provocatively. She wasn't "stripping" in the exotic sense, but with my newly opened eyes, I certainly saw it that way. I tried to find the thread of what I was saying as she pulled her tank top off, leaving her naked but for her little, satin panties.

I said, "I never feel prepared."

She pulled her pajama top from the drawer and I caught a glimpse of her pendulous breasts swing before she pulled it on.

"You're the most prepared man I know," she said, beginning to button the top up.

"Leave it." I spoke before I could think the repercussions through.

"What's that?"

"The shirt. Leave it unbuttoned." Heat rose along my neck. I fought it back. Forced a smile. "It's just coming off again when you get in here."

A smile formed on Annie's lips. "Twice in one night."

"Blame Paris." Blame Rick?

When Annie turned to me, she *sauntered* to the bed—and that was definitely, deliberately sexy. Unlike the Annie I knew—or at least the one that had calcified in my head after all these years. Was this the one Rick thought he knew? Was this the side of herself she hinted at another man? The side that giggled and flirted.

Besides, we both know you like it.

Or had something more happened between them? It should have killed the mood. Instead, even the suggestion that my wife was unfaithful shot through me like a kick of adrenaline. When I refocused on her, on that moment, and saw her slowly unbuttoned what few buttons she'd done, saw the shadow of her deep cleavage where the pajama top parted, I lost the thread of even that thought. I just wanted her, like I'd wanted her in the shower. Only stronger.

"The way you're looking at me..." Annie said. Color had formed in her pale cheeks.

"You're beautiful."

"Thanks." She pulled open her top, baring her bounteous breasts. The shirt fluttered to the ground behind her as she crawled into bed.

When our lips met, she was on fire. We both were. I pulled her against me, turning onto her side, my hands exploring her soft body. She gasped as she felt my erection, felt how hard it was, but didn't say anything.

I pushed my hand into her panties, once again reminded that she'd waxed there, that she'd left nothing but a slash of hair above her wet pussy. And her pussy was so wet, drenched and warm and blossoming. I easily pushed two fingers into her, drawing a moan. She arched in my arms as I shifted my lips to the side of her neck.

The waxing and her excitement took on a new meaning in light of what I'd heard. Was she thinking of this Rick guy now? Had he gotten her excited? Surely she didn't get this wet just crossing the room to me.

That spurred me on. I pulled her panties off as she clawed at my boxers. With Annie on her back, I sank into her with a mutual sigh. Lacing my fingers through hers, I held her hands to either side of her head, pinning her to the bed, as I began to fuck her. It was a move I could have easily done in my twenties—maybe even thirties. As a forty-five-year-old, my muscles screamed almost immediately, but all I needed to do was think of Annie flirting with this Rick and it was easy to suffer through.

Annie moaned, her eyes closed, her red hair stuck to her forehead and cheeks. Our stay in Paris had mostly been sunny, and as a consequence, Annie's freckles had spread, dappling her forehead. It should have been an innocent thing, but with her hair damp with sex, caked against the freckled skin, the innocence was dirtied up. Like the very image of my wife.

As I fucked her, I thought about those two. About *Rick*, a man's man, thick shouldered and young. I imagined the two of them here, in Paris,

instead of me. On a story, maybe, sharing a room, sharing a bed. I gripped Annie's hands tighter, fucking her harder. I didn't usually do this, didn't dominate her like this, didn't think she liked it. But I swear, she moaned and gasped louder, her hips rising to meet mine.

"Oh, Trav," she hissed. "You feel so good."

"I'm close," I managed.

"Me too."

I drew from my reserves. My arms and abs screamed at me for doing this, for maintaining this position. My heart beat like I was having a cardiac arrest.

"Come, baby," she said. Something she just didn't say. "Come inside me."

She'd *never* said that.

Sinking deep, all the way to the hilt, and I exploded. Annie squeezed her hands into mine, moaning loud enough that I would have felt self-conscious if I wasn't so out of my mind. Stiffening, she joined me, her pussy rippling around my still-pulsing cock.

We collapsed into one another, a sweaty heap of panting flesh.

"I think..." Annie managed, catching her breath. "...that we need to move to Paris."

Now that the orgasm had slaked my insane fantasy of its energy, I was left confused. I held her close, pulling the sheets over us as our skin cooled and sleep took us, wondering why it turned me on as much as it did—this idea of Annie being indiscreet with another man.

Sleep took me before I could fully wrap my head around it.

Chapter 3

Nothing is truly an epiphany. Everything is a journey of realization, an idea working its way slowly, insidiously, through our subconscious until one day it bubbles to the surface.

The journey of this insidious fantasy didn't begin in Paris, although it took me a long time to connect the dots. If I had to pinpoint a starting point, I'd say it was in that year after I graduated. Annie still had a year left and I already had a job lined up a few hundred miles away, so we spent the better part of that year apart.

We didn't really split up. We both really cared about each other, the L word had been dropped by both of us, and when I thought of the future, Annie had become a part of it. But distance is also hard, and I'll admit that, at least back then, I was a pretty jealous guy, trying to reconcile someone as beautiful and smart and amazing as Annie was so far away from me. She was a catch, and for a good part of a year, there were plenty around looking to fish.

Back then, we didn't have cell phones. FaceTime and Skype didn't exist, and long-distance calls were charged by the minute. We wrote a lot of emails—long emails—and even exchanged letters through the post. But contact was minimal, and as the months went on, I couldn't help but wonder if Annie was able to fend off all her would-be suitors.

Then a friend of mine came to visit, Shawn Dougherty, who added a whole lot to my suspicion.

"How've you been, man? How's school!" We were out drinking, catching up on old times. Shawn was also finishing up his grad program, same class as Annie, but where she spent all her free time researching, Shawn goofed off as much as he could get away with.

"You know," he said with a shrug. "Happy to get the fuck done with school and all that. Can't wait to get into the real world."

I chuckled. "Don't be so eager." Shawn was in for a rude awakening. It was hard to see him working a nine-to-five.

"It's just getting boring at school. I've seen the same faces for the last three years of grad school, man. It's like one, big incestuous family."

That tweaked a jealous chord in me. I ignored it. "I miss it, though. I miss Annie."

"I'd miss Annie, too," Shawn said with a chuckle. He'd always been pretty open with me about his thoughts on her. And then, because he was drunk and he was Shawn, he added, "You should watch out for Brian, by the way."

"Brian Hoffman?" He was one of the associate professors in the psyche program, young and begrudgingly handsome.

"Only Brian I know."

"And why should I watch out for him?"

Shawn shrugged. "You know Annie's been T.A.ing for his classes, right?"

I did, and it was one of the many sources of paranoia for me. "What are you saying, Shawn? Spit it out."

"Nothing to spit out, really. Just that they've been spending a lot of time together's all. I've seen them down at the Cask." The campus pub.

"She wouldn't do that," I said, wishing I felt as confident as I hoped I sounded. "And he wouldn't, either. She works for him. It's unethical."

"Wouldn't be the first time Brian's fucked one of his T.A.s. Rumor has it that he actually picks the hottest ones with that in mind."

"You're an asshole."

"Hey, you should feel complimented. He picked your Annie!"

And that was that.

But not really.

It ate away at me. Brian Hoffman and Annie, having a drink at the Cask. Laughing together. Sharing moments. Getting close. Falling into bed with one another after a long day of grading papers and meeting with undergrads, fucking into the early morning then falling fast asleep in one another's arms.

My insecurity consumed me. I didn't deal with it well. There was a span of about two months when I figured my relationship with Annie was over. I wrote Shawn almost as much as I wrote Annie during that time, getting him to spy on her for me. Or not really spy, but just keep an eye on her and Brian.

Not that Shawn was any help. Annie was Brian's T.A., so of course they were together a bunch. But they also weren't walking around as a couple, either. They didn't hold hands in public. They didn't go on dates. I

lived in this perpetual state of uncertainty. I trusted Annie, but I didn't. She was this good, wholesome, smart woman who'd one day be my wife, and she was a sexy, young woman sowing her wild oats at last.

I never confronted her about it. Never brought Brian Hoffman up. Not then, not after. Not once in our nineteen years of marriage. The incident just kind of faded away over time, becoming just another hazy memory that made up who we were as a couple until one day, I overheard her talking to another man, Rick, and it all came back, along with the realization that not only are other men attracted to my wife, but she's not blind to their attention, either.

Listening to Annie and Rick flirting kickstarted that old part of me I'd hoped I'd buried—that queasy, lightheaded feeling of being a little off, of having slept too long, or not enough. It was Annie and Brian all over again, but different this time in a fundamental way. It wasn't just jealousy. I was excited—as excited as I was jealous. Impossibly, the two feelings were lashed together, like I couldn't feel one without the other. I knew it was paranoid, but I couldn't help myself. We returned home, and things seemingly went back to normal, but for me it didn't.

I viewed everyday things through the lens of my obsession. Annie seemed to be running more, dressing younger. She spent more time riding Ruby, and taking yoga classes. It sculpted her butt into a work of art. To me, Annie had started doing these things because she wanted to impress Rick, because she craved his attention, but was that true? Was she behaving any differently? Or did I see ulterior motives because I wanted to?

Chapter 4

On the first day of work after Paris, I watched Annie get ready for work, that question spinning through my head. Messing everything up. She put on makeup and blew out her auburn locks, but that was normal. Right? The clothes she picked weren't unusual, either—a gray pencil skirt and a black, sleeveless blouse that she'd owned for years, and a modest pair of heels.

But still, the doubt that had insinuated itself into what was normal was there, thickening my blood, quickening my pulse.

"What?" she asked, catching me looking as she fastened on her earrings.

"Nothing," I said, feeling guilty. "You...I like your earrings."

She held up the one not hanging on her ear. It wasn't particularly special—a small, red stone that hung on a silver chain—but I didn't recognize them, and that made them sexy.

"Thanks. I picked them up in Paris, actually. At a little market."

"Pretty." I didn't normally talk about Annie's jewelry and knew how suspicious this seemed, so I quickly changed the subject. "So do you think your story will run this week?"

She lit up at the mention of her work. "It's looking that way. Rick says it'll probably run front page. It's not the Washington Post or anything, but still pretty cool."

My heart skipped at the mention of a Rick, but as much as I wanted to bite on it, I resisted. "Are you kidding me? This is better than front page of the Post. That runs every day. This is once a week." That was about as long as I could actually resist. "Who's Rick?"

I did everything I could not to sound accusatory. Or weird. Or suspicious. Even still, my voice rose, nearly cracking like a prepubescent boy's. Which was kind of how I felt.

"The new editor at the Herald. He's been working with me on this story. Really talented guy."

She didn't sound moony. She didn't bat her eyelashes and sigh. If anything, she sounded more mature about the whole thing than I had. Except that her last words kept reverberating in my head, all day after that. *Really talented guy. Really talented guy.*

Really talented guy.

The phrase took on sexual undertones. I imagined Rick fucking her, filling her with his “talent” as she moaned and cried out, “*You’re such a talented guy!*”

I looked him up. Found him on LinkedIn. He was every bit the nightmare that I’d imagined. While he didn’t have blond hair and blue eyes, he was handsome. His profile photo looked like a male model’s—defined jawline, thick, dark hair, deep, brown eyes. He was clean cut in the photo, but looked like the kind of guy who could effortlessly grow some scruff to look extra fuckable.

Until Paris, I didn’t think Annie had a “type.” Rick here—Rick Archer—was *every* woman’s type. And Annie liked him. Even if I hadn’t overheard their exchange, or saw the quiet way she’d sat after their conversation, I knew. *Really talented guy.* Annie didn’t give out compliments lightly. You had to earn them.

When Annie texted me, telling me that she was running late, that she had to make some last minute revisions to her story before the print deadline, my paranoia hit a new high.

It wasn’t unusual. The International Herald put their weekly publication together on Tuesdays, everyone coming together to work out the last kinks of their stories before going to press and online publication. Annie had worked a late Tuesday before since taking this contract, but this time, her announcement made my guts feel watery.

I spent the night, alone in our home, pacing and restless. And hard. What the fuck was wrong with me? I still don’t completely get it, even now.

It was during that fretful wandering through our house that I thought of Annie’s diaries. Ever since I’d known her, Annie kept a diary, writing in it sporadically. I used to tease her about it, but after awhile, it just became one of the many quirky things about her. She even passed the habit down to our daughter, a remarkable feat in an age of Facebook and Twitter.

“Some things I don’t want to say to anyone but myself, but it helps to get them out,” she’d explained, years ago. As I paced through the house, I recalled that explanation like a lightning bolt.

I’d been curious over the years about what she wrote. Who wouldn’t be? She’d shared a few passages, and they were pretty mundane, in a personal way—drama at work, before the kids; anxiety of leaving the workforce, during the kids; the stress that came with raising them. It was a

good outlet for her. It was also a good indicator to me, too—she wrote more frequently when she was going through something big.

I hadn't actually seen her write in a diary in a long time, but maybe I just hadn't been paying attention? Or maybe she was keeping the writing from me?

My wandering took me to Annie's study, where she spent the time not in the office going through her notes and assignments. Her laptop was gone, of course, but most of her notes were stacked neatly on her desk, meticulously organized.

I didn't go in there often, and felt like an intruder as I did. It smelled like Annie rather than our house—her lavender shampoo, the freshness of the plants and flowers by the window, and the smell of the books that lined her bookshelf. She'd put a plush, light blue rug down, soft beneath my toes, and reminiscent of my wife.

Walking across that rug without her there felt wrong. I almost left. I didn't. I was driven by a curiosity that had taken on a life of its own.

It was so quiet. I remember that. Remember being able to hear my heart echo in my ears as I crossed across that plush rug to her closet. I opened the doors to the smell of paper and mothballs. We used this closet for overflow—mostly Annie's—and her suits hung neatly. I only spared them a moment's glance, though. On the shelf above is where she kept her diaries.

They occupied nearly the whole shelf, mixed diary brands and types over the years. We used to give them to her as stocking stuffers at Christmas, or pick them up in exotic locations when we used to travel more. I thought of Paris, and the missed opportunity there. Ten years ago, I would have grabbed a little, hand-crafted leather journal from the market to surprise her at her birthday.

She'd organized them chronologically, of course, and marked each cover with the start and end dates that the diary covered. The ones with shorter date ranges marked the more eventful times in our lives—when we'd started dating, when we'd gotten married, children. It thinned out between those, and had been very thin until...until a few months ago.

The last diary was blue faux leather and closed with a little, golden lock. I pulled it down and ran my fingers across the lock. I shivered. None of her other diaries had locks on them.

Checking the date, it began about three months ago, give or take a few days, and covered about two months of time. I wondered where her active diary was, but even more than that, I wondered what I'd find written in it.

I shut the doors to the closet shakily and turned to her desk. It was in there. Had to be. I crept back to the drawer and sank into her swivel chair. I knew I was being intrusive. I knew that I didn't *really* have any reason to look, or worry. So I thought at the time, anyway. That's why I hesitated. That's why, when I heard the sound of the door opening and closing downstairs, I snapped out of it, sneaking out of her office and shutting off the lights. I tip-toed back into our bedroom, my ears burning with guilt, just as Annie came up the stairs.

"You're home," I said cheerily. I had no idea what time it was, so couldn't even make the "you're early" or "you're late" comment.

Annie did it for me. "Sorry it got so late. I'm surprised you're still up."

"Oh, you know, have a lot on my mind."

Annie nodded, buying this as she passed by me. She gave me a friendly kiss on the lips on her way to the bedroom. I grabbed her before she could go, pulling her in for a deeper kiss. Her brows went up in surprise, but she went with it, our tongues meeting and playing. I wanted to taste something suspicious there—booze, toothpaste...another man's come—but she just tasted like Annie.

Still, as we got into it, Annie turned to me, wrapping her arms around me to kiss me back with equal passion. What started as a test led to us fumbling with each other's clothes on the way to the bed.

Here again, I went on a discovery mission as I kissed down her body, disappearing beneath the sheets. She didn't stop my journey, didn't pull me back up to her. Still, I held out hope—and fear—that I might find something amiss—the salt of another man or the latex scent of his condom. Again, she only tasted like Annie, although she was drenched. Even her panties were soaked, and I as danced my tongue across her pussy—still impeccably smooth from her waxing—I couldn't help myself from fantasizing about why.

I imagined Rick getting her some place private—a private meeting room at their shared space. At the late hour, most people would have left. They'd lock the door, their lips would meet, their hands would wander. He'd push her over a table, hike her skirt up, and pull her panties off.

"Ohhh, Trav..." Annie moaned.

The fantasy raged, unshaken by my name. I thought about how Rick would bury his fingers into her, doing it for her, acting as his proxy. Her moans grew louder, lost their meaning as she raced to her explosive end. Was she thinking the same thing that I was? Was she imagining Rick doing this to her? Eating her? Marveling that the proper, conservative psychology columnist had such naughty and pent up desires?

For a moment, I thought she might scream as she came. Her hands dug into my scalp as she climaxed, but she caught herself before completely losing it. She restrained herself. At the last second, she seemed to remember who she was—or at least who she was *with me*. Would it be different with Rick?

I climbed out from under the sweltering sheets, hesitant to kiss her with her excitement smeared all over my cheeks and chin. I rubbed my face on the pillow beside her as she aimed my cock at her pussy. It was a practiced move, a familiar one, but for a second, I wondered what it would be like to close my lips over hers and force her to taste herself. Would it thrill her? Disgust her?

Would it be different if Rick did it?

I nearly came, just like that. Not even three strokes in. Somehow, I didn't, although I knew I wouldn't last very long. She was just so wet, so ready. I knew it was all in my head, but in the jumbled heat of the moment, my head was whispering that maybe something *had* happened. Maybe not sex. Maybe nothing more than flirting, but she'd been working late with a man who clearly had the hots for her. Who she, maybe, just maybe, had a crush on.

With my face buried in the pillow beside her, surrounded by the smell of her hair and the soft touch of her fingers along the back of my neck, I came. I couldn't hold out any longer. She felt too good beneath me, and those illicit thoughts were just too tempting.

I'm pretty sure Annie faked her second orgasm to coincide with me. She did that on occasion, and I always pretended that they were real, even though deep down I knew she was just doing it so I wouldn't feel bad. She moaned. It sounded good. But it lacked the intensity that her real orgasms did.

Not that it mattered here. Mine was real and intense and draining. She held me long after it subsided, stroking my hair as I caught my breath and my heart returned to normal levels.

That was unexpected. We both were thinking it. I could almost hear her asking it in our silence. We'd been together for too long for silence to be truly empty. But neither of us gave voice to it, both content to let it linger and fade as sleep took us.

The psychologist in me thought about how perfect a microcosm this was for our own marriage. The husband in me just let it lie.

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Chapter 5

I didn't look at the diaries. Not at first, anyway. In the light of the next morning, I realized just how much of an invasion of privacy that was. We'd been together for years—decades now, plural—and I'd never gone there. I couldn't do it just to satisfy my fantasy-driven bout of insane curiosity. So I told myself.

Rick wasn't the first guy to flirt with my wife. He wouldn't be the last. It was most likely why I'd cultivated the fantasy that I had.

I dealt with it. I stayed out of her diary, out of her personal space. I convinced myself that it was all in my head. It was fine. Exciting, even.

We had great sex. Annie looked better and better with each passing week, and it wasn't just that she was working out more. It was her confidence. The way she carried herself.

That became crystal clear about a month after Paris. So did the attraction between Rick and her.

*

Annie's work on the immigration and sanctuary city story earned her an award from the local chapter of the American Institute of Online Journalists, who were throwing a small reception to hand them out—ironic due to the nature of the award.

Annie downplayed the whole thing, telling me that we didn't even have to go. That they could just mail it to her. The Herald's editor-in-chief, Bruce Barry, thought differently though, playing up the award on their site and insisting we all go.

I looked to the date with trepidation, all of it centered around one man—Rick Archer. He'd most likely be at this thing, especially since he was the editor on the story that received the award. He was also a member of the Herald's small staff, and if Bruce was insisting we go, he was also probably insisting that the rest of the staff attend.

We'd invited Annie's younger sister, Lisa, along, who was always down for free drinks and an excuse to celebrate something. I looked forward to seeing Lisa. She was fun, the wilder of the two sisters, and also gorgeous. Annie teased me about my crush on her—something I

vehemently denied—but I couldn't help it. Not only did she have this electric personality, putting out a vibe that she'd be down for anything, but she also looked like a filthy version of my wife. Her hair was honey blond, rather than rich copper, but they had the same expressive blue eyes and nearly identical spray of summer freckles. On Lisa, though, they looked decidedly naughtier. Lisa was more curvy than Annie, too, like her body was built for sex.

She knew it, too, and didn't shy from the attention. The evening of the reception, for example, she dressed for action, slipping into a slinky LBD that put her full and freckled tits on display. The spaghetti straps of the dress strained, ready to pop.

"Jesus, Lise, I think you may have purchased a size too small," Annie commented as we met up with her outside the reception hall.

Lisa took the opportunity to adjust her dress, effectively drawing my eyes back down into that healthy cleavage. "Aw, thanks, Annie. You look great, too." She winked at me, like I was in on some private joke that I didn't understand.

Annie actually did look great. While her black dress wasn't as short or as low cut as Lisa's, it was sexy in an elegant way. It was floor length, for one, and while it hugged her curves and showcased a hint of her own impressive cleavage, it merely hung off her shoulders and covered her arms.

These two had an interesting relationship. They loved each other, supported one another, did things like go to award ceremonies for each other, but I'd never met a pair more competitive. It was better now that they were older, but Annie still told me stories about how Lisa had stolen a few of her boyfriends, or how angry Lisa had been when she finished high school with a GPA of just a tenth under what Annie had graduated with.

Lisa had gotten married in her twenties, beating Annie by a year, despite being three years younger, but that had fallen apart quickly. She didn't remarry after that, choosing to become the cool aunt instead of being tied down, and I got the impression that even now she lived a pretty free-wheeling lifestyle.

"This is fancy, Sis," Lisa said, nudging Annie as we entered the reception hall. It was, indeed, fancier than I'd expected. I'd thrown on a black suit and tie, but now I wondered if I should have dusted off the tuxedo. I wouldn't have been the only one.

“Yeah,” Annie said, also surprised at the opulence of the hall. “Not exactly what I expected.”

“So this is, like, a big deal,” Lisa said.

“Looks like it.”

Now that we were in there, I stopped thinking about Lisa and Annie’s rivalry and started hunting for Rick. It didn’t take long for me to spot him across the room, talking to the small contingent from the Herald.

He was tall. Taller than I’d expected, maybe a head taller than my six feet. He was as clean cut as his Facebook page, his dark hair cut and styled into something reminiscent of a Wall Street exec. Also, he wore a tuxedo, making me further question my decision not to.

As we approached, I heard Lisa whisper, “Who’s the tall, dark, and handsome guy?”

“Shh,” Annie whispered back. “That’s Rick. He’s kind of my boss.”

“Lucky you.”

“You are impossible, you know that?”

Bruce was the first to greet us at our arrival. “The woman of the hour has finally arrived!”

An embarrassed Annie made quick introductions. She introduced Rick last, and he happily stepped forward, holding out his hand to me. “Rick Archer. I’ve been working with Annie on the immigration and sanctuary city stories she’s been doing. Amazing stuff.”

“She’s pretty talented,” I agreed, smiling at Annie. When I looked at her, she was blushing, and trying to hide it.

“Yeah, we’re lucky to have her.” I saw something pass between them. A look. A glance. A secret smile. It was like sand being kicked up along the bottom of the ocean.

We mingled, sticking together for the most part, although Bruce Barry took the opportunity to network with some of the other bigwigs in attendance. Rick seemed focused on Lisa in particular, and while she hid it well, I could tell how that attention rankled Annie.

“Looks like your sister’s making a new friend.”

“Hm?” she said, like she had no idea what I was talking about. “Oh, yes, look at that. Think I should warn Rick about her?”

“Warn him? I thought he was single.”

“He is.”

“Then don’t cock-block him, honey.”

“I’m not. I just... he’s kind of my boss. And she’s my sister. I don’t want him to...you know—”

“You don’t want him to have sex with your sister.”

I couldn’t help but chuckle at how flustered that got her. She was being so obvious, but also completely unaware that she was. She decided to change tactics. “He’s, like, five years younger than her.”

“I don’t really think that your sister’s age is going to bother him.”

Annie rolled her eyes at me, was about to say something else when she seemed to realize how jealous she sounded. “Forgot she had you under her spell, too.”

I tried to laugh it off, but I’d touched a nerve and knew that it was time to back off. “So when do you get the award?”

That happened about a half hour later. There were some presentations and speeches, a membership call for those who hadn’t joined already, and then the awards were handed out. It was amazing, watching Annie stroll up there, dressed in her evening gown, to accept it. With her red hair up in a twist and the cameras flashing, she looked like a dream. And she was my wife. I glanced at Rick, who was just as enraptured, and reminded myself never to take her for granted again.

After the reception, the plan was for Lisa, Annie, and I to grab a drink in celebration. Lisa decided to throw a little wrench into that plan when she approached us with Rick at her side. “I invited your boss along, Sis. Hope you’re cool with that.”

“Of course,” she said, although she definitely wasn’t actually cool with it.

I heard the truth in her voice, which meant Lisa probably did too, but she ignored it. She stepped closer to Rick, slid her arm into his, and said, “Great, let’s get out of here!”

We went to a bar downtown, finding a table where we could talk. If Rick was uncomfortable with the sibling dynamic, he didn’t show it.

“So what’s next for the award-winning duo?” Lisa asked.

“Still working that out.” Annie glanced at Rick. They’d talked about this already.

Lisa picked up on it. “What?”

“Your sister has this amazing ability to connect with people. It’s like she’s a Jedi or something.”

Lisa laughed. "I'm pretty sure that's what a psychology degree is, right, Trav?"

"I never did get my lightsaber." Banter was easy for me, especially when I'd been drinking, but I was far more interested in what Rick had in mind.

"I've been trying to convince Annie to actually visit some of the families we've talked to. To get their stories face-to-face."

"Rick's just angling to take an all-expenses paid trip to San Francisco," Annie said.

"I was actually thinking LA, but San Fran would do, too."

"Definitely go with LA," Lisa commented. "A lot more fun there, in my opinion."

"Which is so not why we're going, Lise," Annie said.

"So you're going?"

"I knew you were game," Rick said.

"No, I didn't..." She shot an acidic look at Lisa, who merely shrugged. "I'm still thinking about it."

I felt like I was in a tailspin. Mayday, mayday, we're going in for a crash landing.

"Stop thinking and just do it. That's your problem, Sis, you overthink things. You're hot shit. You know that. You just won a little plaque that literally proves it—"

"Not literally," Rick interjected.

Lisa rolled her eyes and laughed. "Forgot I was in the presence of a bunch of grammar nerds. You know what I mean, though. You guys kick ass together. Keep kicking ass."

My stomach fluttered. I implied innuendo where there was none, and started getting hard anyway.

"Your sister is a very smart woman," Rick said to Annie.

"Aw, that's so kind of you. Pretty, too, right?"

Rick laughed at her brazenness. "You don't need me to tell you that."

Lisa batted her lashes. "But I like hearing it."

Annie rolled her eyes at me. I was still in too much shock to give her any kind of reassurance. My wife may be taking a trip with this man? Without me?

"Your parents' handed down some really good genes," he said.

"So did yours," Lisa said.

“You’re not coming onto me, are you?” Rick asked.

“Oh, no. I’m not that subtle.”

“Lise? Leave him alone,” Annie said.

“He’s a big boy. I think he’ll be fine.” She locked eyes with Rick.

“You’ll be fine, right?”

“Depends on what we’re doing?”

Lisa leaned forward and whispered into his ear. Rick’s face lit up.

“You’re right, you’re definitely not subtle.”

“So want to walk me home?”

Rick pulled his wallet out and slapped a twenty on the bar. “I’d be honored to, ma’am.”

Lisa snorted. “Call me ‘ma’am’ again and I take back what I just said.” She stood. “See you around, Annie. Good seeing you, Trav. Next time, you can finally tell me all about your Paris trip.”

“Talk to you later, Annie,” Rick said. He didn’t even look marginally ashamed of what he was about to do. “Nice meeting you, Travis. Have a good one.”

“You, too.” I couldn’t help myself.

“Oh, I will.”

Alone, Annie and I sat there in stunned silence for about two seconds. Then, Annie turned to me and said, “Proud of me?”

“Hm?”

“For not cock-blocking my boss.”

I laughed. “Good job.”

“If I get fired because of this, though, I know exactly who to blame.”

“Then let’s hope Lisa shows him a good time.”

Annie rolled her eyes, but even she couldn’t be completely upset. “I’m pretty sure she’s good on that front.”

We left shortly after that. Now that the energy of our two younger companions had left, we suddenly felt tired. Or at least I did. It was late, I’d been drinking, and I was not in my twenties—or even thirties—any more.

When we did get home, though, Annie must have had a second wind, because she practically attacked me. I wasn’t about to complain. Seeing her in her dress all evening had me worked up. I didn’t last long, though, and when she was done riding me, I quickly passed out.

Chapter 6

I finally broke down and read her diary the day after the award ceremony—a little over a month since Paris. I didn't go seeking it out. The opportunity just presented itself. We had a slow start to the morning—a Saturday. Or, I did, anyway. I slept in, one of the many perks of living in an empty nest now. I didn't bother getting dressed for the day. By the time I came downstairs for some coffee, Annie had already had hers and was dressed.

"Welcome to the world of the living, sleepy head," she greeted.

She was dressed for horse-riding—tight, off-white breeches, tall, riding boots, a dark blouse, her copper hair pulled back into a tight bun. It was sexy as hell, and one of the many reasons I encouraged her to keep up the sport. Riding also did amazing things to her ass and legs, both of which were on full display in those riding pants.

"I didn't think you had a riding session today."

"I didn't, but I need to burn off some of last night's rich food. I'll be back in a few hours."

"Have fun."

"Will do. Love you."

Alone, I wandered the house with my coffee, intending to get dressed and start my day. I happened to look into Annie's study on the way up to our bedroom when I saw it sitting there—her diary. Her *current* diary. It matched the last finished one—blue, faux leather with a golden lock to keep it shut. Only this one wasn't locked shut.

My heart started going even before I took a step into the room. I shouldn't do this. I wasn't going to. So I told myself. I was just going to check to see if it really was locked, that was all. Because it probably was—

It wasn't. The latch lay open. I touched the faux blue leather of the cover, running my fingers across it, half-expecting to feel it electrocute me or something. A ribbon ran from the spine into the heart of the journal, where she must have left off. Tempting me.

I went to the window that looked out over our yard. Annie's little SUV was gone. I was alone. I took a deep breath, held it until I was dizzy. Nothing's in there, I told myself. Nothing was going on between Annie and

Rick. They were just coworkers. Everything was professional. If it wasn't, he never would have taken Annie's sister to bed.

Or maybe he just did that to get Annie jealous, this dark voice inside of me whispered.

But she wouldn't be.

But maybe she was? And the answer is in that diary right fucking there, man.

I sat down. Just to check. Just to see if she even wrote about last night. This could have been sitting here for days, for all I knew. It's not like I came in here very often.

I followed the ribbon, flipping the diary open to an entry close to the end of the book. Sure enough, it was dated this morning.

Sunday, September 7

Some things never change. Typical Lisa behavior. I don't know why I would ever expect anything else. She's 40 and she's exactly the same! It felt just like when Eddie Keeler came over to study Bio with me. I knew why he wanted to come over. Lisa knew why he wanted to come over. But it didn't stop her. Two..three weeks, I keep expecting him to ask me out—or at least try to kiss me—but nothing. I even stole one of Lisa's sluttier tops to push my boobs at him, but nothing. It all made sense when I saw Eddie & Lisa at the carnival together. I still can't believe I followed them.

Lisa gave me quite the education that night. Letting a boy get to 2nd base was a big deal to me, but there was Lisa, two years younger than me, going down on Eddie in a dark corner of the parking lot! I was so angry I wanted to run over there and yank her away by her hair, but I was too fascinated by watching them. And too confused. Anger wasn't the only emotion rushing through me that night. It was right around then I discovered the joys of self pleasure.

Seeing Lisa flirt with Rick last night took me right back to that night at the carnival. I know that's crazy. We're friendly, but I work for Rick. He's not my boyfriend. Eddie wasn't

either, but I wanted him to be. I don't want Rick to be my boyfriend. Do I? No! I'm married! Married women don't have boyfriends. Well, some do, but I'm not one of them, no matter how tempting it may be.

Rick. Thinking about him makes me feel things I know I shouldn't. I've been good (mostly) so far, but he doesn't make it easy. Lord, does he make it hard! Rick just being Rick would be enough for most women. I know it would be enough for me if I was single, and it was certainly enough for Lisa (bitch!). You just don't see a lot of guys walking around who look like him. Rick belongs in a cologne ad in GQ, minus his shirt. No, do not think of him with his shirt off! Travis is sleeping upstairs and I don't have time to jump in the shower to take care of things. Anyway, just working with Rick everyday is enough to tempt even the most pious nun, or at least launch an armada of fantasies. But Rick makes it infinitely hard to be good.

I still don't understand it. I'm not an old hag, but Rick is almost 10 years younger, and it's obvious he could have his pick of the sexy young things in the office. Don't know why he's so focused on me. Stared into the mirror this morning after my shower and still didn't see it. Maybe one day I'll ask him. I should be grateful (?) but it just makes everything so complicated. If only he'd really taken "I'm married" for an answer (said he understood, but no) in the beginning I wouldn't be feeling like this. I'd have my fantasies, but I wouldn't have real feelings to deal with (jealousy, desire, guilt).

Maybe Lisa has solved all that for me. Maybe Rick got tired of all the push-pull & yes-no and decided if I wasn't going to say yes my sister was the next best thing. Everyone has always said we look alike. I know Travis thinks so. Sometimes I suspect he might even think she's hotter, the way he stares at her tits. He thinks I don't know. Ha! But Rick got

that prize, I'm sure of it. Maybe Trav is as disappointed as I am? He shouldn't be after how last night ended! But then maybe I'm the consolation prize? Am I a terrible person? I ripped off Travis's clothes, but it was all Rick in my head as I rode him. Even a second of Eddie & Lisa, except Eddie turned into Rick. The wave of guilt afterward told me I'm terrible, but I'm starting to get used to that. Rick is very good at giving me reasons to feel guilty.

Can't navel-gaze any longer. Have to get the day started. The Rick-Lisa (bitch!) thing is going to work out one way or the other, no matter how much I torture myself over it. Just wish my position was clear. We'll see on Monday!

I sat wide-eyed and unmoving, long after I finished the passage. Until that moment, sitting there with my heart trying to hammer free from my chest and my guts roiling, I could have written the whole Rick thing off as something in my head. A fun, dangerously sexy—yet still safe—thing in my head, but made up. I could always fall back on that kind of rational doubt.

I could no longer do that. I could no longer see things and pretend I was just seeing what I wanted.

Married women don't have boyfriends. Well, some do, but I'm not one of them, no matter how tempting it may be...

I've been good (mostly) so far...

My thoughts bubbled up through something thick. I felt slow to react. Slow to process it all. What did “mostly” mean? Mostly good? I turned back to the entry, searching her words for some clue. Rick came onto her, that was clear. Focused on her, over all the other women. She mentioned a “push-pull, yes-no” thing between them. I got the “pull” part. I got the “no” part. But she'd said yes? To what?

I was so focused on cracking this mystery—and still so sluggish trying to do it—that I failed to hear her car door slam shut. I almost missed the *front door* opening and closing. If Annie had come upstairs and caught me reading her diary, maybe this story would have ended differently. Maybe that's what should have happened.

Instead, I leaped into quiet action, replacing the ribbon, shutting it quietly, and slipped out of the study. I just made it into our bedroom when Annie called from downstairs. “It’s raining out at the farm. Riding’s off.”

“I’m sorry, dear,” I said, hoping my voice didn’t sound like a preteen’s. “I’m going to jump in the shower.”

“Okay!”

I was already hard even before I peeled my clothes off and stepped under the spray. As I ran soap over my cock, I stiffened even more as bits and pieces of the diary assaulted me. She’d played with herself in this shower, thinking of Rick. I didn’t even know she played with herself at all! I mean, I figured she did, because she was human, but never really believed it. Somehow, it always felt like Annie was above that or something. Or if she fantasized—when she fantasized—she used me. Like last night, when I became her stand-in for Rick.

I began to stroke myself at the thought of that. How many other times had she thought of Rick when we were together? A lot, lately, I imagined. I hoped?

Rick is very good at giving me reasons to feel guilty.

What had happened?! I almost left the shower, grabbed her diary, and started to page through it like a researcher. The answers were probably there. She didn’t hold back. Clearly she didn’t even consider anyone else reading those entries. It was catharsis for her, so if Rick had done something, had tried something, and she’d...gone with it—

The screech of the shower curtain ripped me out of my revelries, and right as I was about to explode against the wall.

“Trav! This isn’t what I was expecting,” Annie said, eyeing my soap-covered erection. She looked properly scandalized, which I thought was a little hypocritical of her, considering what I knew. I almost called her on it before I realized that I *shouldn’t* know.

“Um, sorry, I just—”

Annie recovered quickly. “You know, I can help you out with that, right?”

Shows how shocked I was that it didn’t register that she was naked. When I did, though, I saw her the way Rick would have seen her—all soft curves and pale skin, dusted in freckles, natural in a way that women in their twenties couldn’t be. Her beauty appeared effortless—only I knew how much effort went into it.

“I’ll take your silence as a yes,” Annie said, pleased with how my eyes ran over her naked body. She reached out and wrapped her hand around my cock.

She kissed me before I could find anything intelligent to say, and as her soft body pushed up against mine, Rick was there again, in my place, enfolding her in his arms and kissing her back.

Annie pulled back, long enough to look me in the eyes. I saw mischief there. “What?” I asked.

She seemed to take a deep, fortifying breath. “Just figuring out how best to help you out.” Her blue irises flashed. “I know...”

She dropped to her knees, swinging my cock out under the spray to wash the soap off. I could hardly believe this was happening. Blowjobs were rare enough, but I could count the number of blowjobs I’d received from her knees on one hand. Annie always told me she didn’t like how submissive she felt in that position, and how uncomfortable it made her. Now, though, she did it eagerly.

Still, as always, I gave her an out. “You don’t have to...”

Was that disappointment in her eyes? Why did I feel like I’d just said the wrong thing?

Annie dipped forward anyway, swallowing my cock into her warm mouth. I groaned, leaning back against the cool tiles of our shower as she began to blow me. I wanted to run my hands through her hair, but resisted. This moment felt delicate, like this side of my wife was a skittish cat, ready to bolt.

Was she thinking about Rick? Was she imagining doing this to him? Her eyes were closed. I’d read her diary. I knew she had last night. So—

“God, that feels good, baby,” I hissed. And then, taking a risk, I said, “Play with yourself. Touch yourself while you...do that.” I couldn’t even tell her to blow me. Or suck me. Or take my cock. We didn’t talk to each other like that. Even asking her to play with herself was a stretch.

But she did it. She nodded, still not releasing me, as her left hand snaked down between her thighs. Now she could really imagine her with Rick. Had I just given her permission?

Her moans came a moment later, quivering around my cock as she slashed and stroked it with her tongue. I wasn’t going to make it. I wasn’t going to last. Not with the diary still fresh. Not with all those revelations.

If only he’d taken “I’m married” for an answer.

An answer to what? What had Rick done to prompt Annie to remind him that she was married?

But the line that did me in was the one I kept circling back to, again and again. *I've been good (mostly). Mostly. Mostly—*

“Oh, Annie, I’m—” That’s all I managed. My balls tightened. My shaft rippled. The first blast of come caught her by surprised, filling her mouth before she had a chance to pull away. The second landed a rope across her high cheekbone, marring the innocent, refined beauty. The rest she aimed against the shower wall, her hand taking over where her mouth had done the stroking.

Until it got too much. Until I had nothing left and I was too sensitive, but hadn’t begun to soften yet.

Before I could speak, she straightened, smiled at me, and turned into the shower spray to rinse away the come. I stared at her, once again seeing her through another man’s eyes. Reaching out, I stroked her body, filling my hand with her bountiful breasts. Motherhood had been good to her in that department, and while I knew she thought they sagged too much, I loved their ripeness. To me, they hung perfect and mouth-watering and full.

I stepped up against her, pressing my body against hers. “You’re so sexy,” I whispered.

“You have to say that.”

“Maybe, but you know it’s true.” *I saw the way Rick looked at you*, I almost added before remembering myself. My hand drifted down her hips and across her ass. “Sorry that you couldn’t get out, horseback riding. The results are, uh, really showing.”

Annie laughed musically. “I’m sorry, too.” She turned to me, putting her hands around my neck. “But you can make it up to me if you want to.”

We kissed, but I knew what it was she wanted, and I wasn’t going to leave her unsatisfied either. I ran my hands down between her legs, finding her slick, even under the cascade of water. I pressed two fingers into her, forcing a moan from her.

I almost said, *You can go back to thinking about Rick*, as I dropped to my knees. The thought alone caused my cock to stir and my stomach to swim. I pressed her against the shower wall and lifted a leg over a shoulder. Her pussy was beautiful, the wide landing strip rising above her pussy lips.

I touched the band. It was only about the width of my index finger now, when a month ago, it was at least two. I couldn’t talk to her about Rick

or her diary, but I couldn't help myself here. "You've been taking care of yourself down here," I said.

I brushed my thumb across her clit, drawing a gasp. "You're partly to blame, you know." *Partly...* "Need to be ready, whenever."

Only maybe I'm not who you think of when you get ready?

"That's so hot." It was as much an observation as an answer to my own thought. "I love it."

I dipped forward, tracing my tongue along her smooth lips. Annie groaned, her fingers going into my hair, encouraging me. Thing was, she'd never done any kind of grooming in all the years that I'd known her. Not even when we were younger, although back then, this wasn't the trend. So why now?

I teased her, kissing away from her pussy and out along her thighs. I could feel her muscles beneath, hardened from hours of horseback riding and running. I doubted Lisa's legs looked this good, and I wondered if when Rick compared them, too.

"Oh, stop teasing," Annie sighed.

I shifted back to her pussy, pressing my fingers into her as I worked her clit. It was like touching a live wire. She tensed up, releasing a choked gasp. Looking up at her, she was lost in another world, her eyes closed, her head thrown back. She wasn't as quiet as normal, either, letting herself moan a little more, comforted, perhaps, by the hiss of the shower spray.

Those moans of hers were almost enough to get me back up again. She'd always been so quiet, even before the kids. This was new. This was exciting.

Her thing with Rick was exciting.

"Oh, Traaavis," she moaned, pumping her hips against me as she came. I pressed deep into her, curling my fingers, finding what I thought was her g-spot as I flickered my tongue across her clit, fast enough that my jaw began to ache. "Oh, yes, yes!"

Her cries, that exclamation, sent a jolt through me. It felt like she was letting go, letting her inner-self out. I wanted to fuck her, and miraculously, my cock rose to the challenge.

"I need you," I said, pulling back.

"Here? In the shower?"

"Pretend we're back in Paris."

Annie giggled, nodding.

It was awkward, especially since I wasn't as young as I once was. We tried a few things, but in the end, she bent over, facing away from me, while resting her foot on the soap dish and I entered her from behind. My legs burned from having to keep them bent, and we almost slipped and fell twice, but eventually, we found a rhythm. And it was dirty and fun and clean all at once.

"God, you feel huge," she said.

"I like this," I huffed. "Feels different."

"Mmm, yeah."

I reached between her legs, fingering her clit as I fucked her. "You like that?" I asked.

"Yes."

We didn't do this. Didn't talk. All of this felt like something new. "You're so sexy, baby. So hot."

Annie only moaned in reply.

"Let yourself go, honey. Come for me."

Her breathing grew heavier, quicker. She was closing in.

"That's it, honey. Come. Come on my... on my—"

She exploded before I could bring myself to say the word "cock." This time, it wasn't hushed or constrained. It was loud and deep and so fucking sexy.

"I need to stop," I said, pulling out of her. "I'm sorry, my legs are killing me."

"But you haven't... You're still hard."

"Let's finish showering and we can move this to someplace more comfortable."

Annie laughed. "Sounds good. You could soap my back."

I grabbed the bar of soap, lathering my hands. "I can soap more than just that," I said, collecting her tits in my hands and squeezing.

"Must make sure those are nice and clean."

I traced my hand down between her legs again. "I can think of a few other places to keep clean, too."

Annie sighed. "Feels like we're teenagers or something. You're frisky this morning."

"I can't help it. Not around you."

"Don't get me wrong, I'm not complaining," she said with a laugh. "But maybe let's stick to getting clean for now. I'm getting all pruney."

“Fine, fine.” I was, too. We got back to business, got all cleaned up, and made love in our bed, like the normal Annie and Travis Belmont that we were.

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Chapter 7

The weekend was like all other weekends before them. I mowed the grass. We ran errands. Grilled outside, now that the weather was nice. It was all good. All...normal.

Only beneath the surface, I felt like an alcoholic in need of another drink, yet ashamed to admit it. The details of the diary entry had already begun to fade, and all I wanted to do was go back in there to read. And I couldn't. I was stuck with my memories, with my impressions.

I should have felt some jealousy, and don't get me wrong, I did. But I should have been crippled by it. Instead, it got my heart racing every time I thought of it. Here was a guy, looking as good as he did, hitting on my wife. Not taking no for an answer. That was as flattering as it was messed up.

Annie met up with her sister for brunch Sunday morning, and I resisted the temptation to go back to the diary for about three minutes. Then I was back up in her study, looking for it.

This time wasn't so easy. First of all, I had to search for it—she'd tucked it away in the bottom drawer of her desk. Second off, it was locked, and as much as I looked, I couldn't find the key. I considered picking it with a paper clip before I wised up. Even if I was able to get it unlocked without breaking it—a big if—there was a high likelihood that I'd scratch the cheap, golden lock.

I took this as a sign that I really shouldn't be reading it. I slipped it back into place, made sure that everything was exactly where it was when I'd found it, and left.

Oh, I did memorize the brand of diary, though, and immediately went searching for it on Amazon. It was easy to find, and they were in stock. I debated whether to order one. I really did. Happening upon the journal was one thing, but this felt like a whole other transgression.

Then again, so was whatever was going on. Even if it was nothing.

But it wasn't. Something must have happened. Or, I thought breathlessly, something *will* happen.

So in the end, I ordered one, sent to my work address. Just to have the option. So I told myself.

"How's your sister?" I asked when Annie came back.

“Unbelievable. She’s going to get me fired.”

“Didn’t work out with...Rick?”

Annie snorted. “No. She came from his place this morning. Apparently they spent all day together. And all night.”

“Wow.” That was arousing.

“Yeah.” She just rolled her eyes. “I’m going to take a shower. Then you want to hit up the garden center?”

“Sure.”

I watched her go up the stairs, knowing that she wasn’t just going to be washing her body in there. I almost joined her. I probably should have, but I also liked the idea that she was so hotted up that she had to “take a shower” to take care of things.

We did make love that night, and her eyes were closed as we did, and she was as into the sex as ever. And just as ever, seeing Annie as she thought of another was hot.

*

“So you still have your job?” I asked Monday evening when I came home.

“Guess so,” Annie said. “Lisa didn’t come up.”

“Wild sex with a sibling isn’t something that comes up in your Slack channel often?”

Annie laughed. “You’d be surprised. But no, not today.”

“You working late tomorrow?” I asked, as casually as I could.

“Probably not. I’ve only got a little piece this week.”

“Ah.” And then, because that was not the proper way for a husband to respond to news like that, I added, “Great! I was thinking we could pick up some Lebanese.”

“Yummy.”

On Tuesday, I went over what I knew. The facts, even as they began to fade from memory. My wife worked with a very attractive younger man who was hitting on her, and since she’s Annie, she’s put him off so far. But still, she felt guilty, which suggested there was something to feel guilty about, even if she hasn’t given in to Rick. He was her guilty pleasure, her dirty, little secret.

Probably nothing would happen. This was Annie we were talking about, after all, not her sister. If this is what it took for her to feel sexy again—to realize just how sexy she really was—it was worth the risk. Or so I convinced myself. It's not like she was angry with me, or thought less of me. But I was who I was, the man who'd been at her side for over two decades. I was familiar, I was her day-to-day. Rick was new and exciting and illicit.

So I did nothing. I let it lie. When the package arrived with the diary I'd ordered—the one matching Annie's—I didn't even open it. I tucked it into my desk drawer at work and left it there, telling myself that I didn't need it.

That lasted all the way until 3 o'clock, when my phone buzzed with an arriving text.

[Annie]: Turns out I may be late here after all. Working on a new thing.

The buzz was back, something between nervousness and excitement. Something that set my stomach on edge and made my fingers shake. I would have left that very moment, package in hand, but I had to work late, too. Meetings and deadlines and stuff I could care less about as I thought about Annie working late with Rick and his dark, good-looks, and easy, flirty smile.

I didn't eat dinner. I didn't want to waste any time. I headed straight home, getting in close to 8. Annie wasn't back yet, so I wasted no time. I don't think I even turned on any lights. With the key to her diary in hand, I headed for her study.

Her diary was there, in the bottom drawer. I slipped the key into the lock, half-hoping that it wouldn't work. That it wouldn't unlatch. For a second, I thought that it wouldn't. It caught, I turned harder, and there came a click. I was in.

Flipping to the last page, I found that there was a new entry, dated Monday. Monday evening. Last night.

Monday, September 9

This thing with R is out of hand. SLUT! What the hell am I doing? Better start at the beginning if I am going to make

sense of this.

I've been having weird feelings around him (that I shouldn't have), but this was the first time I was nervous to see him. I wish Lisa wasn't so detail oriented. I was afraid that the second I saw R all I would be able to do was picture him pushing my sister back onto her couch. I don't know if I'll ever be able to sit on that thing again.

R was on my mind when I chose the blue pencil skirt for work. Travis used to tell me how much he liked my butt in it. I guess it makes me a shameful hussy that I hoped R would notice, too, but after what happened with Lisa this weekend I was feeling competitive.

Lisa showed up for brunch yesterday in a sparkly cobalt sheath she'd obviously worn out the night before. It was no walk of shame. Lisa was glowing and proud. I could tell she was dying to spill all the details, but I didn't take the bait. I made her bring R up.

"What a weekend!" she gushed over Bloody Marys. When I didn't ask her to go on, she did anyway. They went back to her place Friday night, she offered him a nightcap, but they didn't even make it past the living room before her dress was on the floor, Lisa was on her knees. I didn't want to picture it, but unfortunately I am intimately aware of what that looks like. Lisa used words like "aggressive" "strong" and "yummy" to describe R, and that was before they moved to the bedroom.

"Oh. My. God. Annie, it's why I love younger guys. He was unstoppable!"

I just stared down at my drink while she fed me the details, hoping she would take the hint. She didn't. Lisa loves "a guy who knows what he's doing", and apparently R does. He's

“big, but not too big”, the kind of guy who “curls your toes and makes your eyes roll back”.

He was so good, one night wasn't enough. They went to the gym together Saturday, went out that night, and had round two at his place afterward. Lisa said he hopes the walls of his condo aren't too thin. She couldn't stop going on about how good R is with his tongue. That one made me grip my glass a little tighter.

A man who can go down (and do it well) has always been one of my weaknesses. I never come harder than with a guy who's really good at oral. I stayed with Phillip in college an extra 3 months because he was so good at that—even though he was a dud at everything else. It's not the reason I married Travis, but it didn't hurt he was a master at that. I shouldn't say was. He's still very good, it's just not something that happens very often—or it wasn't, up until Paris and the anniversary waxing. That seemed to light a fire under him. It's why I haven't let it grow back yet.

It wasn't quite as bad as I'd feared when I got to work this morning. Sex wasn't the first thing I thought of when I saw R, but it was tough. That man knows how to wear a pair of jeans. I was tense, but I kept it professional when I saw him. He did not bring up Lisa, not then. We were in the bullpen discussing a story, and I began to relax, as it felt like a normal morning. He always behaves himself when others are around. But as he spoke, I concentrated on his mouth more and more. I do that sometimes when he's smiling, but it wasn't his smile that had me this time. Lisa's words rang in my ears, and I thought about R using his mouth. I thought about him smiling up at me from between my thighs. I thought about that tongue, pressing... Okay, don't get distracted now. I can go upstairs and jump Travis when I'm done here.

I was so distracted I completely lost track of what R was saying. He laughed it off and I ran back to my cubby. I checked myself in my compact mirror. I get flushed when I'm turned on, and I didn't want to be that obvious. I was a little red under my makeup, but nothing too bad. Disaster averted, I was relieved when the rest of the day went normally. I got through it with only stray thoughts of R.

I thought I was home free, but R caught up with me in the parking garage. Almost felt like he was waiting for me. I was just about to get into the car and he came very close. Close enough that I could smell his cologne and see the stubble on his cheeks. Close enough that I had to make an effort to not think about his mouth. R was so close he could have touched me, but he didn't. He rested a hand on the roof of the car. I was trapped—in a way—and that caused prickly heat to shoot up my arms.

R was direct. He wanted to know if it was weird that he went home with Lisa. I played dumb, and told him I hadn't given it a second thought. I even threw out that old chestnut, "We're all adults." R didn't want it to be weird between us. My voice was too high when I asked why it would be. He wasn't buying my playing dumb. I think I jumped when he touched my bare arm and insisted, "You know why."

What was I supposed to say to that? I'm married. There was nothing between us. Not really, but only because I hadn't let there be. When he kissed me before Paris I pushed him away, told him I couldn't. The Kiss. Every time I think about that kiss I feel sick & tingly all over. I pushed him away, but not fast enough—not fast enough for a married woman. The guilt made me sick. Still makes me sick. Travis deserves better. Should have pushed R away faster. Shouldn't have looked at him like that afterward—like I wanted him to do it again. And I shouldn't have been so turned on. I felt that kiss all the way down to my toes!

When was the last time a kiss felt like that? When was the last time anyone other than Travis had kissed me like that? No one but Travis should be kissing me like that! It had been a long time, but not as long as it should have been. Such a slut! I should tell Travis I need a spanking.

Stop getting sidetracked! Told R he could have Lisa if he wanted her. He said she wasn't a substitute. R said there is no substitute. No lie, that made me melt a little. R is too good. I got snarky, asked if having two sisters was a fantasy. R laughed. "Only at the same time." Haha. Very funny. I bet Travis has had that fantasy too. I told him this was probably for the best. R admitted maybe it was, but it wasn't what he really wanted. His hand got tighter on my arm.

I should have resisted more when he pulled me in and kissed me. SLUT! Was this kiss longer than the first one? I don't know, but it was worse anyway, because I didn't stop him until he was touching my boobs. R stopped. Reluctantly. Told him I had to go. Once I was alone, I sat in the car and barely resisted touching myself.

What the hell is wrong with me? I have a good life. I have a husband I love. Just because things haven't been so exciting lately (until Paris), it doesn't give me a license to sleep with a coworker. Travis deserves better. I should march right upstairs and confess. I can't. It's not fair to burden him with this. It would crush him. I know he loves me. I have to deal with it. I have to control myself, dammit. And why am I even still entertaining R? I should be angry he used Lisa, no matter how I feel about her. He can put it any way he likes, but come on, fucking one sister over the weekend, kissing the other Monday? The sad thing is, if he was honest with Lisa, she probably wouldn't care. I'm the only one here with a sense of decency. Not really.

It felt good to be indecent. How long has it been since I did something indecent? It's fun to be bad sometimes. It hasn't

been so long that I don't remember. I was never as bad as Lisa, but I had my fun misbehaving. And then I became a grown up. And a wife. And a mom. I know I need to stop whining about this. I have a good life. But...

No more beating this horse. Not tonight. I'm going to go see if Travis is up and apologize in his favorite way. He'll appreciate it, even if he doesn't know why. SLUT!

I felt sick...and tingly all over. That about summed up how I felt, too. The sick part descended like the onset of the flu, my body getting clammy, shaking, feverish. Rick had kissed Annie? Twice? And just last night?

I should have been angry. Or pissed. I should have been disgusted by my wife. “Slut,” she’d called herself, writing it in all caps and underlining it. I could read the self-loathing in her neat script. That’s what I should have felt, too.

But I didn’t. I felt betrayed, sure, but...but weirdly exhilarated by that betrayal. Rick had *kissed* Annie—my Annie, my sweet, always-do-the-right-thing Annie. And it made *her* feel good.

This was real. No longer could I pretend that it was all in my head. The problem was, despite what I’d just read, I continued to think that it was a game. Like, because my wife was such a good person, because she had a moral compass that put mine to shame, she’d never *actually* do anything.

But she’d kissed him. Or let herself be kissed. Not once, but twice.

I thought about last night, how she’d come into the room and initiated sex. How wild she’d been. How into it. How loud she’d come. That wasn’t for me. That was all for Rick. For the kiss she’d shared, and the sex she fantasized about.

I skimmed the entry again, as if I needed to reconfirm that the things I thought I’d read were real. Even then, it didn’t fully set in. If it had, I should have been more horrified than I was. And I certainly shouldn’t have sported the erection that I did.

“The Kiss,” she’d written. And underlined. It had happened before Paris. How much before? I flipped back in the diary, looking for it without really reading anything. Before I could scan far, though, I heard it—the chirp of Annie’s Infiniti outside. She’d come back.

I jumped into action, tucking the diary back into its place, making sure it was locked, and slipping once again out of the room. It was déjà vu. I needed to stop this cycle, but knew that I wouldn't. I was enjoying it too much—as fucked up as that is.

“Annie?” I called downstairs.

“We finished up early. Or, at least I did. Turned out I wasn't really needed after all.”

I tried to read into that. Had Rick rejected her? The idea of it filled me with an urge to go after him, make him apologize, like some over-protective father. Like some boy had hurt Olivia's feelings, not my wife's.

When she came upstairs, though, she didn't seem upset. She smiled at me, kissed me, as friendly as ever.

“Long day?” I asked.

“Long, but not bad. It's a Tuesday, you know?”

I nodded, wanting to sniff her, to see if she had any of Rick's cologne on her, before realizing how weird that would be. As it was, she sensed something was up.

“What?”

“Nothing. Just tired. My day was long, too,” I lied.

“Come on, let's get ready for bed. We could both use it.”

That night, we didn't have sex, despite how badly I wanted it. I lay awake late into the night, long after Annie fell asleep. I listened to her gentle breathing. I watched her peaceful face. She looked beautiful and sweet and so incapable of even thinking about doing anything inappropriate.

Yet she had.

And I liked it.

Chapter 8

Later that week, as we were catching up on the DVR in our den, I said, “Hey, I was thinking, we should do something together. The two of us.”

Annie was stretched out, her legs resting in my lap, her eyes half-closed. “Hmm? Aren’t we doing something together now?”

“I mean something new. Something...I don’t know. We can experience together.”

“Like what?”

We were in a rut. It’s why Annie was where she was, after all. It’s why she had these urges to be inappropriate, and as much as I liked that, it also wasn’t healthy. Not for her, or me, or our marriage. We needed something to break out of the mold. Something exciting. Only I hadn’t thought much further on it. “Um... golf?”

Annie snorted. “*You* play golf.”

“Not well.”

“How about ballroom dancing?” she offered, although it was more a challenge than a real suggestion. She knew I wasn’t a huge fan of dancing.

“Archery.”

Annie laughed. “Backcountry hiking.”

“Now we’re a long way from Paris,” I said. I didn’t even know that she knew that such a thing as backcountry hiking. “But we *should* travel more. Isn’t that what we always talked about, when Olivia went off to college?”

“We went to Paris.”

“So one trip—a *work* trip, no less—in over a year since Olivia went to Princeton.”

“You’re the one working all the time,” Annie said. She wasn’t being critical or patronizing. It was true. She was simply stating the fact.

“I’ll see about getting more time. Lord knows I have a billion accrued hours.”

“So... Santorini?”

“I hear Fall is the best time to visit the Greek Isles,” I said. The thought of Annie standing on a whitewashed balcony, wearing a linen dress that billowed around her, catching in the sun, was definitely appealing. “I’ll see what I can do. How’s your schedule?”

“You know I’m flexible.”

“Oh, I know,” I said, bouncing my eyebrows.

Annie laughed. “Flirt.”

I squeezed Annie’s feet. She had nice feet, and had taken to keeping her nails painted and groomed. “I meant with work. I thought someone...you, maybe? Said something about traveling. For a story? California or something.”

I swear her face turned red. Or maybe it was the shifting color on the television. She didn’t flinch or look away. She didn’t even really hesitate. But...there was something.

“That was Rick. He’s been trying to angle to get a trip out to LA, under the guise of revitalizing the immigration and sanctuary city story.”

“You did win an award for that,” I said. “Can’t really blame him.”

“You’re as bad as he is,” she said, needling my thigh with her toes. “We’d go out there, he’d spend all his time partying and hitting on those stick-thin girls, while I’d do all the work.”

“Then you’d just have to keep him occupied.” I do not know why I said that. It just popped out. This time, Annie’s face definitely flushed.

“What?” she asked, searching my face. It felt like she was picking through my brain, untying the mess of my thoughts. This is what she did, after all. This is what made her such an insightful journalist.

“Put him to work. Get him to line up interviews. Go over your notes. Whatever it is he does. If the magazine is paying for the trip, then make him work for it.”

Her hawkish, deep blue eyes lingered on me for a good, long second or two before accepting that I knew nothing. But was there something to know?

“He’s technically my boss.”

It’s a technical thing now, huh? I shrugged. “I doubt you’d let a technicality like that get in the way.”

“Ha. Are you calling me bossy?”

“I plead the fifth.”

“You’re too much.”

I pulled her to me and kissed her. “I’ll show you too much.”

“That doesn’t even make sense—”

I kissed her again. The conversation was over. So was any attempt to watch whatever was on TV. I shut it off, offered her my hand, and led her to

the bedroom. As we made love, it didn't escape me for a moment just how wet she was.

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Interlude I

“So you encouraged her to go to California with a man that you know she’d kissed.”

I shift uncomfortably in my seat, drawn out of my story and back into the present. Even now, Dr. Caroline’s words feel like fingertips tickling along my spine. And the underside of my balls. I manage not to groan. Manage to keep my eyes on our therapist and focus.

“I did, yes.”

Caroline doesn’t judge. She’s merely making note of it—and making *me* take note. There’s plenty of fault to go around, and I shoulder a good deal of it. But I understood that already. “At the time, I still thought of it all like... like something abstract,” I say. “Like a fantasy. I’d been harboring this thing, in some form or another, for years. I just didn’t fully get it. During that time, I still didn’t quite get it. I didn’t think about the consequences of what I was encouraging.”

“And you didn’t want to talk about it with Annie?”

“I...” Now I do glance away from Caroline, immediately regretting it. I snap my focus back. “No. I didn’t.”

Caroline nods. “Okay. Let’s continue.”

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Chapter 9

We never did make it to Santorini that Fall, but Annie did go to California. And Rick went with her. The kicker is that I kind of encouraged it. I could have shut it down. Lord knows that Annie gave me plenty of outs.

“You think this is silly? I could do all of these interviews over the phone, or over Skype,” she said one evening as we were reading in bed.

If I’d said, *You know, you’re right. Save the Herald some money and take the calls*, I’m sure she would have stayed. Hell, I know she would have because I’d read her diary and knew what she was trying to avoid. She’d kissed Rick. Twice. She didn’t think she could trust herself to be alone with him and was looking for an excuse not to go.

And every time, I argued that she should. Because deep down, I wanted her to go through with it. Or maybe I wanted her to prove to me that she wouldn’t—that she was strong enough to resist. I didn’t know, but I found myself pushing her into it.

“I don’t think it’s silly at all,” I told her. “It’s not just about the interview, right? It’s about experiencing a little bit about what their lives are like. You’re going on a patrol with one of the officers. You wouldn’t be able to write about that accurately if he just told you about it.”

She sighed in resignation. “Yeah, that makes sense.”

So why did I want her to go? Was this some kind of test of her fidelity? I guess that’s what I told myself back then. It sort of was, too, only that wasn’t it.

This was just another escalation of the risk for me, and the riskier it got, the more exciting. It was a game of chicken, and while I told myself I’d be the one to swerve away at the last second, I kept telling myself to drive just a little faster, get just a little closer to collision.

There was a cruelty in it, I know. I watched her struggle over the days leading up to the trip. She didn’t sleep well. She looked lost in thought more times than not. When I asked her about it, she told me she was just thinking about the trip. It wasn’t even a lie.

If she’d just suffered the whole time, that probably would have snapped me out of it. I would have made up some reason for her not to go, she would have taken it, and we would have veered away from disaster at

the very last second. But she didn't suffer the whole time. She was of two minds, torn asunder. The Annie I knew struggled, but the other Annie, the one tempted to do something wild and reckless, was there too, excited and exciting.

On the week before her week-long trip out to California, I came home to an Annie fresh from the salon. I don't always notice these things, but this time it was hard not to. "Wow, you look great," I said.

"Thanks. Just a little touch-up. You know, since I'll actually have to deal with people in real life."

"Foreign concept, I know."

She'd had her hair trimmed and curled so that it fell in loose, bouncing ringlets around her shoulders. The red was a more vibrant shade, too, which must have been new. To match, she'd painted her nails and toes bright red—a detail she didn't mention and I pretended not to notice.

The real kicker, though, the real evidence that slowly the tempted side of Annie was gaining control was in the last night we were together. Annie was packing her suitcase—a huge suitcase, the same one we'd shared on our trip to Paris, only this time, she'd completely filled it with her own things. I came in and hugged her from behind.

"I'm going to miss you," I whispered. "I can't remember the last time we've been apart for a week."

She turned, wrapped her arms around me, and sighed. "I can always call it off."

"No, you can't. Not really." I kissed her. "And I'm being selfish. It's going to be an amazing experience for you."

Annie winced, covering it by looking away, turning back to her suitcase. "It'll be good," she said, without looking at me. "Rick's lined up a pretty full schedule of interviews."

"So you start in San Francisco and then head down to LA?"

"That's still the plan."

"He gets his partying and skinny girls after all."

Annie laughed. "A compromise."

I peered over her shoulder, surreptitiously checking out what she'd packed. It looked like mostly comfortable clothes for the field—jeans, yoga pants, t-shirts and blouses. Things she normally wore on the weekend, as opposed to into the office, although she had a few of those packed, too.

“You seem nervous,” I said. She tensed, and I put a hand on the small of her back, stroking her. “You’ll do great. You’re a natural.”

She took a deep breath and turned to me. She looked dead serious, like she was on the cusp of a confession. My stomach fluttered. I swooned, if only for a little. Before she could say anything, I kissed her, slowly and lovingly. At first. Then, pushing my tongue into her mouth, I deepened it, and she went right with me.

“I love you, honey,” I whispered, my hand going to the base of her shirt. “Let me give you something to remind you of that.”

Peeling her shirt off, I pulled her against me again, kissing her hard as I slipped my hands inside her pants. Her ass was cool and full, filling my hands as I squeezed. Would Rick feel this tomorrow night? God, I hoped so.

Breaking the kiss, I moved down her neck, my lips working along the sensitive sweep of skin there. Would Rick discover just how erogenous this zone was? I imagined he knew a lot of tricks—many of which I had never dreamed of—and with a full week with Annie, would use them all on her.

That got me so hard. I needed to get out of my pants. Annie’s hand was there first, feeling me, squeezing me. She worked at my belt, freeing it as I reached behind her and unclasped her bra. It came open, her breasts bouncing full and free. I dipped lower, wasting no time before taking her swollen nipple into my mouth. It was already so hard, so ready.

Annie shimmied out of her pants herself, taking her panties with her, stripping herself bare. I whipped my shirt off, joining her in her nudity as she crawled back onto the bed and I pursued.

“I’m going to miss this so much,” Annie said, reaching for my cock.

“It’ll be here when you’re back.”

She pulled me close as I lined my hips up over hers. “Mmmm, that’s going to be a fun reunion,” she said.

I pressed my hips forward as I felt my cockhead touch down on her slick pussy. She’d touched it up recently. In preparation for her trip. In preparation for Rick?

“That feels so good,” I groaned as I began to slowly fuck her. “I love that you’re keeping yourself nice and tidy. Like you’ve got this secret that no one else knows about. So when you’re talking to people, when you’re interviewing them, they think they’re talking to this professional, put-together woman, when really, underneath it all, she’s got a little naughty in her.”

“I don’t know about that,” she said, stretching back, accepting me. Accepting my psycho-babble.

“It actually makes a lot of sense,” I said. “Makes it easier for you to put on the persona of researcher and interviewer, because you know it’s all a persona.”

Annie snorted, pulling me down over her. “Can you stop talking and remind me of what I’m going to miss while I’m gone?”

“Oh, a little demanding. I like it.” I kissed her neck and began to work my hips faster. “I’m liking this naughty side of you.”

“You...you like that?”

“Mmm, you know I do.” I leaned close, kissing up to her ear. “What else do you demand of me?”

I didn’t actually expect anything. I drove into her, feeling her fingernails tap along my back, but never really thought she’d do more than moan and pant. But then, hesitantly, she said, “I want you to fuck me.”

It was possibly the first time she’d ever used the F-word during sex, and it nearly did me in. My heart skipped. My balls tightened. I fought off my orgasm. “What did you say?” I growled against her ear.

“I want...you to *fuck me*,” she repeated, with more confidence behind it.

I pulled one leg up over my shoulder, holding her thigh against my chest, bracing myself there. I looked down at her as I thrust forward, watching her writhe and twist. Watching her moan. Her eyes were closed, her brow furrowed, her orgasm swelling somewhere deep inside of her. Her hands seemed to move of their own accord, one grasping the bedspread with a white-knuckled fist, the other—the one with her wedding band—collecting a bouncing breast, squeezing it, tweaking her nipple.

I fucked her harder, feeling things tighten inside of me. I was close, and wouldn’t be able to hold back if this went on any further. Things felt premature, though. It all felt too soon. Annie looked like she was in for the long haul, to be fucked late into the night, and I wanted to give it to her.

Just as Rick would give it to her.

Just as Rick might give it to her *tomorrow night*.

“Oh, fuck, Annie. I’m... I’m—” I couldn’t hold it off. I couldn’t stop my balls from bursting, from filling her with my pent-up and conflicted enthusiasm.

Annie did her best to join me. Moaning and panting, she dropped that left hand down between her legs, playing with her clit, trying to get off. She cried out like she did, she moaned and stiffened and sounded like she did, but I wasn't completely convinced.

"Did you come?" I asked.

"I'm good," she said.

It wasn't an answer, but neither of us probed further. Instead, I said, "I liked that. Hearing you talk like that."

"You did?"

"It was hot. How about you?"

She didn't answer immediately, perhaps struggling with her own thoughts on it. "I liked that you liked it."

I kissed the top of her head. It was as good an answer as I was probably going to get, but that was frustrating. I felt like we were close to a breakthrough. She wanted to be fucked. She wasn't just saying it because she thought it was what I wanted to hear. I knew this, because I'd read her diary.

With that thought, my own guilt ramped up. I'd read her diary, and I knew I'd read more. I'd binge on it when she was gone. I practically trembled, just thinking of starting from the beginning, of watching Rick's seduction of her unfold from the beginning.

"I'm going to take a shower," she said. "So that I can just throw on my clothes and head to the airport tomorrow morning."

"Good idea."

We kissed again, and Annie climbed out of bed. Her naked backside tempted me into joining her as she sauntered into the bathroom. She walked with a casualness that came from all of our years together. How would she behave with Rick? Would she be this comfortable with him after a week? Would he just throw an arm behind his head and watch her prance about him, naked and unashamed?

The shower cut on. I climbed out of bed myself and pulled on my pajamas. There, sitting on the bedroom storage bench at the foot of our bed, was Annie's suitcase, shut but not zipped up yet. Glancing behind me, listening to the shower splash around her, I took a deep breath and flipped it open.

My hands shook, right along with my shuddering breath, as I pulled back the top layer of her professional blouses, looking for whatever else

she'd packed. Right at the top were a pair of heels that I recognized, but that Annie rarely wore—her black, patent leather heels that she reserved for when she needed to look her most professional.

It was what was packed into one of those heels, though, that got my blood racing—a black velvet bag that held a vibrator. It was small and pink with a twisting base that probably controlled the speed. My heart skipped along. She didn't own a vibrator. At least, not that I was aware of. Apparently I was wrong, and what an exciting thing to be wrong about. This was actually a good sign. If she had a vibrator with her, then maybe she'd be able to burn off some sexual energy and be able to keep Rick at arms length. Right?

I set it back into her heel and went on searching. When I found her underwear, though, I began to buzz with a sense of wrongness. Thongs. It seemed she'd only packed thongs.

This wasn't a smoking gun. She could have other reasons for owning a bunch of thongs—after all, she'd been wearing clothing that was tighter than usual, and since she got home before I did and always changed into something more comfortable, I never got a peek at what she wore beneath.

But Annie didn't wear thongs. Until that moment, staring at the evidence, I thought she only owned a couple—ones I'd purchased for her a long time ago and were relegated to the back of her underwear drawer.

I tried taking comfort in the fact that the sexy lingerie did *not* extend to her sleepwear. She hadn't packed a little negligee, just the pajamas she wore all the time, long sleeved and sexy only because everything she wore was sexy. But still...

The shower cut off. I snapped out of my daze, quietly set things back the way they were in the suitcase, closed it up, and climbed into bed. I was actually hard again, something that I hid beneath the covers because I didn't want to explain to Annie why I was hard again.

She emerged with a towel wrapped around her torso and one in her hair. It made me think of a tiny dress, which made me wonder if she'd packed anything like that for her trip. After all, being away from anyone she actually knew, she was free to actually go on a date with Rick. That thought made it difficult to calm my swollen erection.

"You think you'll go dancing, while you're out there?" I asked.

Annie laughed. "I'm not counting on it. It's going to feel *late* as it is."

“Three hours difference. By the time you get to LA, though, you’ll be over the jetlag.”

“My plan is to fight that as much as I can. Easier to transition back here.” She dropped her towel, treating me to a flash of her narrow landing strip before she grabbed an oversized t-shirt and covered herself. She caught me looking, suddenly looking bashful. “What?”

I groaned. “You know what.”

Her face fell forward, her dark red hair spilling across her face, and she climbed into bed. She said, “You really like that, don’t you?”

I took her hand and led it to my cock. Her brows went up in surprise. I couldn’t remember the last time I’d gotten it up twice in one night. “I really do.”

Before she could protest that she needed to finish packing, or get to sleep, or any of that, I had her on her back, her legs spread open, as I crawled down between her legs. I’d left her unsatisfied before, and while she probably took care of things in the shower, I wanted to leave an impression on her through the rest of her trip.

As I went down on her, as I danced my tongue across her smooth and rich folds, tasting her shower-fresh scent as she moaned above me, I wondered where we’d be when she came back. If something did happen, then what?

But then again, nothing actually was going to happen. After all, Annie just wasn’t the type. Right?

Chapter 10

I dropped Annie off at the airport Sunday morning. We had breakfast together before she headed through security. She looked casually beautiful, the epitome of the woman I married. I could almost imagine this woman walking into our psyche class 22 years ago, although her scarf was more decorative than the one she'd been wearing that cold day, and she'd foregone a hat.

Today, a cool September morning, she'd dressed for comfort—yoga pants, a loose sweater, a pair of ballet flats. The knit scarf was an orange infinity scarf that I'd given to her last Christmas—scarfs had become a tradition between us since that first meeting—and gave her a trendy, youthful look as she boarded.

"I love you," she mouthed just before stepping through the security gate. One of the TSA agents, I noticed, gave her a quick once-over as she did.

I waved, and that was it. I was alone. For one week. And Annie, the love of my life, was off with Rick Archer, who she'd already kissed twice. Who had the hots enough for her that he'd pursued her into their garage, and who probably fucked her sister just to get Annie jealous.

My stomach on my drive home. I was actually shaking when I got back to the house. It seemed eerily quiet. Empty. I wandered inside. We'd lived here for fifteen years of our nineteen year marriage. We'd raised our daughter here. We'd made a life for ourselves, right here.

I was only 45. Annie was only 43. We'd had Olivia young, and because of that, so much of our identity was wrapped up in being parents. In making a life for our child. She was off to college now, on her own, and, it seemed, we were floundering a little to figure out who we were.

Maybe Annie was ready to move on from me. It was a chilling thought, but one I also couldn't take seriously. As crazy as it was, I never even considered for a moment that she'd leave me for Rick. Or leave me for anyone. She loved me. I didn't doubt that, even if she was about to cheat on me.

See, thinking like that still gets me. It's like a gut-punch, right to my core—powerful, visceral, and filled with fluttering excitement. I know I

keep going over it, but you have to understand, Annie was like this perfect, good girl. She always did the right thing. When she got picked for jury duty, she didn't try to get out of it. If she wasn't charged for something at the grocery store, she went back and had the cashier ring her up correctly. She didn't even cross the street unless she had a walk signal.

So to imagine that that woman was capable of having a fling with a guy like Rick was crazy and wild and so erotic. That she was my wife only added to the intensity.

I cracked open a beer—because I was going to need alcohol to get me through the next few hours—grabbed the diary key from my briefcase, and headed straight upstairs.

My heart must have been going a million miles an hour, racing faster than Annie's jet at take off. I could almost hear its roar in my ears, only to blink and hear nothing. Absolutely nothing. My footsteps didn't even register as I padded across her plush carpet and opened the bottom drawer of her desk.

Which was empty.

Well, not empty. The random scraps of paper, envelopes, pens and pencils, they were all there. But her diary wasn't. I searched the next drawer, then the next. I searched all the drawers, finding nothing at all but exactly what you'd expect to find in a desk.

Then it occurred to me. She'd taken it with her. Of course she had. She'd be gone a week—one of the most intense weeks of her life. She'd need her outlet.

My disappointment was fleeting. When I opened her closet, I discovered that a second blue leather diary sat next to the first, the last entry from last Monday. So she'd taken a fresh one, to record her time there. Or maybe none at all.

Either way, I had a record. And I had time. I pulled down the older one, the one that covered her the time when Rick would have started at the Herald. I could start at the beginning. I could read how it all unfolded.

*

Friday, May 3

Got an email about a new editor-at-large at work. Rick Archer. I've never been a big fan of change, so of course I sat down and did my homework. I hated the pre-internet days when you had to go into things blind. I tackled it like any other research project. Looked at his LinkedIn first, since this is professional. First impression—he looks like a frat boy. Too pretty to take seriously. But I chided myself. That's not fair. Keep an open mind. His resume is pretty good. He's worked at several of the larger websites, interned at CNN. Okay, so he probably knows what he's doing. But he's so young! Again, not fair. That's my hang-up.

I'm not old, or so I keep telling myself. But I'm not a kid anymore (I have a kid! She's in college!), and I've got to accept some new experiences. One of those is that I'm going to be working with younger people, and I may even be answering to some of them. I don't know if I'll be answering to Rick, but I do have to work with him, and I can't think of him as a kid if I am. Besides, he can't be as young as he looks—not based on his resume. He's got to be at least 30, not in his 20s. I had my PhD and a child by the time I was his age. I was definitely an adult.

Rick looks pretty active, based on his Facebook page. I'm surprised he has time to work. He's friends with lots of pretty young things. That's understandable. It looks like he's single. If I was still in my 20s—and single—I'd be friends with him too! Getting past how young Rick looks, he is very handsome. Just the type of boy who had me thinking improper thoughts way back when. Good thing I'm too old to be distracted now. Haha!

It took me a little bit of scanning before I found the May 3 entry, which seemed like the very beginning of the Rick stage of Annie's life—and I have to admit, I was curious if she had any other brushes with “types of boys” who had her “thinking improper thoughts.” The idea of it buried itself tantalizingly in my gut.

The entry, though, was so typically Annie. She was self-critical, grounded—mostly—focused on her age, and his, and how she couldn't help herself from looking at the world through that lens.

I got up, surprised that I'd finished my beer—but then again, not so surprised—and went to use the bathroom. I had a week, so I wanted to milk this diary for all it had while she was gone. Not that I was under any real illusions that I wasn't going to race through it.

I'd been careful not to read through the entries as I searched for the start of the Rick affair—"affair," I shuddered. I looked for his name, but didn't want to know the details. Because I had so much time, I could do this the right way. Could watch it all unfold like a sexy train crash.

Going downstairs, I poured myself a glass of water, looked out into the backyard. It was all the same out there, all just the way it had always been. A breeze rolled through, ruffling the orange and red leaves of the trees, sending them fluttering across our lawn. I'd have to rake that up.

But not now.

I went back upstairs and plopped back down at Annie's desk, picking up where I'd left off. The next few entries were pretty mundane. She didn't write every day, but close to it. Most of the entries were short, just a few lines. "Went riding. Ruby was a little sluggish. Think the poor gal is coming down with something." Or "Got my hair done today, tried a different shade of red. I think I like it." Or "Travis got invited to the Paris Symposium! Eek. Paris!" Eventually, though, I found the next Rick entry, dated a week later.

Friday, May 10

Met the new boss. Same as the old boss. Not really. Sally was very laid back about my work. Beyond some minor stuff, she mostly left it alone. After our initial meeting, I don't think Rick will be quite the same. One word: intense. Have to admit, some of his jargon about achieving and excellence had me rolling my eyes. Hate corporate speak and buzzwords. Another way I'm an old lady, I guess. By the way he was talking about striving for excellence, and squeezing

all the juice out of every story, I think he is going to be way up in my business. Squeezing the juice? Who talks like that?

At least he's easy on the eyes. I should feel guilty for thinking that, shouldn't I? I mean, feminism and all that. But doesn't feminism mean I get to objectify a guy the way they've been objectifying us forever? Anyway, Rick. Even hotter in person than he looked online. Work is pretty casual, but he wore a shirt and tie. That shirt must be tailored. Really showed off the time in the gym. Yum! God, I'm terrible. Am I becoming a dirty old lady in my middle age? No, I could tell all the other girls in the office noticed too. Don't think I've ever seen anyone quite so welcomed. I could see some of them making plans. Glad I am out of that rat race. I may be a boring, married woman, but it makes life easier.

I think I'll go try to molest Travis. And if I can't get his attention, there's always the showerhead.

I wasn't sure what had me more excited, the way she talked about Rick in such a blunt, objectifying way, which was so unlike the side of Annie she projected to me, or her reference to our showerhead. Our *showerhead*? It was detachable, but it never occurred to me that she actually detached it for that reason.

I pressed on, skimming forward in search of the next juicy bit.

Saturday, May 18

Weekend was nice. Lisa came over with some guy and we barbequed in the backyard. I wonder if she wore that dress knowing it was going to get Travis's attention? I don't think she would ever try to steal my husband—he's really not her type—but I know she's always liked his attention. It's like she's telling me, "I could have him if I wanted him."

Could she? I've pondered that a lot over the years. I guess trying to climb into Travis's head is an occupational hazard. I might not be practicing, but I'm still a shrink at heart. I'm very lucky I am married to such a good man, having a sister like Lisa. I know she's not above stealing a guy from me, but I also know Travis is rock solid. That's why it doesn't bother me that he checks out my sister. I know he'll never do any more than look. Maybe he has some thoughts in his head, some fantasies, but that's harmless. Who doesn't let their mind wander? If you could get in trouble for thoughts, I'd be seriously screwed! Especially since Rick started at work.

I've never liked it when a boss just dropped by my desk, but for some reason I don't seem to mind when Rick does it. He can park that cute tush on the corner of my desk anytime he likes. If only I was single and ten years younger! I think I'm too late, though. Pretty sure he's already sleeping with Amber.

Anyway, back to the weekend. Nothing much to report. Nice, but boring. Lisa and her latest boytoy climbed all over each other, not caring that we were sitting right there. It made me wonder when Travis and I lost that heat. Not that we ever behaved like that in front of other people, but I miss the days when we couldn't keep our hands off each other. It's still good, when it happens. There's just not that need anymore. Maybe Paris will help.

I took a break after that. What came next, I knew, was The Kiss, and while I wanted to get there, there was so much packed into the May 18 entry that I needed to process before it was overshadowed by that kiss—Annie's thoughts about Rick, about her sister and me, about missing the heat of our relationship.

I ate a late lunch, grabbed my gloves, and headed outside to rake the leaves. Manual labor was what I needed, and as I formed neat piles through our yard and stuffed them into brown, paper garden bags, I considered the diary. And me and Annie.

“There’s not that *need* anymore.” She was right, and clearly she also missed it. The ironic part, of course, was that the more I read about her inner turmoil and the temptations that Rick Archer presented, the more I craved her. Raking the leaves, thinking about her, I missed her. I wanted her. I was hot for her.

Maybe the question was less about my need for her, though, and her need for me. It was a chilling thought, and one that made me take a hard and honest look at myself. At 45, I think I held up pretty well, but I wasn’t the skinny track runner that she’d first met. I’d put on a little weight, just like every other middle aged man did, but even if I hadn’t, there was no way I could have competed with a man like Rick. I was never in that kind of shape, even when I was his age. Even when I was younger.

If only I was single and ten years younger. So would she go for a guy like Rick? I never got the impression that she liked that look—the frat boy look, as she’d thought of him in her first impressions. Broad-shouldered, square-jawed, clean cut. Then again, Annie was full of surprises.

Then there was Lisa. I actually remember that barbeque, way back before Memorial Day. It had been one of those perfect, pre-summer days. Lisa had come over in this short summer dress that showed off her devastating legs and full rack. It was turquoise, covered in flowers, and strapless. I think. Whatever it was, I couldn’t stop looking at her, but thought I’d done a good job hiding it. Guess not.

Thing about Lisa was that Annie was right, I’d never do more than look. What I’d never told her was that way back when we’d first started dating, Lisa *had* tried...something. It was when I was still in school with Annie and Lisa came to visit. I could still remember walking in on her while she was in the bathroom, having just finished up a shower.

“I’m so sorry,” I’d said, averting my eyes. All she had on was a wet towel, wrapped around her nineteen-year-old body.

“No need to apologize. I don’t mind.” She’d passed me, close enough that I could smell the soap off her pale, pink skin, heading into the guest bedroom. Just before pulling the door shut, though, she looked over her shoulder, met my eyes, and let her towel fall open. Shameless, she let me linger on her naked backside before saying, “I don’t mind at all.”

We never talked about it, but I never forgot about it, either. Even now, years later, when I see her in a pair of tight jeans or a short skirt, I think about her naked ass and the dimples in her lower back.

What was crazy was that I'd never do anything with Lisa, as tempting as the blonde was. First of all, she scared me. Second, I loved Annie, and even imagining the pain my wife would feel if I ever did something like that was enough to sober me up, every time. It's probably why I never told her about the shower incident.

I'm not an idiot. I understood the strange double standard going on here. How could I be worried about hurting Annie when she was off doing this thing with Rick?

But Annie was struggling, just as much as she was tempted. What was it she'd said? She didn't think I deserved her? She didn't want to confess about the kiss because she was worried that it would crush me. She struggled. It just wasn't enough to prevent her from packing a set of secret thongs for her trip with another man.

And that was so fucking hot.

"Hey, I think you got it all," Jared, our neighbor, said. I stopped what I was doing, realizing that I'd been raking the same pile of leaves for the past five minutes.

"Oh, right. Thanks."

"You can borrow my leaf blower if you want. Saves time."

"No, I'm good. I like the exercise."

"I hear you," he said. "Same way I feel about mowing the grass. Take care."

"Thanks."

I went inside and checked my phone. Annie had texted that she'd arrived safely and was headed for the hotel. My heart skipped a beat. I wondered how long it would take for Rick to seduce her.

[Me]: Great! Hope you can relax some. Miss you already.

I almost hit send, but at the last second, deleted the part about missing her. While it was true, I also didn't want to add to the guilt and her self-consciousness of what she was doing. She was on a razor edge. Things could still go either way. It still amazes me that when I thought about it, in my heart of hearts, I wanted them to fall the naughtier, sweatier, sexier way.

[Annie]: Not sure about the relaxing part. We've got an early morning interview tomorrow. At least 9am will feel like noon

to me.

I wondered where she was. Sitting in the hotel lobby with Rick at her side? Alone in her hotel room? In her hotel room with Rick?

I tingled.

[Me]: Make sure you rest up for that. Plenty of sleep. I'm sure you'll do great.

[Annie]: Thanks, honey. Call me before you go to bed.

[Me]: Will do.

She asked me to call her, which meant she wasn't planning on doing something that I'd awkwardly interrupt. Which was a good thing. A comforting one. And a disappointing one. It was weird how I found myself rooting for the affair. But I was.

I went back outside and did some more chores—hauling the bags of leaves to the curb, dragging the patio furniture into the garage, giving the lawn one final, pre-winter cut. The whole time, I kept looking up toward the window of Annie's study, where her diary entries awaited, and wondered why I wasn't up there now.

The answer? Anticipation. By the time I was finished with the yardwork and I was beneath the shower, I was buzzing with the promise of what was in those pages. I dressed, thought about dinner very briefly, then went back to her office and picked up where I'd left off.

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Chapter 11

Thursday, May 23

I think I'm losing it. I must be. I think Rick was flirting with me today. He told me how good I looked, and how "that color" brought out my eyes. I guess he didn't get the sexual harassment video. Except, I didn't feel harassed. Flattered is probably the right word, although that doesn't quite cover it. I hope my cheeks didn't look as hot as they felt. After these weeks of noticing Rick, it was nice that he noticed me. He was probably just being nice. Had to be. Pretty sure he's still sleeping with Amber.

Saturday, May 25

It is not all in my head. I may be soccer mom (retired? Still can't believe Olivia's in college!), but I remember what it feels like when a guy is flirting with me. And Rick wasn't being subtle. Not once we got to lunch. He really turned it on then.

We were supposed to be working on the sanctuary cities piece, but Rick strayed from work early. He asked if I was just all about work. Of course not, I told him, but it was important to me, especially meaningful stories like this one. Rick said he admires my passion, wishes everyone had it. I felt myself flushing again, and cursed my pale, freckled complexion.

I turned the tables by asking about him. Hate to stereotype, but I've found guys like Rick like to talk about themselves. I only really knew what I'd gleaned from his social media stuff. He loves far-flung vacation spots and being active. Vacations just sitting on the beach aren't for him. He'd

rather be zip lining or rock climbing, discovering new places. Hearing the list of places he's been reminded me of all the places I have not. I don't regret having Olivia early, but it meant our vacations were always family vacations. I was not dragging a toddler through a rainforest. And when Olivia was older, we just sort of fell into always taking the typical vacations.

Rick insisted he was single. I wanted to ask if he's seeing Amber, but I didn't have the nerve. He said he's too young to settle down. Rick said he's having too much fun. I observed the unfair double standard that men are free to play the field, while women are judged and called whores if they behave the same. Rick said he never judges and admires women who feel free to do as they please. And then he asked if I was one of those women!

I know I turned 20 shades of crimson before reminding him I'm married. He said that doesn't stop everyone, and I said it stops me. I know that didn't come out right, implying that I wanted to, but Travis stops me. That's not true, but he plowed right on, pointing out that I wasn't always married.

"What exactly are you asking me?" I asked, after draining half my water.

"How wild were your wild single days?" Rick asked.

I didn't answer right away, because some fun college memories came to mind, and there was that period when we were apart while Travis was living in Philadelphia while I was finishing school. We were technically together, but I felt like we had a don't-ask-don't-tell policy. I didn't go crazy, but I knew that if I was really settling down with Travis when I finished school it would be my last chance to put myself out there. I didn't quite have the nerve to do that—put myself out there—but I didn't need to. I had plenty of interest, and guys

being guys, no one seemed to have a problem that I had a long distance boyfriend.

When I did answer Rick, it was with a cryptic smile, and a vague assurance that I'd had my fun. Honestly, sometimes I wonder what might have happened if we hadn't settled down so young, but I think everyone does that. It doesn't mean anything, and I wouldn't trade my life for the world. Rick followed up to ask if I missed it, being single. I assured him my husband takes very good care of me, so I have nothing to miss. But as I watched his cocky smile and scented his masculine cologne across the table, I let my mind go where I couldn't allow my body to.

I paused here only long enough to process the “don't-ask-don't-tell policy” that we apparently had just after I graduated. I'd always suspected that *something* had happened—with Brian Hoffman, the associate professor, or one of the other grad students. To get confirmation that something had, though, was different. Was powerful. The difference between imagining jumping out of a plane, and that moment when I'm actually pushed from it. My stomach bottomed out. I went into freefall. But man was it exhilarating.

Didn't sound like it had only been Brian Hoffman, either. “Guys being guys,” she wrote. Plural.

But that was then. So much more was happening now. I read on.

Tuesday, June 4

Work is interesting these days. I'm enjoying the writing and research of course, because I've always been a nerd for that stuff, but that's not what I mean. I'm talking about Rick of course, or R to me now that I think of him as my work boyfriend. He's not work husband material, because I don't take him that seriously, but he's a fun work boyfriend.

The term “boyfriend” amplified that sense of freefall. I could practically hear the wind roar in my ears.

Since breaking the ice, R has become open about his interest, at least when we're alone. And he's finding a lot of excuses for us to be alone. The story we're working on gives him a good excuse as there's a lot less group work than one-on-one time now. The conference room has glass walls, but sometimes I think R forgets that.

R is always quick to point out how good I look, and how lucky Travis is. I always say thank you, but I've stopped blushing at it. I'm so used to it, I think I'd be disappointed if R didn't say anything. I think I've been playing it cool, though. He doesn't know that it gets to me.

I pointed out yesterday that his behavior is probably sexual harassment. He asked if I feel harassed. That did make me blush! All I could do was smile. I hate it when R makes me feel like a shy schoolgirl. And then he had the nerve to say he's the one who should feel harassed. Like a fool, I walked right into his line. He said, "It's not fair having to work with a sexy woman like you. You're close enough to touch, but you say I can't. Imagine the sexual frustration I'm walking around with."

I laughed at him. What did he think I was going to do, throw myself on top of him right there on the conference room table? "You poor baby," I told him, followed by, "Does that sort of thing usually work for you?"

There was that cocky grin again. R insisted he likes a challenge. I tried telling him I am not a challenge. I'm not playing games. I am a happily married woman. Off limits.

We were standing beside each other by the table in the conference room. He leaned very close. I felt his hot breath on my cheek. It gave me goosebumps. I tried to keep from trembling. In a low, sexy voice, R told me, "If that's so, then why do you look at me like that? Why are you shaking right

now, Annie? I'll buy happily married, but off limits? We'll see about that."

And he left me there like that. I wanted to scream. I wanted to strangle him. I should have marched right down to HR and put an end to it, but I didn't. R wasn't really harassing me. I knew he sensed that there was a part of me that was receptive to him. And I was so frustrated because what I really wanted was for him to pin me down on that conference table and take me. I almost didn't care that there was an office full of people on the other side of that glass wall.

It was so, so very wrong, in so many ways. Looking, sure, everyone does that. Everyone has fantasies, and I was having some vivid ones. I had imagined working late with R, him kissing me. I would resist at first, but he'd know I didn't mean it, and he'd keep pressing. He'd lean me back on the table, and I'd reach to undress him.

Ok, stop! Not the time to get myself all worked up again! I jumped Travis last night. I don't think he knew what hit him. It was...nice? No, nice isn't right. It was good. Travis knows how to make me feel good. But after all these years it's too much of the same. We kiss. We touch. He plays with my boobs, which I love, but somehow I feel like he's on autopilot and he's trying to get to the main event. Travis is so sweet. He never tries to start before I'm ready. But I don't always finish. I don't blame him for that at all. I know it's on me. My head just isn't in it sometimes. And maybe it's a compliment that he can't hold out. He still finds me sexy enough that he can really get off quickly! I want to look at it that way.

I know it wouldn't be that way with R. I don't know why, I just know. If he can make me feel that way by just whispering in my ear, I can only imagine what it would be like if he put his hands on me. No, better yet, don't imagine that! Too dangerous!

I've got to push R away. I feel like it's getting risky now. If I keep sending him mixed signals, he might take it as a green light. And then what am I going to do?

“And then what am I going to do?” was the question of the hour. I checked the time. It was eight o'clock here. Only five o'clock where she was. What was she planning to do for dinner? She was out there with Rick, her “work boyfriend.” Made sense that the two would grab a casual bite to eat, but for one moment, I considered that dinner wasn't casual. I imagined Annie putting on something nice, doing her makeup, putting on a little perfume. I closed my eyes and saw them sharing a candlelit dinner, staring into one another's eyes, laughing over their glasses of wine.

To quote Annie, it was “so, so very wrong, in so many ways.” And yet despite that, despite the risk factor, I actually unbuckled my pants and pushed them down to my thighs, freeing my towering erection. Right there in Annie's home office, surrounded by photos of our family, of her diplomas and accolades. I stroked myself as I re-read parts of the last entry, focusing on trigger words: “work boyfriend” and “wanted him to pin me down” and “makes me feel like a schoolgirl.” I re-read her daydreams, and how sure she was that he'd be good in bed. I could hear how tempted she was. And this was months ago. Early June. Things had evolved since then.

I almost came, thinking about those evolutions. I somehow resisted, slowing my masturbation. I took a deep, calming breath, stared out the window—where night had fallen and I hadn't noticed—and went back to the diary.

Wednesday, June 12

Today R asked if I think about him. Instead of doing what I should have, saying no, I answered, “Of course I do. I see you every day, and we're working on this article together.” R said that's not what he meant, and I clammed up. Of course that wasn't what he meant.

R's been a little more subtle, but no less persistent. I think he realized he's not going to push me into his bed, so he thinks

he can lead me there. He's barking up the wrong tree. I am not going to cheat on Travis. I am not going to let things get out of hand.

I've been thinking more and more about that time with Dane. Was it like it's been with R? It's hard to remember, that had to have been 10 years ago. The details are fuzzy now, even if that kiss wasn't.

Dane? Dane Armstrong?! Annie kissed Dane Armstrong ten years ago?!

Travis was at that conference, Olivia was at camp. Dane had always been flirty, and he really poured it on when no one was looking. It felt good to have another man notice me, so I didn't exactly discourage it, and I thought it was harmless anyway. Much like R now.

What I do remember was how I felt that evening when Dane dropped around with a bottle of wine, knowing I was home alone. I should have turned him away. I was exhausted from riding all morning. But the house was so empty, and it left me feeling lonely. He said he was alone that night too, something about a girls' night out. So we sat out by the pool, and opened his wine, and it was really relaxing. Dane was flirty, but no more than usual. We laughed. It was a good time.

I remember sitting on the edge of the pool, our feet in the water, still warm from the hot day's sun. Dane started rubbing my shoulders, and I was tipsy and tired and sore from riding, so I let him. He had magical hands. I don't know why I didn't see it for the move it was, but it felt good to be wanted, and Dane was so handsome. I only snapped out of it when Dane leaned in and kissed me.

And for one, weak moment, I kissed him back. God, I still feel the shame!

At least I came to my senses right after that. Right after I felt our tongues touch and—stop it, girl! It was wrong. I pushed him away, told him to leave. And unlike R, he didn't push. Dane knew what he was trying to do, and looked to infuriatingly smug. That helped me get over it.

It was only in the cool aftermath that I realized that I'd played a role in that. That I'd let myself get caught up in Dane and put my guard down. And for what? I had no marital excuse. Things were really good with Travis then.

“And for one, weak moment, I kissed him back.” As soon as I read that, I came. It caught me by surprise, spraying across my t-shirt like I was some teenage boy just figuring this shit out. I grabbed a handful of tissues off Annie's desk and carefully wiped myself, mindful not to get any of this on her diary or the upholstery of her chair.

Annie and Dane? Together? Now that I'd come and the rich buzz was sated—for now—I felt cold. Was this for real? It had to be, otherwise she wouldn't have written it. I pushed back from the desk and ran my hand through my hair.

I liked Dane. Always did. He was just a nice guy, always ready to help a friend or neighbor out. He owned a pickup, and he'd helped me haul mulch and topsoil more than a few times. Back before he split up with his wife, Lisa—not my sister-in-law—there was a time when I could see our families getting along were it not for the huge age difference of our daughters. That never did happen, though. Was this why?

Fuck, she'd kissed Dane?! It rocked me again. Had more happened? I glanced down at the diary, skimmed the next few lines.

I was never the same around Dane after that, and I prayed that Travis didn't notice. He never said anything. And I'm sure he appreciated the month of crazy, spontaneous sex we had afterward. I bought some fun lingerie back then. That part of it was amazing. Travis was going down on me almost every night.

So no, didn't sound like it. I do remember those times, though, and the lingerie she'd worn. I remember that she'd actually purchased a garter belt and stockings, although they'd not come out of the back of her drawer since then.

So that had been guilt? Shame? I just figured it had to do with us approaching ten years of marriage, and Annie deciding to put an effort into things. Never did it occur to me that the spike in sex had to do with her thoughts on Dane.

I wandered out of the room, kicking my pants off and dumping them into the hamper. I went back into the shower—a much colder one this time—but just couldn't get thoughts of Dane and Annie out of my head.

This established a pattern. A vulnerability to Annie that I never knew. She'd never confessed that kiss. She'd never confessed our gap year and her time with Brian Hoffman. Were there other times? And why did that make me hard again?

I got out of the shower before I came again. Toweled, dried, changed into my pajamas. On a whim, I checked the back of Annie's lingerie drawer. Her garter belt and silk stockings were still there...but so were other things. Newer things. Things that weren't tucked away, but folded neatly in front. I thumbed through them. Thongs. Annie owned a small collection of thongs.

Jesus. I'd noticed the few she'd packed for California, but this showed that the skimpy panties were more function over form—so nothing was seen through clothes rather than be seen with her clothes off. All of a sudden she was concerned about visible panty lines, which in and of itself was hot because it meant she was thinking about the way men looked at her.

By this time, it was past nine o'clock, and I was starving. I went downstairs, heated up some leftovers from last night, and texted Annie.

*[Me]: Hey, how's it going? Think I'm going to turn in soon.
When's a good time to call?*

When she didn't immediately text me back, of course my mind filled in lurid, pulse quickening images of Annie and Rick together in bed, his hips driving and driving as she cried out beneath him and—

Ring!

“Hey, Annie.”

“Hey, sweetheart.” She sounded tired, but not out-of-breath tired.

“Long day?”

“Very. And it’s not even seven. This is crazy.”

“You’ll adjust.”

She sighed. “Yeah, just as I’m ready to head home.”

“You eat yet?”

“Yeah. Well, no, not really. Ate a granola bar.”

“Make sure you eat. You get a *per diem*, right? Room service!”

This felt painfully mundane, considering what I knew could actually be about to happen out there.

“Yeah, that may be all I can manage. I swear, I can barely keep my eyes open. And we’ve got such a long day lined up tomorrow.”

We. The inclusion sliced through me like a blade. “Get some rest, honey. I’ll talk to you tomorrow.”

“I love you, Travis.” I wasn’t sure, but I swore that I heard more conviction than normal in the platitude.

“I love you, too, Annie. Sleep well.”

“Going to be weird sleeping alone.”

So she’ll be alone. That was comforting, even if I didn’t think—hope?—that she’d be spending all her nights alone this trip.

“Speak for yourself,” I said. “I’m going to spread out in the middle of the bed.”

Annie snorted. “Have fun. Don’t get used to it.”

“Night, honey.”

After she hung up, I dumped the dirty plates in the dishwasher and went upstairs to get ready for bed. Grabbing her diary and carrying it out of her office felt wrong, but I was too tired and exhausted to dwell on it. In bed, I flipped it open and got back to that shocking entry, with my heart back in my throat.

...I was never the same around Dane after that, and I prayed that Travis didn’t notice. He never said anything. And I’m sure he appreciated the month of crazy, spontaneous sex we had afterward. I bought some fun lingerie back then. That part of it was amazing. Travis was going down on me almost every night.

I guess my new situation is similar, except Dane is no R. Dane and I were peers, and I didn't know there was anything behind his flirting. R is the younger boss, even more the forbidden fruit. And R is very clear about what he wants. I need to shut him down!

R told me he noticed I've been dressing sexier, and said he likes it. Have I? I thought I had something of a work uniform. Casual pants, a silk blouse. Maybe some of my slacks are tighter than others, and some of those blouses do kind of cling to my chest. But I always wear a cami under that burgundy one with the V neck that doesn't button so high. I don't think I'm dressing for R, but am I fooling myself?

If I am dressing differently, Travis hasn't noticed. Does he pay that much attention anymore? He hasn't said anything unusual. I don't think I've been paying enough attention either. I'm way too distracted with thoughts of work and thoughts of R. There's not enough room for anything else. It's not fair to him. It's not fair that his wife has a crush on her co-worker either. All of this energy I'm pouring into R, I should be pouring into my marriage. Maybe if I was, R wouldn't think I was available.

We need to turn our Paris trip into a second honeymoon. I'm afraid to say anything to Travis, though. I don't want him getting suspicious.

She was right. For so long, I'd neglected her. I'd been consumed by work, by the speaking tour and a book I was working on. I hadn't shown Annie the attention she deserved. Truth was, we'd been going from lovers to friends for years. It was natural, I know, but Annie deserved more. I knew it. Every once in awhile, I'd look at her and be amazed by how lucky I was. She was smart, funny, beautiful.

When Olivia went to college and left us with an empty nest, I'd somehow gotten it into my head that all of that drifting apart stuff would be

resolved, as if our daughter's presence in the house was the reason. Like, now that we were alone with each other, we'd be forced to get close again. That didn't happen, of course, because it takes effort to fix something, and both of us were too consumed in the lives we'd become accustomed to.

The entries that followed the June 12 one were more about Olivia's decision to stay in her college town over the summer, rather than come home. Annie missed her "best friend," not just because she wasn't around, but because Olivia was forging a life of her own. A life separate from us. Annie struggled hard with that. I wondered if it left her vulnerable to Rick. I wondered what would have happened had Olivia stayed. Or if I'd started noticing her earlier.

I fell asleep, thinking I'd have wild and vivid dreams about this stuff. In the morning, I remembered none of them.

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Chapter 12

I considered skipping work. I really did. I still had pages and pages to read in the diary, including *The Kiss*, which I anticipated with a chugging heart beat.

But I got up, got dressed, and dragged myself to work. The diary would have to wait, no matter how much I thought about it.

It was weird, that diary juxtaposed against what might be going on out in California, as confusing as the time difference was to wrap my brain around. What I was reading were Annie's thoughts from months ago, yet because I was just reading them now, I was processing them like she was having them now. But for all I knew, things could have gone so much further. She could have started fucking him weeks ago, long before this trip.

God, but that thought sent a shiver of arousal through me, when it should have meant horror.

I thought about that through the day, since I couldn't read her actual words. Was I a cuckold? Not in the literal meaning of the word—to be the husband of an unfaithful wife—although I could be that, too. But rather, was I a cuckold in the fetish sense, a man who got off on the unfaithfulness of his wife.

Obvious answer was yes, and yet the more I read about the fantasy itself, the less I liked it. I didn't want Annie—or worse, her lover—to rub my face in the affair. I didn't want to be humiliated, either publicly or privately. I didn't want Annie to start denying me sex, or locking my cock in a cage, or coming home and making me eat her lover's come from her pussy.

I took comfort in what I read. She didn't think less of me, other than that I wasn't paying enough attention to her. She didn't deride me in her diary, didn't think of me as a wimp or an idiot. I wasn't some pathetic sap she was stringing along.

There was an aspect of the whole thing that really got me off, the way it really shouldn't, and that was that all of this was going on behind my back—or so she thought. She was doing this for herself, getting swept up in it not because I thought it was sexy, but because she did.

As soon as I got home, I jumped back into the diaries. Almost a month in diary time had passed since the bombshell one about Dane Armstrong and the kiss.

Friday, July 5

Today felt dangerous! R was messaging me all morning, telling me how hot I looked. First I played coy, then I told him to stop. The problem was, I couldn't wipe the smile off my face. It's terrible, but ever since R mentioned how I was dressing, I did think about him when I got dressed in the morning. It's why I've started wearing thongs for the first time in my life. And it's not like I went to work in a cocktail dress or anything, but I had a feeling what he might like. I know the attention I get when I wear my short sleeve mock turtleneck. It's nice and clingy, like all good knits. The long gold chain only accentuates things. And my gray slacks are only slightly less tight than my riding breeches. I couldn't help it if R couldn't control himself.

R's been getting handsy lately. Not like groping, but a casual touch on the arm, brushing a stray eyelash from my cheek. Lots of light touches on my back. They are the kinds of touches that should be meaningless, but every time he touches me I feel the sparks and I start to tingle down below. It's really frustrating! It feels like I'm wet all the time now! R has to know how he's affecting me. He has to feel the heat I do when he touches me.

I think I've been avoiding sex with Travis now because when we make love I keep fantasizing about R, and I just feel guilty. God help me!

Most telling of all, I don't remember this dry spell. I don't remember her avoiding sex. And she felt wet all the time? Did she still feel that way? If so, I gave her three days, max.

I flipped through the next entries, scanning for a capital R, not really reading anything until I came to July 19. July 19, the day that I'd been waiting for all this time.

Friday, July 19

It finally happened today. I can't even pretend to be shocked, because I was expecting it. The sane, decent part of me hoped it wouldn't happen, but deep down I knew it was going to.

At the end of the day on a summer Friday, the office was virtually abandoned. Most of the office had been taking half days on Fridays, so it had been quiet all day, even before people started filtering out for the weekend. I stayed late because I had things to finalize before we left for Paris on Monday. I didn't even know R was still in the office, although I should have. He wasn't letting me go without a goodbye.

R drifted over to my desk, and I didn't even notice him until he sat on the edge that way he always does. I found him smiling down at me. R commented on what a hard worker I was, and how he admired that the most. I giggled and told him I knew that wasn't true. He insisted it was. "It's what makes you so sexy," he said. "You're even smarter than you are beautiful. It's how I know you'll be so good in bed, because you've got such a creative mind." R really knows how to make me melt. But I was not going to just fall into his bed.

I stood, hands on my hips, challenging. I asked if that's what this was all about. He's been after me because I'm so smart? It's got nothing to do with my tits? I still can't believe I said that! I think I even shoved them out at him.

R stared at me. He didn't even try to pretend he wasn't staring at my chest. I suddenly realized just how quiet it was.

We were alone in the bullpen. Sure, there were IT guys somewhere in the offices, but we were effectively alone. My heart hammered in my chest. I felt myself getting damp.

“Yeah, you’re hot, Annie. But if you were just hot and nothing else, you wouldn’t be any different from the other girls in the office. It’s about way more than tits and ass.”

“You’ve got such a way with words,” I taunted. It’s all burned into my brain.

“I’ve got better talents.”

“I’m sure you do.”

“You aren’t curious?”

My nails were digging into my palms to distract me. The danger was palpable. I pled the Fifth.

Of course R kissed me. Why wouldn’t he? I wasn’t running away. It probably felt like I was daring him to do it. His strong hand grabbed me by the back of my neck and reeled me in. I thought he’d crush my lips against his, but no. He was soft. He hesitated. He waited while I froze. He waited for me to kiss him back. And then we were really kissing! God, were we kissing! It felt like he lit a blow torch in my body. I don’t know the last time a kiss made me feel like that. I don’t know if a kiss ever made me feel like that! I didn’t feel anything like that when Dane kissed me all those years ago. My hands were on R’s solid chest, then his thick arms. I don’t know if I was pulling him closer or pushing him away. I don’t know how long we kissed like that. His other hand touched my hip. God, I wanted him to touch me!

And then I woke up. Reality came crashing into my brain. I did shove R away. I told him I couldn’t. It could not happen! I have a husband and I love him and I was not going to do

that to him! It was wrong. I couldn't be that person. R had to stop. We had to stop.

R stood there and let me rage at him. And he didn't try to stop me when I grabbed my bag and my purse and ran out of the office. I sat in my car and cried so hard I thought my lungs would burst. HORRIBLE SLUT! FUCKING TRAMP! What the hell was I doing? Married women do not kiss strange men! I DO NOT KISS STRANGE MEN! But I do, don't I? I let Dane kiss me all those years ago. I'd been playing games with R for weeks. What did I think was going to happen?

Travis. Oh god! It makes me sick to think of him. Here he is, all excited to take me to Paris, to reignite our spark and celebrate our anniversary, and here am I, kissing another man at work. Travis, always there, always loyal. Travis, who would always stand by me. And what was I? I was a SLUT.

Thank god I am getting away from R. I am going to use this time to get my head straight and get our marriage back on track. And I am going to send R an email and tell him it can never, ever happen again! I'm not who he thinks I am. I can't be.

I must have read the passage three times. Maybe four. Hard to tell because after the second read, I jumped around, skipping to read things that titillated my lust as much as it churned in my gut.

I don't know if a kiss ever made me feel like that! It hurt to read, couldn't stop me from comparing myself to Rick and feeling like I came up short, yet it was intoxicating. Like I'd chugged a fifth of whiskey or something.

There was also a fatalism to the way she wrote about the kiss. She was expecting it. Maybe even looking forward to it. It *finally* happened. She wasn't even shocked. She thrashed and moaned with the guilt of it, but if she was truly guilty, she wouldn't have let things get there, right?

But that wasn't fair, because she was guilt-ridden. She was regretful. She let herself get carried away, but when she remembered me, she felt awful. The irony here was that if she just told me, she could have relieved that. But then again, if she'd just told me, I'm not sure it would have been quite as exciting.

Annie was the kind of woman who always anticipated the needs of others. Her empathy made her a great social worker, and later a great journalist. But it also made her more prone to doing things for others rather than herself. What was so exciting about this thing was Rick was exactly what made it wrong—she was doing it completely, indisputably for herself.

The phone call snapped me out of my contemplation. Calls were such a rare thing these days that the ring through the house was like a raid siren or something. I looked at the time. 8 o'clock. Annie calling to check in.

"How was today?"

"Good," Annie said. She sounded exhausted. "We got some great interviews. Oh, Travis, the situation here's so complicated."

"It always is," I said, feeling the double meaning, and hoping that she didn't. "When it's all politics, it's easy to see things abstractly."

"Yes!" Annie said. "Don't get me wrong. I don't agree with the policies. On a broad level, you know where I stand. But when I'm actually talking to actual *people*, I'm not thinking of it like it's a party platform or something. I see the consequences, I see the repercussions. It's hard to see things as so black and white after that."

"So how did you sleep last night?" It felt like a balloon was trying to escape my chest through my throat.

"Not so well. Got up at 3:30. Tried to get back to sleep, but eventually I gave up and went down to the gym." She laughed. "Kind of spooky to work out with the gym all to yourself, but it passed the time."

"You must be tired."

"I am, but I'm not. Something about hearing the stories from all these good men and women has given me a boost. Reminds me of my days in social work."

"And you call yourself an introvert," I said with a chuckle.

"I'm the girl with the recorder, remember? I'm not out there talking in front of huge crowds of psyche nerds, like someone I happen to know."

"Well, I'm happy that you're happy." I paused, unsure of how to push things forward. And why did things suddenly feel so awkward between us?

“You done for the day?”

“Yes, done. Thank God. I think we’re grabbing a bite to eat somewhere, to go over what we have so far.”

We. Rick and Annie. *A bite to eat* sounded like forced casualness, too, but I also recognized that I was getting a bit paranoid.

“Sounds good. I won’t keep you then. Have a good night, Annie. Talk to you tomorrow.”

I grabbed the diary almost before the line was dead. There was more. Almost two months more. And I wasn’t going to bed before I did so. Not that I thought anything would beat the kiss, or the revelations of Dane, but after chatting with Annie on the phone and imagining her out there in San Francisco, going out with Rick, the build up to the trip would help me understand how close she was.

Little did I know.

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Chapter 13

I read the entries immediately after The Kiss without truly reading them. My mind was still wrestling with the two timelines—back in July with the illicit kiss at work, and what was happening right now, out in California. She didn't bring her diary to Paris, so there weren't any entries from the trip, but she'd written almost immediately upon return. Most of it was more agonizing over her guilt, reassurances that she loved me, and vows to put Rick behind her.

She was particularly concerned with the award ceremony, where I'd meet him for the first time. "He's going to know. How can he not?" She tried getting out of it and lamented when she could not. Of course, it came and went, he hooked up with Lisa, which eventually led to their second kiss outside her car in the parking garage.

That happened September 9. A whole week passed before she wrote another.

Saturday, September 14

I feel like Alice down the rabbit hole. My world feels completely different now, and the only place I feel sane is on the back of Ruby. Riding this morning was the only time I've felt calm all week. R took what happened by the car as a green light, and why shouldn't he? It's not like I smacked him when he kissed me, or told him to get away. I didn't report him to HR. I weakly told him I had to go. He had to have felt how that kiss affected me. He had to know I wanted it as much as he did. SLUT! It was all laid to rest, but then the Lisa (guess I can't really think of her as a slut anymore, can I?) thing happened, and I exposed myself, and R jumped right in there. The second kiss was like Alice deciding to drink the potion, only I didn't realize I was making a choice in that moment. It felt like it was just happening to me.

I think I've avoided writing in this diary all week because I didn't want to face my own behavior. So this is going to be a long one.

I didn't see R the following morning. I think he was waiting to see if I would come to him. I didn't of course. The last thing I needed was to see him with everything going on inside me. I couldn't even look Travis in the eye the night before. How was I going to face R?

My luck didn't hold out all day. R caught me when I was coming in from lunch. I was about to go into the building when he called out my name. It felt like he'd been waiting for me. I froze with my hand on the door pull. I could have darted inside and pretended I didn't hear him, but I stayed frozen long enough for him to catch me. He grabbed my arm, not hard enough to hurt, but forcefully enough to signal he wasn't letting go. R said, "Don't you think we should talk?"

So we took a walk, meandering through the city streets, silent for the first five minutes. I think he was waiting for me to start, but if that was the case, the walk would have taken all day. R finally started, stating, "There's obviously something happening between us."

I tried to tell him it couldn't happen, but R didn't want to hear it. He knew my arguments, and he understood, but he insisted it was happening whether I was married or not. He said he knew I wanted him and asked how long I was going to try and fight it. I started telling him as long as I need to, but...

He kissed me again! R pulled me into a doorway and kissed me, his palm pressed to my cheek. It flipped a switch inside me, igniting a furnace. If my resistance was weaker the second time R kissed me, it was nonexistent the third time. My eyes fluttered closed and I gave into him eagerly. I held onto his arm and parted my lips when his tongue

flickered across them. He pushed me against a little alcove and I went.

Oh my god! Kissing him is so hot! I was on fire, but it gave me the chills all the way down to my toes. I swear, each kiss has gotten better. R has turned me into a shameless slut! He kissed me right there in the open, and not only didn't I fight him, I pulled him closer and held him and ran my fingers through that wonderful, thick hair of his. The kiss had my heart beating so fast, it made me dizzy. He pulled back and we just stared at each other, and then I kissed him! I wanted to climb into his lap. I wanted to be all over him—and that was just from a kiss.

I feel like R has turned me into a gushing teenager, and it's embarrassing, but these feelings are so weird. It really does make me feel like I did when I first discovered boys—all excited and scared and horny and dying for just a kiss, or better yet, a touch. I'm a grown woman. A mother. A wife. But kissing R in some alcove right along the street in the middle of the day turned me back into a fearful, trembling teenager.

It was all the same old emotions, but for very different reasons—sort of. The excitement is because a cute boy likes me. I guess that never changes, does it? The fear is fear of getting caught because I'm doing something I shouldn't be. I felt the same as a teenager too, but now getting caught means something very different. It's not fear of getting pregnant (god forbid!) or of letting my parents down. Getting caught this time would not mean a lecture from my parents.

Oh god, Travis. I wish he wasn't such a great father and sweet husband. I wish I could claim an excuse for my behavior, other than I want it and I can't help myself. If Travis was mean, or truly neglectful, I could try and make myself feel better by telling myself he deserves this. But none of that is true. Travis deserves a loyal, faithful wife. I think of

my husband and I am overwhelmed by guilt, but then I think of R, and I'm filled with something else.

R's hands were strong, but gentle. He respected me enough not to grope me in public, but he came close enough to give me a taste of what I could have. I knew the game he was playing. He saw my weakness and figured it was only a matter of pushing the right buttons, and I would give myself to him fully. I get why he felt that way. I was flushed and shaky when we finally pulled apart. And soaking wet, but he didn't know that part. I actually showed some restraint on that score. If I was that aroused with Travis, I would have just seduced him. He wouldn't have stood a chance. But I did just resist begging R to take me to a hotel. Maybe that's why the first words out of my mouth were so crazy. I had to assert myself.

"I'm not going to fuck you," I said, very matter-of-fact. R laughed, and soon I was laughing too. I still can't believe I said that. Cursing in general is so not me, and doing it in polite company is something I would never do. R is already bringing out all kinds of new things in me.

I insisted that I meant it, and R said he could respect that, but it didn't mean he wanted me any less. He also said there were lots of things we could do without fucking. That gave me the chills, because it took me back to those younger days when I was trying to maintain my virtue, but boys were trying to get into my pants, and it was an internal struggle to keep them out.

Why do we hold girls to such silly standards? Even now, boys are expected to be walking raging hormones, while girls are expected to be the gatekeepers when it comes to sex. I'm glad I never put such unrealistic expectations on Olivia. Typical Travis, he wanted nothing to do with "The Talk." He probably still thinks she's a virgin. I had the talk with Olivia very early on purpose, and thought offering to

get her on the pill was the responsible thing to do, as long as she promised she would still always use condoms. Not that I wanted her running around irresponsibly having sex, but I didn't want her to be afraid or ashamed of it, the way I was taught to feel. Somehow those lessons from Mom were lost on Lisa, but she always went her own way. I was always more apt to behave.

Do I regret behaving myself so much when I was younger? I was no saint, but I was hardly the class slut either—even if I had deep yearnings to be. If I had felt free of consequences and morality, how would I have behaved? Would I have been like my sister? I think I became a blowjob specialist because I understood how it felt to go home feeling extremely frustrated. Even when I let a boy get a hand up my skirt back then, they hardly knew what they were doing. Their blind fumbling rarely got me off, and I was too timid to show them how to do it.

And now as a grown woman, temptation has reared its head again, and it seems I am not quite up to the challenge. I'm more sexually confident as a woman than I ever was a girl, but my desires haven't changed. If anything, the myth about a midlife sexual peak seem to be all too true in my case. And R has perfect timing.

I paused here, my heart racing, my cock hard. If a simple kiss like this hit me profoundly, how would I feel once she got back from California and learned that she'd done *so much more*? Not to mention the setting—they were in public this time. It was dangerous. Risky. Completely irresponsible. That it was Annie being so irresponsible made it all even sexier.

I went back to reading the same, long entry.

Once the dam was cracked that day, I found myself giving into him easily. We took lunch together every day that week. We only made it to a restaurant that first day. I used to hate

how huge the Infiniti Travis convinced me to buy is. It always felt like driving a tank. Now I appreciate the room. R's little sports coupe is way too small for any kind of backseat fun. That first day he led me to the parking garage, I knew what he was up to, and I was full of butterflies. The tingling that swarmed my body quieted the alarm and (I'm ashamed to admit) my guilt. R took the fob from my hand and clicked open the locks. I meekly climbed into the backseat.

Oh my god! It was such a rush! Can every new kiss keep getting hotter? That's not possible, right? We were all over each other in a rush of lips and hands. It's kind of a fervid, sexy blur to me now, but I trembled when R unbuttoned my shirt. I reached back and unhooked my bra for him. His mouth on my breasts was unreal. My nipples were throbbing! I don't know where I found the willpower to stop him when he tried unsnapping my pants. He unsnapped his own, and put my hand down them. I love how R takes control. He felt so big, so hard through his boxers. I barely passed the test that day.

I swear I didn't consciously think about it when I dressed the next morning, but I wore that A-line dress for a reason. R is VERY good with his hands. I don't know if I ever came so fast from someone just touching me like that. He didn't have to put my hand anywhere that day, and I didn't resist when he nudged my head toward his lap. He's every bit as big as I suspected he'd be. All I can say is, Wow! What a challenge! R was patient with me, but I had to remember how to really relax to take care of one that big. I'm impressed with myself that only a little escaped my lips.

The whole week went like that, but I kept my word. I did not sleep with R. And when he suggested we go to a hotel on Friday, I said no. When he slipped out of the car at the end of the day (2x times in the backseat those last couple days!),

all I could think was that I had to wait until Monday to see R again.

Yes, I am a cheating slut. I cannot confess to being an unrepentant one, however. When I walked through the door and saw Travis at the end of the day, my stomach dropped, and I wanted to run out of the room. I was sure he would see something different about me. He had to see my scarlet letter. How could he not see what a slut I'd become? But he didn't. Travis went right on like everything was normal, and that just made me feel worse. When he reached for me, I wanted to pull away. I knew I was unclean. But I was so damned horny from maintaining my chastity with R, I didn't resist Travis for a second. Does it make up for my unfaithfulness that Travis suddenly had an insatiable wife? I wish. He would not appreciate the real reason why I told him I couldn't wait until we got upstairs and bent over the counter for him.

I know the counter cannot hold. I cannot maintain this double life. But I also cannot control myself around R. I don't know what to do.

Stunned. That left me stunned. Every part. Every revelation. *We only made it to the restaurant that first day... I reached back and unhooked my bra for him... I had to remember how to really relax to take care of one that big...*

Annie hadn't been a good girl at all, leading up to California. She hadn't held out, despite how much she told herself that she was. They'd fooled around in the car. They'd gotten naked together. In the car!

She'd sucked his cock and swallowed his come. In all the years we'd been married, I could count the number of times she'd actually swallowed my come on one hand. It wasn't something that good girls do—at least not with their husbands. It made me wonder about before, though, about our “gap” year when she was just having fun. Had she swallowed associate professor Brian Hoffman's load? Would she have swallowed Dane's, had he made it that far?

She'd been so bad, and I had no idea. Until that moment, I'd figured that she may have kissed him again, a time or two, but that was it.

I skimmed the post again. Second time, after the shock, I noticed a second thing she kept going back to—his size. Rick's size. He was big, and that made her insatiable. *I barely passed the test that day*, she'd written. Bizarrely, I found myself simultaneously rooting for Rick and rooting for my wife to resist.

There was one, final entry in the diary I had. I read on.

Monday, September 16

R announced in the morning staff meeting that we are going to California next week for a follow-up to the sanctuary cities story. Color me surprised/not surprised. I am surprised it's coming so quickly. R probably doesn't want me to get cold feet. I know it's paranoid, but it feels like he has this master plan to seduce me. He wore me down, I gave into his advances, but drew a line. And now, he's taking me to the other side of the country where he'll have me all to himself, with two convenient hotel rooms. There better be two hotel rooms!

What am I going to do? I can't very well say no, and R knows that. The immigration issue is far too important for me to let my personal problems get in the way of covering it—covering people doing good work and the consequences they face. R's reasons for coming with me are weak, but I know I'll never convince him to stay back. I'm going to have to go and find my backbone and stick to my word.

I don't know if I'm more scared or excited. Once the shock of R's announcement wore off, and I got past how much work I'm going to have to do to prepare, my mind went to all the dark and dirty places it visits when I think about R. We'll have a whole week together. Yes, we'll be working long hours, but we'll also be together all the time. I won't be coming home to Travis at the end of the day, but a hotel

where R will only be a few feet away. I know I won't behave myself, not really, but can I hang onto that last shred of control? Will I want to? Even now, I'm not sure I want to, but I know I have to.

Travis. How is he going to feel about my going away for a week so suddenly? He doesn't seem to suspect anything, but that doesn't mean he wants me jetting off for a week. He won't stand in my way, but I'm sure he won't be happy. Or maybe he will save me from myself and suggest we put it off.

R and I did not meet for lunch today. Too much to do. But we did have a hot make out session in the garage. Hot make out session. I really do sound like a smitten teenager.

Annie was holding out on Rick *for me*. Not for herself. Not really. She may tell herself that, but her mind went to “dark and dirty places” when she thinks about him. She was counting on me to get her back on track. Oh, the irony.

It was good to read, though. She wasn't being malicious. She really did care about me—at least enough to feel guilty. In another world, in other circumstances, maybe we could have worked out an arrangement. We were both into this, but neither of us were willing to share that dark secret with the other.

It was hard to sleep that night, especially with Annie's diary on my nightstand. I went back to it a number of times throughout the night, when I couldn't sleep, reading the slow erosion of Annie's resistance.

It was somewhere in the middle of that night that I had my epiphany. I was reading, once again, about how they fooled around in the car, hard and hot as it was, I wished I could have seen that. Wished that I could have heard it. Half asleep, I grabbed my phone and made an impulse purchase, one I completely forgot about by the time I finally fell asleep.

Chapter 14

The International Herald had an Instagram account. I discovered it on Tuesday, when I was poking around their site, looking for...I don't know. Incriminating photos of Annie with Rick, maybe?

Of course there was nothing incriminating about the photos, but there were a couple of Annie, taken from just yesterday. "Our own Annie Belmont, following up on her award-winning series in SF," followed by a link to the sanctuary city series.

It was the photo that I focused on. She was dressed down in a pair of jeans and a sleeveless, knit top, that, while not sexy in any overt way, did mold to the fullness of her breasts. It had to have been a deliberate choice, too. What had she said in that diary entry? Something about knit tops being "nice and clingy"? I recognized this one. The burgundy color set her hair off, and it had a high neckline with a narrow, plunging V that was modest, most of the time. Unless she bent forward and you could look down her shirt just right, and it showed a lot more.

In this photo, of course, she wasn't bending forward provocatively. She was crouched down, her arm around the shoulder of a Salvadoran child as the boy laughed.

That photo, however, got me wondering about other ways that I could catch a glimpse of what was happening over there *now*, since I had no more diary entries until she was back. I scoured the rest of the Instagram feed, but that was the only photo from her trip. So far.

There were some photos of her receiving her award, though, looking glowing in her dress. There was even one of her standing next to Rick, who had a hand behind her back. They looked like a couple, I thought. An attractive couple. The comments didn't exactly back me up, but they did call out how good looking they thought the two were. *Wow, the Herald should get into video, and As beautiful as she is thought-provoking.*

I checked Facebook, but at first I didn't see anything to get my blood pumping, on either Annie's or Rick's accounts. Annie wasn't all that active beyond Shares and Likes, and Rick mostly posted photos of food and scenery. It was only at the end of the day that I went back to Rick's feed and took a closer look at the photos.

Sure enough, the most recent snapshot of food was posted yesterday—a chicken dish, the presentation professional and expensive looking. The caption attached was also telling: “Beautiful dinner amidst beautiful company.”

Now, I didn’t know that he had dinner with Annie—not at the time, anyway. He could have met up with a bunch of friends out in San Francisco, and anyone reading it would likely come to a similarly innocuous conclusion. But to me, it struck home.

On my way home, I had a thought. A very bad, very wrong thought—what if I broke into Annie’s iCloud account and read her texts. The only thing that stopped me, I’m ashamed to admit, was when I got home and experimented with my own iCloud account and discovered that it alerted my phone that I’d done it.

I did go through her older diaries, but nothing was quite as powerful as the newer things. I found a couple things she wrote around the time of the Dane incident, and unlike her justification of what’s going on with Rick, she was completely horrified by the kiss with Dane at the time. She debated telling me numerous times, and apparently came very close to confessing about a month after, but chickened out.

What I was more interested in was what went on in the year we were apart, but the diaries she kept in the closet didn’t go back that far. I wondered about that. Had she hidden them? Destroyed them? Or just not started the diary until we got together more seriously. As far as I could recall, she’d always kept one, but maybe they got lost in the move.

Or maybe they were filled with things that she wanted to erase from time. What a thrilling thought.

What I did find, when looking around for those older diaries, was Annie’s old iPad. At first, I didn’t think much of it. In fact, Annie and I had already said our goodnights and I was in bed, settling in for another fitful night, when it occurred to me—Annie’s iPad may still have her iMessages account loaded into it.

My fingers actually shook as I retrieved the tablet. The batteries had died long ago, so I plugged it into a cord and let it power up, waiting impatiently. After trying a few of Annie’s known pin numbers, I got in. It was almost too easy. My stomach quivered. I held my breath and hit the Messages app. Honestly, I didn’t expect much. It had been a while since

she'd used this, and I wasn't sure if she ever properly set up the program anyway.

But she had. And like that, I had access to all of her texts. In many ways, it was more exciting than unlocking her diary. This meant keeping tabs on her in real time. It was also such a terrible invasion of her privacy, but hey, she was the one fraternizing with attractive, younger men.

I found her message thread with Rick—"Rick Archer" because Apple made everything formal like that, and for a second, I wasn't sure that I could bring myself to actually open it.

But of course I did.

[Annie]: Okay, all set.

[Rick]: Meet you in the lobby.

The last two texts were time stamped last night, around 8 o'clock California time. I pulled up the food photo that Rick had posted last night. 8:32 pm. It checked out. They'd had dinner last night.

I swept upward, glancing through the rest of the texts, but disappointingly, they were about as banal and innocuous as the first ones, and unlike those first ones, I had no context. They texted about heading to the airport Sunday. They coordinated sharing a cab from SFO to their hotel. Annie texted him Monday morning when she was down in the lobby, ready to head out. It was all business, all coordination and logistics. Not even a single emoji was used.

But as I looked closer at the exchanges, I noticed that chunks were missing. Going back further, there were large gaps when nothing was exchanged. Like their conversation had been sterilized. Like she was deleting messages.

As if on cue, a new message came in, and as the iPad rumbled in my hands, I nearly dropped it.

[Rick]: So how about that drink?

I stared at the text for the longest time, holding my breath. Waiting. Then came Annie's reply.

[Annie]: Okay, but just one. Still pretty full from that dinner.

[Rick]: That was so nice of them to host us, but honestly, I would have preferred just you and me, like last night.

[Annie]: Rick...

[Rick]: Oh come on. I know you had fun last night, too.

[Annie]: Don't make me reconsider that drink.

[Rick]: I'm already downstairs. Have a spot right next to me at the bar. Should I have a margarita waiting for you? Or I could bring it up to your room.

[Annie]: I'll be down in a few minutes.

And then, like magic, the texts disappeared from her history, one by one, until the record was gone. It was so wrong. I almost took a screenshot, just so I could look back on it and know that I really had seen it. Instead, I left the iPad to charge and went to bed.

In the morning, of course, there was nothing new.

*

I took the iPad into work with me that Wednesday, checking it compulsively, like a gambler checking the sports scores. I saw no texts going in or out, but that only meant that they hadn't texted while I was looking.

The day wore on, distracted. I wrote some reports, double checked them, was disgusted by the number of typos and errors I'd made. I shut out Annie and Rick and focused in on my work. I even put away the iPad, as much as it killed me, but it was what I needed. The day slipped by at last, and before I knew it, the sun was setting and I was still at work.

Annie called me before I'd left. This was their last day in San Francisco, and they'd be getting up early tomorrow to fly down to LA.

"At least you're still jetlagged, so early isn't *that* early."

"Yeah, bonus there," Annie said, unconvinced. "Unfortunately, I think the jetlag has just about worn off."

“Oh yeah? Forcing yourself to stay up to get used to it?” It felt like a dangerous and thrilling thing to ask.

“Yeah. Well, sort of. Drinking coffee at five o’clock just to stay awake through an interview probably has more to do with it.”

“That’ll do it.” Things felt awkward between us. I fidgeted, reaching under my papers and absent-mindedly flipping open the cover of her iPad. “So you hit the ground running in LA?”

“Yeah. We’re meeting with law enforcement first...” She went on, giving me the highlights of her itinerary there. My focus, however, drifted to the new texts that had popped up on the iPad.

[Rick]: so should i rsvp for this black tie thing saturday?

[Annie]: I still don't have anything to wear.

[Rick]: and i told you, you'd look great in anything. just wear that black suit you wore yesterday. put your hair up. you're gorgeous. no one will notice.

[Annie]: Oh no, I'm not going to be the old lady dressed in a pantsuit at an LA party.

[Rick]: then buy a dress. i'll even help you shop for one. ;)

[Annie]: What a generous offer, but I'm capable myself.

[Rick]: a surprise then. i love surprises. especially when they involve stockings.

[Annie]: lol You're too much.

[Rick]: :P

“Trav? You there?”

“Uh, yeah. Sorry, got distracted by a...thing.”

I heard her silence loud and clear. She was frustrated.

The back of my neck burned. “Sorry, what were you saying?”

“Nothing important.”

The text stream moved on the iPad.

[Annie]: I'm in. Just need to get a dress.

[Rick]: and stockings. don't forget about stockings.

"So you come back Monday?" I asked, focusing things back on the phone call.

"Yeah, Monday late, though. And then we've got the Tuesday production day. I'm so not looking forward to that." She sounded distant, and a moment later, I knew why. She was typing.

[Annie]: We'll see about that.

[Rick]: i hope we do see.

[Annie]: ...

[Rick]: Drink?

"I should get going," I said. "I'm still at work. Need to grab a bite to eat."

"You're not just eating take out every night, are you?"

"Maybe...?"

The Annie that laughed was the old Annie I knew, sweet and smart and slightly disapproving of my unhealthy habits.

[Annie]: Sure. Why not.

That Annie was not her.

"Well, get a salad then. Stay away from the fried chicken, okay?"

"Salad it is."

*

Thursday and Friday rolled by without much incident, although I knew this black tie event, whatever that was, loomed large. I intercepted a few texts, but nothing too incriminating.

[Rick]: that patrol officer was staring at your tits the whole interview

[Annie]: He wasn't the only one.

[Rick]: you noticed?

[Annie]: I always notice, dear. You're not as subtle as you think.

[Rick]: i blame the top.

[Annie]: Uh huh.

There wasn't any talk of getting drinks, or buying dresses, or stockings. All of that could have—probably was—talked about offline. Most of the exchanges were logistics, the kind she kept on her phone and didn't delete.

We talked, discussing our days and saying goodnight, but things felt distant. I wondered what was going on in her head. I should have just asked her—that's what normal people do—but instead, I cursed that I didn't have her diary. That I couldn't invade her private thoughts like some creep.

But then again, I also knew what was going on. She was conflicted. She enjoyed the attention she was getting from Rick, but also hated how much she enjoyed it. I had no idea if she'd crossed any lines, but if she hadn't, Saturday night at the gala was going to be a real test.

Saturday crawled. I did some hard work, tried getting Annie and Rick out of my head. It was hard, though, especially with the messages they exchanged Saturday morning.

[Annie]: Got a dress.

[Rick]: color?

[Annie]: Black.

[Rick]: to match your lingerie?

[Annie]: You'll just have to wait and see.

[Rick]: you're such a tease. send me a pic.

[Annie]: Now that's a line that I'm not going to cross.

[Rick]: you've said that before ;)

[Rick]: just get snapchat

[Annie]: I feel like even YOU are too old for that app. Pretty sure it's designed so people my age can't understand it.

[Rick]: nah, it's not so bad. i'll teach you.

And that was the last time I eavesdropped on a text message conversation between Rick and Annie.

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Chapter 15

Saturday evening, I went out. I couldn't stay at home, wallowing in that weird intersection of jealousy and excitement, thinking about the dress she'd purchased for Rick or the evening she was spending as his date. She still hadn't told me about the gala, so I couldn't even ask her about it.

So I just got in my car and drove, without a destination in mind. I considered a movie, but nothing great was showing. I considered a strip club, then remembered that I'd only been to a strip club when I was twenty and wouldn't know the first thing about them. I ended up going to some bar—I don't even know the name of it—and having a drink as I people watched.

People watching was fun, watching the crowd flirt and mingle and talk. This crowd skewed older, closer to my age. Closer to Annie's age. This was the life that Annie could have had, if she was single. She was still full of life, still so beautiful and vibrant and now more confident in herself than ever.

I watched one encounter in particular—a woman with dark hair and pale skin, who reminded me a little of my neighbor, Jessica, and another man, ten years older and full of swagger. I didn't think they knew one another at the beginning of the evening. Judging from their body language, they were just getting to know one another at first. By the end of the night, though, they stood close, their hands touching subtly, their conversation hushed and intimate. And by the end, they left together.

That, more than anything, got me thinking about Annie. To see her in that situation, to watch her flirt and get picked up, would have been amazing.

But I couldn't have that. Not tonight. Tonight, things were out of my hands. I couldn't stop things now, even if I wanted to.

I was a cuckold—not just in that literal sense, but in the fetishized version of it. I could admit that now. I got off on the idea of my wife cheating on me. I didn't want to be humiliated. I didn't want others to know. I didn't want Annie or Rick to rub it on my face, but I was a cuckold, and that fact in and of itself was a form of humiliation. These two were going out to dinner together nearly every night, spending so much time together,

flirting and growing close and, most likely, fucking each other. Behind my back. It was a humiliation, no matter how you cut it.

But I loved it. It was like a drug. I wanted more of it. Was this how the harder cuck was born? Right now, she was fucking in hotel rooms. Next would it be in our marital bed as I watched, tied to a chair? It felt like a drug addiction, spiraling deeper and darker until I didn't recognize myself. Where was rock bottom, and could I stop myself before I hit it?

It was past eleven by the time I got home. Eight o'clock in LA. The black tie gala was in full swing. My stomach cratered as my temporary respite fled. I checked the iPad, but she hadn't exchanged a message since the suggestion of Snapchat—which had been deleted.

[Me]: Headed to sleep. Have a good night.

I didn't get an immediate response, and eventually, I fell asleep.

*

I don't know if I got any sleep that night. Sunday was a blur. I didn't actually get a reply text from Annie until close to noon.

[Annie]: Sorry, just saw this. My phone actually ran out of batteries last night. Just one more day!

I read it like a relief. Like there was a possibility that maybe she wouldn't come home at all. Or that when she did, she'd stay with Rick. But she wasn't going to. Rick wasn't a threat. Not like that. He wanted to keep things open. And why not? He was fucking two sisters, plus probably others. Why settle?

[Me]: One more day. I miss you so much.

[Annie]: I miss you, too. Can't wait to get home. You better be ready for me. ;)

That wasn't like her, but I liked it.

[Me]: I'll make sure I get plenty of rest for you.

She went sightseeing on that last day. A free day. I knew because of the photos she sent me. A photo of her posing in front of the Hollywood sign, or along the star walk, or before a row of palm trees.

Each time my phone buzzed, I buzzed right along with it. I studied those pictures. Annie wasn't alone. Someone else was taking them, and I had a pretty good idea who. She wore a tight pair of jeans and a short-sleeved, turquoise blouse that I loved because of the amount of cleavage it showed, given the right angle. In one photo, I could see the strap of her bra if I zoomed in, her turquoise one that matched her shirt and, I knew because I bought it for her, was constructed of padded lace and did devastating things to her tits.

It wasn't lost on me that the photos stopped coming around one in the afternoon, and that evening, Rick didn't post any snapshots of his dinner.

Once again, I didn't sleep well, tossing and turning as I thought about another man enjoying the charms of my wife—and fighting off the hardon and the urge to masturbate. I almost gave in, but wanted to be ready when Annie returned to me. After enjoying Rick and his monster cock, I needed all the pent-up energy I could spare to compete.

I had no idea what tomorrow would bring. Once I saw her again, would I be able to look her in the eye? She'd betrayed me. She was sneaking around behind my back. There was nothing about this experience that was mutual—at least not from her perspective. We weren't a team experiencing something new. Her actions were completely, wholly selfish and self-serving. As she wrote again and again, she was “such a slut.”

But what kept me up wasn't disgust or anger or jealous rage. It was excitement. It was awe. It was that Christmas Eve anticipation that tomorrow, Annie would be coming home.

Chapter 16

Monday, homecoming, I was a tangle of nervous energy. I hadn't felt this anxious to see Annie for over two decades, back when she finally graduated and we got back together. It was like meeting her again for the first time. It was first date jitters.

I took off early, doing one last sweep of the house. In the rush to get her diaries back in order, I almost forgot to replace the iPad. I almost forgot where I even found her iPad, but figured she probably wouldn't remember exactly where it was, either.

There was one last task to deal with, one that I kept putting off out of shame or guilt or fear. The package had arrived last Friday from Amazon, but I hadn't even opened it yet. That's how conflicted I was. Inside was a voice-activated audio recorder that cost less than \$100—the means of modern eavesdropping and invasion of privacy were apparently shockingly cheap. Annie wouldn't even notice the bill.

I'd been thinking about how to hear them, how to witness their lust first hand. Only there was no way of knowing when or where it happened. Except that I didn't need to know exactly when, and I knew where—Annie's Infiniti.

I wasn't proud of it, but I also was overwhelmed with excitement as I duct taped the recorder to the bottom of her passenger side seat of her QX-60. I tested it, sitting in the back seat. "This is roomier than I thought it would be," I said, imagining Annie and Rick naked back here. My stomach bottomed out as I played it back. It was crystal clear.

I took a shower—a cold shower—shaved and styled my hair. Brushed my teeth. Again, I thought of the first date analogy, and along with that, the fear that maybe, this time, I wouldn't be what she expected.

Which was insane to think, because if anyone should have that fear, it's her, right?

On a lark, I pulled the "Welcome Home!" banner that we'd bought when Olivia first came home from college over winter break, pinning it up over the front door, right where the up lights would hit it.

I got there before her flight arrived, and positioned myself at the terminal exit. Her text came first.

[Annie]: Just landed. Out soon.

I didn't text her back. Didn't give her a warning that I was waiting. Rick was probably on her same flight, and I wanted to see how they emerged together. This was the cuckold impulse in me, a lash that I couldn't help flagellating myself with.

Rick was on the same flight as her, but they didn't come out holding hands. Or even standing all that close to one another. Both looked exhausted, pulling their roller bags behind them along with the other cross-country commuters. Rick looked like he hadn't shaved since he'd left, his scruff dark and rugged, changing him from frat boy to worldly, National Geographic photographer. Annie's hair was tied back in a messy bun. She wore glasses and a baggy sweatshirt over her jeans.

Yet despite her travel-weariness, she practically shined in my eyes. Especially when she looked up from her thoughts and saw me waiting just beyond the gate. The smile she gave me dispelled all my fears that I'd lost her to another man. She didn't quite drop her bag and run for me, but she did speed up, pulling away from Rick to fall into my arms and a deep, prolonged hug.

With a big sigh, she whispered, "I missed you so much."

"I missed you, too." She smelled good. She felt better. I ached for her, and the way her breasts pushed against me didn't help.

Rick caught up to us as we separated—but only just. I felt heat climb up my neck and into my face, now that I was face-to-face with her probable lover. But he didn't sneer or puff out his chest or act like an asshole. Instead, he stuck out his hand.

"Good to see you again, Travis."

"Hey, Rick." I shook it, firm but not too firm. "You guys have a successful trip?"

He didn't bat an eyelash. "Very. Your wife has a way with people. I'm actually thinking we turn some of the audio we captured into a podcast."

He was so cool, so collected, that I began to doubt that anything had happened. Maybe some flirting. Maybe some risqué back and forth. But maybe all of this was in my head after all, despite the things I'd read.

"Sounds amazing," I said.

We moved toward the baggage claim together as Annie told me some of the things they'd learned. They did a ride-along with some ICE officials

that really struck her. Nothing was clear cut. Nothing was simple.

Rick got his bag first, and for a second, I wondered if he expected a ride. When he wheeled his bags away, I breathed a sigh of relief. “I’ll see you tomorrow, Annie. But probably in the afternoon. I plan on sleeping *late*. And you should, too. You earned it.”

I wouldn’t have noticed it if I hadn’t been looking for it—the way her eyes slid away, the slight tint of color that climbed up her neck. “Thanks. I think I may take you up on that offer.”

“Nice seeing you again, Travis.”

He left, and out of the corner of my eye, I caught Annie watching him go, her expression unreadable.

Alone, things started to feel awkward between us again. Although maybe that was all in my head. I’d been having all these crazy thoughts, living with the crazy fantasy, pining over the idea of an unfaithful wife, and now that she was back, I didn’t know what to do.

We collected her bag, took it to the parking garage. Headed home. We talked vaguely about her trip some more, or what I did while she was gone. I told her I’d finally repainted the mailbox and pruned the rose bush, but as we sat in the car, together at last, I could feel the weight of something profound pressing around us. Pressure. Stifling, intense pressure.

“So your flight was good?”

“Yeah. Slept most of the way. I’m so exhausted.”

“I bet. Long week.”

She nodded, staring out the window, lost in her thoughts the rest of the ride home.

I should have broached the subject. I almost did. *So I know about you and Rick*. The statement was right there on the tip of my tongue, ready to emerge. Only that damn pressure kept it in. I couldn’t. I didn’t want to. I wanted to keep riding this dangerous high. I wanted to see where it went.

We pulled into our driveway, and at first, Annie just sat there, staring up at our colonial. If I didn’t know better, I thought she might start to cry. I ignored that on purpose, acting like a clueless buffoon. I jumped out of the car and unloaded her bags from the trunk.

Annie emerged tentatively, like she was much older than her 43 years, and when she looked past me, to the colorful Welcome Home banner, she did start to cry. And they were not tears of happiness.

I folded her into my arms and pretended that they were. “Welcome home, honey. If you were gone any longer, I’m pretty sure McDonalds would have put my name on one of their booths.

She sobbed out a laugh, sniffed hard, and said, “You did *not* eat at McDonalds all week, did you?”

I laughed. “All you said was no fried chicken.”

Annie laughed again through her sniffles. She turned to me, hugging me tightly. “God, I love you so much.”

The affirmation was almost as much for her as it was for me.

“Why don’t we go inside and you can show me how much you love me.”

She brightened, pulling herself from her funk through sheer force of will. When she looked up at me, I could almost believe that dark cloud was gone. But then, I still felt all that pressure.

I’d only been gone for about an hour, total, but as we entered the house, it had that empty, abandoned feel, like a house left on the market for too long. As soon as Annie stepped in and filled it with her presence, I realized that it had been like this all week. That I’d been alone, and now I was not.

I shut the door as Annie looked around, assessing the place like she was seeing it for the first time.

“I vacuumed,” I said.

“I can tell. The place looks great.”

“You were only gone a week.”

“Felt like a year,” she said.

“Yeah.” I stepped up to her, pulling her into my arms from behind. “And I don’t think I can wait another minute.”

“You want me to shower? I’ve been in a plane for almost seven hours.”

“Will a shower take longer than a minute?”

Annie laughed. “Showers can be fun.”

“Let’s do that after, then.” I tugged at the bottom of her sweatshirt. “Right now, I need you.”

When I pulled it off, Annie didn’t stop me. Beneath, she wore a tight, white cami top that didn’t cover much of the turquoise bra she wore from yesterday.

She turned in my arms, even as I pulled at the base of her top. When I pulled it off, her red hair fell from its loose bun, spilling alluringly around

her freckled face. I kissed her hotly, touching her face with one hand as I rubbed her shoulder blades with the other.

“You got some sun out there,” I said. Her freckles had blossomed the way they did in the summer, but more than that, she actually did have some color in her normally pale complexion.

“We were outside a lot. All the time.”

We kissed again.

“It’s hot,” I said. “You’re hot.”

She wrapped her arms around me. “God, I missed you.”

We made out, moving from the foyer into the living room. I pulled off my shirt as she reached behind her and unsnapped her bra, her back to me. I was right behind her, reaching around and filling my hands with those glorious tits. Her nipples were hard as my fingers grazed around them, teasing her, drawing them out longer.

She reached behind and found my cock, rubbing it through my jeans. “I missed this.”

It was a forward thing to say. Not something Annie normally would. I barely noticed. I’d spent the last week imagining another Annie, the one I caught glimpses of in her diary. The one who probably had another man’s cock in her last night. Or this morning?

“You’re so hard,” this new Annie said.

“He missed you, too.”

She glanced back at me, raising a brow mischievously. “Then let’s get reacquainted.”

She pulled me to the sofa and sat me down onto it before sliding to her knees between my legs. I was on autopilot as she pawed at my jeans, and together we pulled them off, freeing my cock. Annie caught it, guiding it to her mouth. But rather than just suck it in, she teased it, tilting her head to the side as she ran her tongue along the underside.

I groaned, watching her go down on me as she watched me. She kept her eyes focused on mine the whole time. Not something she normally did. I was used to her closing her eyes as her hair fell over her face, hiding her beauty. Not tonight. Tonight, she kept looking at me, kept the eye contact, those bright blue eyes that I’d fallen in love with years ago filled with naughty promise now.

Wrapping her fingers around my cock, she took me into her mouth at last, sucking me with a confidence that was new. She’d had practice. She

must have. How many times had she gone down on Rick? How many times had he been treated to this view—Annie’s red hair swept across her forehead, her cheekbones prominent as she sucked, her lips swollen with exertion as they traveled up and down his length.

“Uh, Annie,” I moaned. My only warning. As soon as that image formed, of Annie blowing Rick in his hotel room, I lost it.

Rather than pulling away, like she *always* did, she kept sucking. She kept her lips wrapped tightly around my shaft. When I exploded into her mouth, she swallowed it. All of it. And what was even crazier was that she seemed excited by it. Her eyes danced with the naughtiness.

She slurped off, swallowing the last drops before taking a deep, hard breath and wiping her mouth.

“That was incredible,” I said.

She smiled. “Think he remembers me?”

“I don’t know. He may need more prompting.”

Annie laughed. I pulled her up to me, kissing her. Not caring that I could taste myself on her lips. What a strange taste, too. My hands traveled her body, going to the snap of her jeans. “My turn,” I said.

She smiled even more broadly, helping me shimmy out of the tight denim. Beneath, she wore the boyshorts that matched the discarded bra, as lacy and flimsy as ever. I pushed her back along the sofa and grasped the sides of those panties.

As I went down on her, I tried to imagine whether she felt differently. Had she always been so pink? Had her landing strip been so narrow when she’d left last week? When I pushed my tongue between her lips and felt her hand grasp a clump of my hair, had she always been so forceful?

Annie came, her powerful, horseback-riding thighs clamping around my head, cutting off my air. Something snapped inside me. I wasn’t going to let her push me around. Not now. Not with her in my home.

I pushed her thighs away, kissed her pussy one last time, and slid up her body. The Travis of a year ago would have hesitated before kissing her, tasting of her pussy. This Travis slammed his mouth over hers, demanding she have a taste. Annie accepted, kissing me back, even as her breath caught in a gasp.

I was hard again, thicker than before. Grabbing my dick, I pressed against her soft, wet mound. When I pushed forward, I sank into her with ease. Another man—a bigger man—had had her. It wasn’t my mind playing

tricks on me. Another man with a fatter cock had stretched her, and my dick responded by swelling more.

“Oh, Travis, that’s good.” Annie dragged her fingernails along my back. “You feel so big.”

A flattering lie? Or the relative truth. I fucked her harder, driven by a need to prove myself, to prove that I could compete, even if my chest hair was gray and my BMI wasn’t close to zero. I knew Annie, so I played her like a Stradivarius.

I held out, too. Annie’s blowjob helped on that front. Visions of her doing this with Rick didn’t. It was a balancing act, right versus wrong getting all twisted up until I didn’t know what to think, what to focus on.

In the end, it was Annie’s high pitched moans that pushed me over the edge. She was close, if not there already. I just needed to last before my chugging heart gave out. With one leg against my chest and the other dangling off the sofa, I erupted deep inside my wife, just as she rolled into a second—or possibly third?—climax.

“Now that was a welcome home,” Annie whispered.

We retired upstairs, dragging her bags along. I flopped into bed, exhausted from the sex and all the restless nights that preceded this one. I didn’t even have the energy to put anything on. Annie, still on West Coast time, slipped into a pair of pajamas and kissed me softly.

“I’m going to unpack some of my notes. I can’t sleep quite yet.”

“Okay. Love you.” We were back to the friendly kiss.

“Night.”

She padded away with her carryon, shutting the door gently behind her. She probably was going to go over her notes, but I knew another thing she was probably going to do, too. Her diary had been with her through her whole trip, and now it was home, too.

I shut my eyes, and for the first time in over a week, I slept soundly.

Chapter 17

In the morning, I woke to Annie at my side, sleeping face down. Her red hair spilled across her serene face. I watched her, watched the beauty of her, watched her heavy, measured breaths, and wondered if Rick had been treated to this side of her.

I wondered about him. He wasn't ready to settle down, but would he one day? Would Annie be the one to turn him? If anyone could, she'd be the one. How had Annie written it—she was more than just tits and ass to him. I thought it was a throw away line at the time. But was it?

I crept out of bed. Annie stirred, muttered something in her sleep, but didn't get up. I wanted to go right for her study, in search of the diary, but didn't. Annie could be getting up right after me. Instead, I went downstairs and started the coffee. It was 6:45 in the morning. 3:45 to Annie. She wouldn't be getting up for awhile.

Still, I waited a half hour before creeping back upstairs and sneaking into her study. There, sitting like a treasure on display in the center of her desk, was a new, blue diary. She hadn't even bothered to lock it up.

I took a shaky breath as I touched the leather, half expecting it to burn. My ears were open, listening for the sound of Annie moving down the hall.

Nothing.

I flipped to her most recent entry, written last night, held my breath, and started reading.

Monday, September 30

Travis is sleeping upstairs, but I'm still on West Coast time, so sleep eludes me. That's a lie. My sleeplessness isn't because of jet lag. It's my crushing sense of guilt and regret. Making love to Travis only served to remind me what a terrible slut I've become, and how he doesn't deserve what I've done. Travis is a good man. I cannot blame my indiscretions on my husband. But my regret is only because I know it would kill Travis if he ever found out his wife is a faithless whore. Not what I actually did. I can't honestly say that I regret what happened with R in California.

That last weekend with R was a whirlwind. It was like a romantic weekend away with a lover, the kind you have when it's all new, and your passion is burning bright every second of the day. I felt like a princess Saturday night at the gala, but even better, afterward R made me feel like a whore. His whore. And I reveled in it.

I was so scared when we landed. Seeing R and I together, how could Travis not see what was going on? I felt tension, but it just feels like Travis has a general dislike of R, not that he knows what's going on. Maybe it's a sixth sense that something's off.

I can't keep going like this. As amazing as I feel with R, I can't handle this emotional rollercoaster, and I can't keep sneaking around behind Travis' back. I told R it was over before we came back. I told him it was like a fantasy vacation, but it couldn't happen when we returned to reality. I think he only agreed because he didn't believe me. But why would he? But I have to mean it. I have to stick to it. I have to be a good wife to Travis again. And most of all, he can never learn the truth. Travis can never know I was unfaithful, or even worse, how much I loved it.

I stood in the study like a lightning bolt had just lanced through the ceiling to pulverize me. I knew this was most likely what had happened while she was gone, but reading the words, reading the evidence, still shocked me. *I was unfaithful... a faithless whore.*

My first instinct was to vomit, but even as aware as I was of my gut churning, a numbness descended. Like anesthesia. I registered feeling and emotion like they were skating across the surface of my consciousness, and I was trapped beneath it. I saw the shadows of jealousy, hurt, fury, all sweep by, out of reach, out of touch. Arousal and excitement were there, too, spiking as I re-read my trigger words—*whore, slut, lover*. Annie had a fucking lover.

The sound of the shower finally drove me back to the surface of my mind. I emerged, gasping for breath, a medicated idiot who nearly drowned

himself. She was up. Annie was up. She'd catch me.

The irony wasn't lost on me—that it was me who was worried about being caught. I laughed, hysterical and uninhibited. Shutting the diary, I left it there, unlocked, just as I'd found it.

I stalked down the hall, my cock painfully erect. I heard water splash across the shower floor as Annie moved. "You're awake," I said, my voice too gruff. A give-away.

"Yeah," she shouted back from beneath the spray. "I should get up. Have a lot of notes I need to go over while it's all fresh."

I stripped. I wasn't thinking. I barely even heard her. Stalking into the bathroom, I pushed the shower curtain aside, revealing the suds-covered form of my unfaithful wife.

"Oh, you're joining me—"

I cut her off with a kiss, forceful and demanding. She didn't protest or pull away, and if she had tried, I wouldn't have let her. She was his whore, she'd written. She could be mine, too.

She found my erection and began working it without hesitation, her hand firm, her touch confident. But I needed more. I needed to fuck her.

A couple months ago, when we'd done this in the shower, it had been awkward and unfamiliar. I'd felt silly, and maybe Annie had sensed it, too. Not now. Not in the inferno of this moment. I pushed her against the wall, drawing a gasp from her. Her eyes—those magical, blue eyes—flashed up at me in confusion. I just grinned, a predator finally cornering his prey, and stepped up to her as I lifted her leg and pinned it against the wall.

"Oh, Traaav!" She blossomed as I guided my cock into her unfaithful cunt. She was definitely looser, definitely stretched out. My cock bulged, filling her, hitting places that I never did—only to realize that her "R" probably had—and that, in turn, made me harder still.

Her fingers clutched at my neck, holding on as I pummeled her. Our feet squeaked on the shower floor, but my traction held. I snaked my hands behind her, beneath her, clutching her ass and lifting her up into my arms. Adrenaline pumped through me, fueled by the thoughts that Annie, this woman in my arms, had done enough with another man to merit calling herself a *whore*. What had she done? What did he get her to do?

I lifted her by the ass until both of her feet left the ground. She wrapped her legs around me, locking her ankles around my lower back as I fucked her against the shower wall. We'd never done that before—not even

close. I knew it was a fantasy of hers, but I never thought I'd be able to do it.

Annie screamed and moaned on my cock. She wasn't faking it now, and I was pretty fucking sure she wasn't thinking about R.

I exploded inside of her, molten and powerful and draining. And through it all, I kept fucking her, kept lifting her bodily up and down my shaft, kept slapping my hips into her as her hands crawled through my hair and her thighs squeezed the life out of me.

At last, reality caught up with me. I had to let her down, and when I did, I slipped and nearly fell. Annie caught me. "Travis..." she huffed, out of breath. Her hair was dark from the shower, falling over her flushed face. "Travis..."

I forced a smile. "I was wondering if I could do that," I said, because I didn't know what else to say.

"Yeah, that was amazing."

When I kissed her again, it was the old Annie-and-Travis kiss. The married one. The friendly, comfortable, 'til-death-do-us-part one. "I've been working out."

"And it shows," Annie said, reaching out to touch my chest. It was like she was seeing me for the first time. I remember when I had that feeling with her so recently. A shadow passed across her face. Guilt. "I should have noticed."

I put a smile on. "Now, hopefully, you have."

One last kiss and I was backing out of there. "I need to get to work. You going to be late tonight?"

"No." Her response was quick. Too quick. But I appreciated it nonetheless. "I'll be home at the regular time. It's too soon to go to publication with anything from last week."

"Great. Dinner then."

"Yeah, sounds wonderful." Her words were cheerful, but her tone bordered on melancholy.

I left her alone, before she started to cry and had to make up some lie about why. Walking out that door, I wondered what came next. We'd passed beyond the discovery phase and now, indisputably, we were in the affair stage of this story.

Interlude II

“So when you discovered that she cheated on you, why didn’t you confront her?” Some of that dispassionate demeanor has slaked off Dr. Caroline. I see color in her cheeks, now that we’ve gotten down to the details. “Why didn’t you tell her that you knew?”

It’s a good question. One I’ve been running over again and again since that moment. I knew. I had evidence. She was a cheater, an adulteress. She’d cuckolded me. Cuckold...

“I didn’t tell her because I didn’t want it to end. And I knew that as soon as I confronted her, as soon as she knew that I knew, it would be over. She’d come crashing back to earth. She’d been holding her guilt at bay, ignoring that strong moral compass to live her double life. As soon as she couldn’t do that, she’d stop. And I didn’t want it to stop.”

“And why not?”

Again, I keep my eyes fixed on the therapist. This isn’t easy to admit, but I need to. “Because I wanted to watch. After I read what had happened in California, I *needed* to watch.”

“And did you?”

“It became all I could think about...”

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Chapter 18

I pulled the audio recorder out of her car Wednesday morning. I wanted to check it then and there, but I didn't dare. Annie was still asleep upstairs, still jetlagged, but I couldn't risk it. So I slipped it into my briefcase, kissed her goodbye, and drove to work.

It felt like I had a bomb beside me. I kept glancing over at my briefcase, wondering if the worn leather would spontaneously explode. I actually didn't even make it all the way into the office. I stopped at an Au Bon Pain on the way in, ordered a breakfast bagel, and parked myself in a booth with my earbuds in.

I scrubbed through the first part of the morning, which captured yesterday's Morning Edition on NPR during Annie's half-hour long commute. There were no phone calls or conversations, although Annie would occasionally interject in a news story with an "I can't believe this is actually happening."

The door shut, echoing through what sounded like the parking garage, and the morning recording ended. I held my breath, my whole body tense as I waited for what came next.

I heard the sound of the door opening. Leaned forward, as if that would help me hear even more, and... nothing. It was a recording of her commute home, only this time capturing All Things Considered. The recorder nicely time stamped everything, and sure enough, this one was time stamped at 5:30. Her regular time to leave. On the dot.

I shut it off and leaned back in the booth, frustrated. Which was a crazy thing to feel, right? I was frustrated that Annie hadn't cheated on me yesterday?

I went into work, but only for a few hours. Annie's diary was still there, still at home, filled with juicy details of what had gone down in California. I'd built up the possibility of this recording, and while it may have disappointed, I knew those entries would not.

I texted Annie that I had to take care of the car. She didn't question this, because why would she? I even drove it to the shop where I normally had it serviced, just to get an oil change. Just to have a receipt.

All the while, my heart did its best to beat itself out of my chest. I was afraid to look at the BPM on my Fitbit. And by the time I ascended those stairs to her study, it felt like the onset of the flu.

I flipped to the first entry in this diary. September 21, the day before she left for California. So much had happened since then, and as much as I was tempted to skim through this to get to the end, I knew that the build up would make the end that much more powerful.

Saturday, September 21

All packed and ready to go. Of course Travis did not try to stop me from going. He even seemed oddly enthusiastic about it. I gave him plenty of chances to stop me, but he was always encouraging about my trip with R. He must really have no idea about R and me. I had no idea I could be so good at leading a double life. Maybe I should have been a spy.

Packing for a work trip should have been easy. I don't need more than jeans, leggings (and the thongs that go with them), maybe a nicer outfit or two, to interview subjects and gather information. It's not glamorous work. But knowing R was going to be with me, I found myself considering what I packed in a different light. No comfortable t-shirt bras made it into my bag, and everything matches. I packed that shirtdress Travis has always loved me in. I love it too. It can be sexy, but it's not obvious. I packed a wrap dress I know looks killer on me. But I didn't go over the top. I don't want to push R's buttons (too much), and I don't want to tip my hand to Travis. The same unspoken motivations led to my sudden need to touch up my color at the salon.

One other addition made it into my bag. A "rabbit" sex toy I bought online. The reviews were very positive. I can't believe I now own a sex toy! But I would be without my trusty shower massager, and I needed something to help me resist the temptation of R.

It's late. Off to bed. Tomorrow's going to be a long day.

September 22

That was an interesting flight. Did I think R would behave if we were crushed close together for that long? Did I want him to? The rush of misbehaving mixed with the danger of getting caught is intoxicating. I'd forgotten what that's like. I didn't think I'd ever feel like that again.

R mostly behaved himself on the first leg. We were in coach, of course. Nothing glamorous about being a journalist these days. I had the window, R sat in the middle. A sweet retired lady sat to his left. R's hand kept drifting to my leg, and I let it remain as long as it didn't creep too high. That wasn't happening with someone sitting right beside us. I think she assumed we were a couple. Did she think I'm a cougar with a boytoy? That makes me smile. If she did, she must have just assumed R is one of those men who doesn't wear his wedding ring.

I wasn't tipsy by the time we reached our layover, but I had to ease off the cocktails. I was nervous-drinking on the plane. I kept R's hand out of my lap, but that doesn't mean his massaging my thigh the whole flight didn't have an effect. My LuLaRoe may be uber comfortable for a day of sitting on a plane, but a girl feels everything in tights. The heat of R's hand. The subtle patterns his fingers traced, edging ever upward. I might as well not have been wearing anything at all. I wished my new rabbit friend wasn't tucked into my checked baggage so I could sneak into the lavatory and attempt a solo membership in the Mile High Club.

We have more privacy on our connecting flight out of Chicago. We were toward the rear of the plane, and as luck would have it the aisle seat was unoccupied. What a coincidence! I would not be shocked to find out R bought it.

With more privacy, and another cocktail in me, I was more receptive to R on the second flight.

His hand returned to my thigh, and this time I spread a blanket over our laps. I'm sure the flight attendants have seen that move a thousand times, but I wasn't concerned about them. R reached between my legs and my thighs just fell open. It seemed like he was doing very little—massaging with his fingertips in a tight circle—but oh god! did it feel good. I bit my lip and gripped the armrest. The engines were louder where we sat, but not loud enough. My other hand found the bulge in R's tight jeans. I wanted to tease him the way he teased me. The look on his face told me I was. But I wanted to feel his warm dick in my hand. I asked him to take it out. He told me to do it.

It felt so bad to pull out his dick right there on the plane. It filled my hand, thick and hot, and it twitched while I stroked it. I told R how much I liked his dick, and he leaned in close and told me to call it his cock. I smiled, and looked him in the eyes and said, "I love your cock." The look on his face was priceless, and being so naughty sent a surge of heat flooding through me. I was finally as bad as Lisa, and I liked it. It was so much sexier letting R touch me on a plane, surrounded by people, than it was in the backseat of my car. Trying to control myself and stay quiet only made everything more intense. R told me to pull down my tights and I didn't even pause before pulling them to my knees.

My moan when his fingers sank into me was so loud I looked around to see if anyone noticed. No one did. Or they were looking away. R worked magic with those fingers. I came twice in a matter of minutes and soaked his hand. He pressed his fingers to my lips. I kissed them, then flicked out my tongue, then sucked them. I tasted tangy and sweet. It was insane! I was putty in R's hands. I wanted to be bad for him.

It was like I had something to prove. But I tried to draw the line when he leaned over and whispered, “Suck me, Annie.”

I shook my head and told him no. He persisted. He returned his fingers to my pussy. Okay, that made it harder to resist, but I was sure I’d get caught. The plane was still and the people across from us were napping or engrossed in their phones, but someone occasionally passed on their way to the bathroom. He persisted. R said he was about to come and didn’t want to make a mess. I giggled at that. He thumbed my clit. I was on the verge of another climax. He commanded me one last time. I lifted the blanket and ducked under.

It was so exciting! Maybe the most exciting thing ever! I did climax with his cock in my mouth. I sucked him hard and used all my tricks. R wasn’t lying. He came in my mouth right away. And I swallowed it all like a good girl. Or should I say a bad girl. A very, very bad girl. R knows just how to bring out the bad girl in me. Was she always there, waiting for him? R told me how amazing I was when I came up for air.

At the hotel R asked if I wanted to come up. This time I behaved and told him no. I was exhausted anyway. It felt weird that it was so early in the afternoon, but it felt so late. I went to my room and found out why the rabbit was so hyped. The other girls weren’t lying! Wow! With that baby, maybe I’ll be able to resist R after all.

Going to call Travis now. Don’t know how I’m going to act normal.

She’d blown him in the plane? God, that was intense. I shut my eyes and could see it—Rick sitting back in his seat, one arm behind his head, as Annie slipped under the blanket in his lap, her head rising and falling, obvious what was going on but not caring, either. Maybe Rick even got off

on that. Maybe his eyes met some pretty flight attendant just as he came, his face tightening as he emptied his load down Annie's throat.

R knows just how to bring out the bad girl in me. Was she always there, waiting for him? I knew that answer was yes, and that is why it was hard to really hate the guy.

Monday, September 23

What an exciting, exhausting day! Getting out in the field and meeting all the people affected by these shifting policies was an honor. Hopefully the new series will get readers thinking about the people who truly pay the price for decisions made by the power brokers. The people on top are only looking at their own interests, whether it's financial or political. But these are real lives they are toying with. A child fleeing drug violence (caused by our own drug policy!) in his home country should not come here and find herself nothing more than a political pawn.

It was good to be focused on the work and not thinking about R all the time. He was by my side all day, but he behaved himself (mostly) and supported the work. It's good to see another side of him—not just the playboy trying to get into my pants. The problem with that is, when I see R smart and thoughtful it only makes me want him more. He really is the whole package. Not only is he ridiculously good looking, but he's caring and great at his job. And he wants me! It still rocks me that R is so focused on me. I know I'm not some house frau, but it makes me feel special that he's so interested.

Time to shower and change. Meeting R for dinner in about an hour. Feels like I'm getting ready for a date. I love feeling that old excitement.

A date. She sees more to him than just a fuck buddy. It makes me uncomfortable, and yet it's not enough to make me want to shut it down. Annie had a secret exhibitionist streak—she seemed to get excited about being naughty in risky situations. In a similar way, so did I, only for me the risky situation was Annie's descent into this affair. The more she connected with this other man, the more I got off.

If ever there was doubt that I was a Cuckold—with a capital C—it was gone after that realization. I knew they'd been having dinner based on the Instagram photos I saw in Rick's feed. That was hot. The fact that she started thinking of those dinners as dates was stunning and upsetting and electrifying all at once.

Tuesday, September 24

Another exciting day, but I am exhausted. We spoke to a cleaning service that employs mostly undocumented women. It's hard, grueling work with long hours, but these women would not be able to feed their families without it. And the owner pointed out he wouldn't have the business without a supply of undocumented labor. Not because it's cheap, but because it's hard to find employees at all. It's a symbiotic relationship. Everyone benefits.

The work is not the reason I am so tired. Dinner with R last night was...nice. He tried plying me with wine again, but I was good...until we got upstairs. Keeping a clear head did not help my judgment. I think I held out for about five minutes when R pressured me to go up to his room. I finally agreed to let him come to my room, although I made it very clear I intended to keep my pledge to not have sex with him. At least I kept that...barely.

I wore that patterned wrap dress to dinner, and as I'd hoped, R couldn't keep his eyes off of me. I usually wear a cami under it because of the way it hugs my chest and how low cut it is, but I didn't for R. I don't think I've shown off that much cleavage in years. I was very conscious of all my freckles. I

don't care how cute Travis says they are. The other nice thing about a wrap dress is how easy it is to remove.

There was no pretense when we went to my room. We didn't pretend we were going to have a nightcap, or go over our notes. As soon as the door closed, R was all over me and I was pulling off his shirt. I love it when his shirt is off. God, that man is chiseled! I was so busy kissing and rubbing his muscles that I didn't notice him untying my dress and unhooking it.

R was very appreciative of my sexy lingerie, but he didn't let me keep it on for very long. I tried slowing him down by sitting on the edge of the bed and going down on him. I've gotten very good at taking that cock. He easily slides to the back of my throat now. He gathered up my hair in both hands and slowly took control. Instead of me sucking him, he was slowly using my mouth. I got the chills when he took control. He used my mouth faster, and it got hard to breathe. I was sure he was going to come, but he didn't. I'm sure he still thought he was going to have me.

We were nude on the bed together, and I don't know how I kept R from doing it. He teased me with his fingers, and then his mouth. It wasn't the first time R went down on me, but it was the first time he really had to space to relax and do it properly. Oh my god! Lisa was so right. I thought I'd never stop coming. Have I ever screamed like that before? R took more control over me, insisting I say filthy things. I didn't hesitate long. It felt so wrong—so good—to order R to lick my pussy. I could barely get the words out when I begged him to make me come. It was amazing!

R took his shot while I was in the throes of orgasmic bliss. I only just resisted. Instead, he pulled me on top of him. 69 was never my favorite thing. When I was younger, I always felt self-conscious about it. I was more relaxed this time, but I can't say I performed well. R's tongue had me so distracted

I don't know that I did much more than jerk him off while he made me climax over and over. I did enough, though. R came right in my face. It was weird. In the past I would have been angry, but I kinda liked it. Is that okay to admit? R was in charge, and it was hot that he just did it without asking. I know I shouldn't feel that way as a modern, liberated woman, but I really like R taking over.

He wanted to stay, but I kicked him out. Too dangerous. I know I'd wake up with him inside me, and I'd just wrap myself around him. I showered and fell asleep in about two seconds.

So today was a slog as I was half asleep. We did not have dinner alone tonight—were invited out by some good folks—so I am in my room alone and wishing R was here. I can't help myself. I broke out the new toy (it's every bit as stimulating as promised, can't believe I didn't get one sooner!), but I still want to see R. He wants to meet for a drink downstairs. I know where that will end up. We both do. The only reason I've resisted this long is I'm so tired, and we have a big day tomorrow. But that drink sounds awfully good... Who am I kidding? I need to fix my make-up. I have become a slut, haven't I?

She must have looked amazing in that dress. I knew it well. I could even remember the first time she put it on—without a cami—and how her cleavage spilled out of it. If that's how she looked for that dinner with Rick, no wonder he made his play.

I'd never considered that Annie could have a submissive streak. Neither one of us were all that aggressive when it came to sex, but Annie always gave as much as she took. At least with me. With Rick, the story was different. He'd really taken her head in her hands and fucked her face? No, not just her face, but her throat as well.

And the dirty talk. Fuck, I wished I could have heard that. Annie never did that. She barely even cursed when we were not in bed. Amazing thing was, all I needed to do was scan this diary entry to see the words that she'd

bolded, written over and over until they stood out on the page: “cock”, “slut”, “oh my god!” This, from a woman who sometimes did the Sunday morning readings at our church.

I needed to hear her. My mind started to go to work, even as I dove into another entry.

Wednesday, September 25

R spent the night last night. Not surprised, but I'm disappointed in myself. Had the illusion I had more self-control than that. Self-deception is a bad thing. Maybe I needed that fig leaf to give myself permission to have him up.

That he'd spent the night hit me right between the eyes. It was so intimate. So very, viscerally intimate. And it made me so fucking excited.

We had exactly one drink in the bar, then we were in my room. R saw my rinsed toy in the bathroom and insisted on seeing how the rabbit worked. I told him no way, and he said he'd find out for himself. Did I resist? Ha! R knew very well how to use that thing. He had me begging him to fuck me! I howled it as I came! I still didn't do it, but when he used the rabbit and put his cock in my mouth, I swear I thought I was going to melt into a little molten puddle on the bed.

I've never really thought about having two men at once, but it must be something like that. The rabbit was deep inside me while R took my mouth. I was so busy moaning and coming that he just used my mouth. It was so good! So hot! For a moment, I wished that rabbit was a man! Would Travis ever share me with another man? I can't imagine it, and I don't know if I could handle it. Having Travis and R in bed might kill me!

Wow, that's not something I'd ever considered, either. I let that one sink in for a moment. Could I ever share her with another man? Wasn't I right now? But at the same time... now that would be intense. And I wasn't certain, but reading between the lines—as I was starting to get good at with this diary—I think she wanted it. She just couldn't fully admit it to herself.

R finished on my chest—my tits—and I looked up at him as I rubbed it in. So, so slutty! What a WHORE! And it felt so very good! He swore a blood oath he would be good if I let him stay. R behaved, and I loved being in his arms all night.

It got weird earlier. I kinda had my two man experience. First of all, talking to Travis on the phone brought my guilt back like a smack in the face. I hadn't been thinking about it too much. I was a good unrepentant slut. But talking to my husband brought the real world crashing back in. And then R started texting me at the same time. It was naughty, and it turned me on, goddamit!

There just happens to be this black tie event in LA R wants to attend, and he's not taking "I have nothing to wear" for an answer. He even offered to take me shopping. It was weird balancing R's flirting with talking to Travis. Travis noticed I was distracted, and I had a stab of fear that he was on to me. He wasn't. We got off the phone and my guilt receded. I really wanted to go down to R's room. I didn't, but only because I was afraid of what would happen.

I don't know if I can finish this trip with my chastity intact. I don't want to keep it intact, but can I live with myself if I give into my desire? Dammit! I need a night away from R to clear my head.

This never would have happened if she hadn't gone to California with him. If she hadn't had such an extended time with a man so determined to

fuck her. If she'd been here, at home, coming back to me, she wouldn't have crossed the line. Right?

Then again, she'd been meeting up with him in her car. She'd gotten pretty good at going down on him, apparently, and vice versa. Maybe she would have, one day. The onslaught I was reading here, though, gave her no chance. She wanted it. She finally admitted that to herself. She didn't want to keep her chastity intact. She called herself a slut and a whore, but ultimately, that's who she wanted to be. Some of the time, at least.

Friday, September 27

It happened. We came to LA and our new rooms were adjoining. The door between them wasn't enough to keep us apart. The crazy thing is, it wasn't R who pushed it. I went to him. That was probably his plan all along. Make me want him so bad I'd go to him.

My heart was in my throat when I knocked on that adjoining door. He had the grace to look surprised when he opened the door to find me in nothing more than a black push-up bra and a thong. He smiled and invited me in. R was in total control after that.

R commanded me, and I did everything he asked. I went on my knees. I swallowed his cock, but only after asking for it. And I crawled onto his bed and stayed on my hands and knees while he touched me. Yes, I begged R to fuck me, and this time he did it.

He started tender. I was so emotionally overwhelmed I almost cried. It was a weird mix of guilt and desire and relief. I didn't have to pretend anymore. I wanted R, and I'd finally admitted it. R brought me to the edge that way, but then he got forceful. He lifted my legs over his shoulders, held my butt off the bed, and stayed on his knees while he took me. It was such a power move. It was incredible! He stared down at me, watched my tits bouncing and told me to

play with my nipples. I came even harder that time. He fell onto me and took me hard and deep until he came. He didn't ask, he just came inside of me. Feeling that was like a stab to my soul. I knew it made the betrayal worse. I should have made him wear a condom, but I wasn't in control. I wasn't making R do anything.

The second time he pulled me on top of him. His cock felt so good that way! I bucked on him and screamed and begged and came. I was a mad woman! He finished me from behind that time, with my face buried in the pillows. He smacked my butt, and I welcomed the stinging punishment.

I spent the night with him, and R took me again this morning. We can't get enough of each other. If we didn't have to work, I think we'd spend all day in bed. Now that I've had him, I crave him all the time. But work must be done. I have become the craven slut I feared I'd be.

And there it was, the line crossed at last. She'd fucked him. I read over those details again and again, imagining it, picturing it, holding it in my head long after the words had faded. He'd spanked her. He'd manhandled her. He'd come in her pussy. Bareback.

That fell like a hammer over me. I'd never been concussed before, but I imagined it must feel something like the way I did in the long minutes after reading that entry.

Like an alcoholic coming to the bottom of an empty bottle, I wanted more. I wanted to keep this buzz going. I wanted to know the details of their next two nights, their next three days. But the next entry was the one I'd already read, the one written the night that she'd returned. The one that just mentioned how she felt like a princess at the gala, and a whore after. The one when she'd written, "I told R it was over before we came back. I told him it was like a fantasy vacation, but it couldn't happen when we returned to reality."

Here we were, in reality, and with that reality, I had to consider that maybe it was over. Maybe she would stay true to this declaration. I thought

of the innocuous recording. I wondered if maybe, just maybe, it was over. For real. And why did that make me feel so bad?

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Chapter 19

It was weird, coming back to reality after being so deep in her entries, so deep in the past. I had to remind myself what day it was—Wednesday, just two days since Annie’s return—and where I was—at home, alone, not in California.

I put the diary back where it had been and dragged myself from her chair. I was so erect, so hard. Somehow I had managed not to come while reading all of that. A stubborn part of me wanted to save it for my wife, to direct all that energy, all that lust and fury, at Annie when she got home tonight.

I did the laundry, folding it when it came out of the wash—folded her thongs, although I didn’t really know how such tiny things were meant to be folded. She’d worn these things for Rick. She’d gone to his room, dressed in one and a push-up bra. That must have been epic.

It got me thinking about Saturday evening, and the gala. And the dress that she didn’t have. Apparently she’d bought something, though, and I went digging for that in her closet as soon as I realized it.

The black gown was hidden in the back, along with the LBD that she never wore. It was floor-length, long enough to require heels, with a high slit up one side. The sleeveless design and the high neck lent a sense of modesty that the keyhole front did not. In this dress, with Annie’s full tits, her cleavage would have been devastating. I wished that I could have seen it, only to realize that maybe I could.

I brought up the International Herald’s social media site again, and sure enough, there was a post. “Our own Annie Belmont and Rick Archer, special guests in LA for their award-winning work on immigration and sanctuary cities.”

With it were a series of photos that took my breath away. Annie looked better in that dress than I imagined. She would have looked at home on the red carpet—fitting for LA, I supposed. Her glossy red hair was done up, ringlets framing her face that shone brightly in every single photo. At her side was Rick, the perfect compliment to her glamor. He wore a tuxedo like he was borne to, his shoulders and chest broad, his waist narrow, his smile impeccable.

One photo caught the most of my attention. Rick was talking to a group of equally attractive people, all eyes on him, the center of attention—including Annie's. I zoomed in on the way she looked at him, could feel the admiration and desire in those clear, blue irises. I recognized infatuation there, and want and need. There was a woman who would do anything for that man.

And that dress. The inner-sides of breasts spilled through the keyhole opening, a tight line of cleavage that had to be supported by something, although I couldn't see it in any of the photos as much as I studied them. And I really did study them. She wore heels, as I knew she had to, and I swear she had stockings on, sheer and dark, although the lighting wasn't great. I looked in her panty drawer for what they could be, but found nothing. That didn't mean much. Hose that sheer developed runs easily—especially when forced to spend time on her knees.

I took a cold shower after that. This day stretched, and I felt stretched out with it. At last, Annie came home—not only on time, but early. I was thankful that all I was doing was reading my Kindle—or trying to read it—on the living room sofa.

“Have a good day?” she asked. I thought I saw guilt in her face, a tentativeness in her question, but maybe I was just imagining it.

“Yeah. It was pretty relaxing.” Ha! “Got the car taken care of. Did some laundry.”

Annie's brows went up. “You did laundry? Wow.”

She looked great in her skirt and blouse combo. It was professional and not suggestive in anyway other than the heels she wore, which made her legs and ass look fantastic.

“I know, I'm a hero, right?”

Annie laughed. There was definitely something strained here. “My hero.”

I held out my hand to her, and it was only when she interlaced her fingers with mine that I said, “I've noticed, you know.”

The fear that flashed across her face was priceless. She'd gotten sun in California, but here she looked as white as a sheet. “What's that?”

I drew her into my lap and wrapped my arms around her. “You,” I whispered. She smelled good, perfume dabbed behind her ear. “And the effort you've been making lately.”

“Oh... right.” She laughed nervously. “You too.”

“I need to keep up,” I said. I kissed her neck as my hand traveled up the inside of her thigh, stopping as it brushed up against the hem of her skirt. “I like the thongs. You wearing one now?”

“You... I...” She sighed, totally flushed. Pink had seeped up her neck. “Yes.”

“Show me.” Not “let me see.” Not a request, or a question. An order, and like magic, she responded.

Standing, Annie glanced at me, equal parts puzzled and excited. I did a twirling motion, and she took the hint, turning so that her back was to me, and unzipped her skirt. Beneath, she wore a black pair of panties with a wide, lacy band at the top that narrowed before plunging down through her glorious, bubble butt.

“That looks so good,” I said, reaching out to touch it.

“I... I only wear them because of the skirts, you know. Lisa was teasing me about panty lines.” I wondered how much truth there was to that. “I think my butt’s too big for them.”

“No. No way. It’s like you were made to wear them. Skinny girls don’t come close.” I traced my hand along the crack, reached out with my other hand, and yanked them down. “But that’s not the only effort I’m talking about.” I pulled her down to me as my fingers stroked across her pussy. “They must be right about a midlife sexual peak.”

Her words, right back at her. They just came out, and when I realized what I’d done, my heart skipped a beat before I remembered that she’d written that weeks ago.

“I thought that was mostly just women,” Annie said, reaching behind me to play with my hard cock.

“Like I said, I noticed, and it’s pretty inspiring.”

She turned, working open her blouse as I wiggled out of my jeans. Climbing onto my lap, she wrapped her arms around my neck and dropped onto my shaft, taking me with a deep sigh.

“So you like my new underwear?”

“Are you kidding me? My only complaint is that I have no clue how to fold them.”

Annie giggled. “Me either.”

“I’m willing to live with it.” I’m willing to live with a lot, apparently. “You should get some stockings.”

“Oh?”

“Thigh-highs. I think I know how to fold those, at least.”

Annie nuzzled my nose as I filled my hands with her heart-shaped ass. “I’ll keep that in mind.”

*

I taped the recorder back under Annie’s seat the next day, Thursday, although I wasn’t expecting much. Oddly enough, this day was easier to get through. I had more focus. I was able to think about work and get things done.

Annie was home when I got home. We had a normal dinner. I went to bed, she stayed up late—still half on California time—but was asleep beside me when I was up Friday morning. I went downstairs, scrubbed through the audio, this time just checking the timestamps. Sure enough, there was nothing between her morning and afternoon commutes. I even played a little of the afternoon recording, just to confirm that it was Annie, and Annie alone, getting into her car and riding home.

It was disappointing, but maybe this was a good thing. Maybe this was just a phase, and we were through it. Maybe she really had gotten it all out of her system in California. But then, I realized that as she denied it, that woman, tempted to do bad things with exciting men, was a part of her. It had been that way before, even while we were married. I couldn’t forget about Dane Armstrong. Or Brian Hoffman. They’d primed her for Rick, but she’d always had that naughty side buried deep.

With that possibility in mind, I hid the recorder back in her car and went to work.

If this was over, what did that mean going forward? Had I not overheard her conversation with Rick way back when we were in Paris, I never would have known about this affair. I wouldn’t have suspected a thing, just lived on in total ignorance. I wouldn’t have discovered that in the past twenty years, the jealous streak I’d felt when we were apart had metamorphosed into a cuckold yearning to be cheated on.

Thing was, I knew now. Pandora’s Box was open, and there was no way to pretend that it wasn’t.

Regardless, it was Friday and I was happy to have the weekend to spend with my sexy wife. Time to take this whole thing one step at a time, and I was determined to enjoy it.

As usual, Annie was home when I got home. No random texts telling me she needed to work late. Nothing to arouse suspicion. It was warm for October, and I found her sitting on the deck in the back, sipping a glass of white wine and reading on her phone.

I kissed her. She smelled fresh, like she'd just shampooed, although her glossy red hair was dry, held back in her usual ponytail. She'd already slipped out of her work clothes, which was a shame, although she filled out her leggings and shirt well.

"Nice night," I said, settling down beside her.

She handed me her glass of wine for a sip—a gesture so natural it was like reading my mind. I tasted the crispness of the Sauvignon Blanc before handing it back to her.

"Really nice."

I put a hand on her knee. "I'm glad you're home."

Her smile seemed distant, thoughtful. She glanced at me, timidly at first. Ashamed at what she'd done perhaps? I only smiled more broadly, thinking about how sexy she was. How naughty. It must have infected her, too, because I watched the smile reach her eyes. She sighed. "I'm so glad I'm home, too."

I moved my hand up the inside of her thigh. "I was thinking we could go out tonight. Get some dinner somewhere."

"Sounds wonderful."

"But first... an appetizer."

Annie laughed at my corny joke. I didn't let it distract me, though, pressing my fingers against her pussy through the leggings as I dipped down to kiss her again, harder this time. Her tongue sought mine, her laughter yielding to desire.

When my hand went to the front of her leggings, she pulled back and looked around. "We're in our backyard," she whispered.

"I know," I said, grinning. "Risky, huh?"

I dropped down between her legs, going to work on her leggings more aggressively as she stared at me, fear and excitement dancing across her face. "I don't know..."

When I tugged at the waist of her tights, though, she lifted her butt off the chair and let me pull them down without hesitation. Beneath, she wore a new pair of panties that I didn't recognize, white satin fringed in black lace. Running my hands over her ass, I discovered that it was a thong.

Her smile was lopsided when she saw my surprised reaction. "I figured you'd like them," she said.

I groaned. "So sexy."

Pushing the gusset of her thong aside, I dipped down and ran my tongue along her smooth slit. She shivered, huffing loudly as my tongue danced off the tip of her clitoris. Tossing her hair, she reclined into the patio cushion and lifted one foot onto the chair, opening her legs for me.

I held her thong to the side as I ate her to a quick, gasping climax. She lost all compunction for playing outside, and if the strength of her orgasm was any indication, the risk really did turn her on.

"That was nice," Annie sighed, not moving to pull her leggings back on. She shut her eyes like she was basking in the warm sun, rather than the cool stars of the October night sky.

I released her thong, covering her pussy. My knees creaked and the muscles in my legs groaned in protest as I stood. "Yeah, it was very nice."

I held a hand to her, but she just smiled slyly, brushed her hair away from her face, and ran her hand across the front of my pants. "My turn," she said, feeling my throb against her palm.

"You don't have to..." But she was already drawing my zipper down before I finished the sentence, and after that, I lost the willpower to protest. I almost lost the ability to stand, too, as she freed my cock and swallowed it swiftly into her mouth.

Christ, she was good at that. No, that wasn't quite right. She'd *gotten* good at that. In the last month. She did little things that she hadn't before. She was able to take all of me into her, watching me with those stunning blue eyes as I passed into the back of her throat.

"Oh, Annie, that's feels so good."

I swear, there was a flicker of excitement as I watched her.

I decided to take a chance. "You like sucking...me. Don't you?" I couldn't quite say "cock" to her, despite really wanting to.

She answered by sucking harder around me, and humming a "mmhmmm" that felt magical as it rippled up my shaft. Pulling back, she kept the tip inside of her as she swirled her tongue across my glans, jerking the rest of me with a firm, confident stroke. I didn't have a chance. I swear I didn't even last a minute before I was exploding inside of her.

And just as she'd written she'd done in her diary, she swallowed my come, drinking it without hesitation.

When she pulled back, I nearly stumbled and fell. She stood, catching me with a steady hand. Tilting her head and going up onto her tiptoes, she whispered, “I’m going to go get dressed. I can’t very well go out without pants.”

Without grabbing her leggings, she walked back into the house, giving me a long look at her thong-clad ass. Good God, her ass looked good.

As Annie got ready, I went to her car and removed the audio recording device. I didn’t listen to it. Honestly, I didn’t want to even try because I figured it would just lead to more ironic disappointment and tonight, I wanted to just focus on Annie and how amazing she was.

That evening, we had a great dinner. We Ubered to our restaurant so that we could drink, and we both drank a lot. Annie seemed to relax—and it was only when she relaxed that I realized how tense she’d been. Even when I came home. Even when we went down on each other.

After, we went back home and had sloppy, drunken sex. It wasn’t good for either of us, but it was the best we could do, given our state. I was surprised when I woke in the morning to see Annie already up, sliding into her riding breeches.

“I feel like death,” I groaned. “How are you awake?”

Annie laughed. “Better genes, I guess.”

“Headed out for a ride?”

“As much as I miss you, husband, I *really* miss Ruby.”

“Now the truth comes out.” The joke would have been harmless in any other situation. Instead, I saw a shadow fall across her face and immediately regretted saying it. I played it off, rolling onto my side and pulling the covers up around me. “Give my love to the horse.”

Annie came to my side and kissed me softly. “I’ll be back in a few hours. See you then.”

I actually thought that maybe, just maybe, I’d go back to sleep. Like the world hadn’t changed completely since last week. Like this was just another, lazy Saturday morning in the life of a boring, married guy.

I ended up getting the up anyway, unable to find rest despite my hangover. I took a long shower, and almost felt human after a bowl of cereal and some coffee.

It was only after all that that I wandered into her office and pulled out her diary. I figured that she’d probably written how guilty she felt, and how

she was determined more than ever to make things right with me. In my soft and nostalgic state, I could have used that.

Holy shit, was I wrong.

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Chapter 20

Wednesday, October 2

It was foolish to think R would accept that it was over, but now that I think about it, his pledge to leave it alone was qualified. R said he loved being with me, but he wasn't going to push me to do anything. He wanted me to be happy. Reading between the lines, it's pretty obvious now that he was just going to wait for me to come back to him. I'm sure in his mind, R never had any doubt I'd be back.

R started with flattery. He kept telling me how great California was, and how hot it was. I tried replying generally, but it didn't discourage him. After I turned R down for lunch on Tuesday, he turned it up. "Can't stop thinking about how you looked in that dress," he messaged. R followed that with, "You looked even better out of it. You should be a lingerie model." I told him he was insane. No one is looking for a 43-year-old lingerie model, not that I ever thought I was that hot. But I have to admit, R makes me feel that hot.

It was fun picking out that dress, knowing I was wearing it for him. It was even more fun choosing what to wear beneath it. I've always liked sexy, lacy things. I wear practical things most of the time, but I like the feel of lace and satin against my skin when I have the excuse. I used to buy lingerie with Travis in mind, but somehow we got away from that. Lingerie shopping for my night out with R brought that excitement back. I hate to admit it, but shopping for what R would see me in was more thrilling than it has been for my husband. I'm still in that stage where I need to impress R. It's probably why I've started wearing thongs, after all these years. That's not fair to Travis, but it's reality. Is there anything I can wear for my husband after 20 years together

that's going to get the kind of reaction R is going to have when he undresses me?

I paused here, because the answer *should* be yes. Sometimes, it *is* yes. Like just last night, when I peeled her tights down and discovered her thong. But she had a point. I probably didn't react the same way as Rick did. Not all the time. And somewhere along the way, I'd begun taking Annie for granted.

I went back to reading, realizing that I was about to get an account of last weekend.

The dress I chose was appropriate for a black tie gala, but daring for me. I don't think I've ever worn a slit that high. It was interesting to walk in, but then I didn't mind if R saw my garter belt when I took a step. It was just crazy to think that other men might catch a peek. And the neckline! I've never been shy about having the girls out—within reason—but the keyhole in that dress was insane! I had to constantly fight the urge to cover up. I felt so exposed! I don't think a single man made eye contact all night. And R was very, very appreciative. How would Travis react if I wore something crazy like that for him?

The cut out needed cleavage, and all of the bras I took out to CA showed, so I had to buy something, of course. The black number I bought looked more like a corset than a strapless bra. It had lots of hooks in the back, but R didn't have any trouble getting it off.

R reminding me how hot I looked was only a continuation of that night. He kept leaning over and whispering what he was going to do to me back at the hotel. Knowing he couldn't wait to get my clothes off drove me crazy. I think I was wet all night! And when he got me alone, he delivered.

I don't know if I've ever felt what R brought out in me that night. I've been trying to suppress it, but I just can't. Closing my eyes now, I can feel it like I travelled right back to that night. When we sat, he kept his hand high in that slit. He was so close, he could have easily touched me, but he didn't. I think that was worse than it would have been trying to control myself if he had touched me. I know I wouldn't have refused him. I didn't when R told me to take off my panties toward the end of the evening. God, it felt dangerous! I don't think I flashed anyone, but I came very close.

R circled me in his room, watching me hungrily. It felt like he decided what he was going to do to me. I knew he'd never hurt me, but I felt a shiver of fear. R kept pushing me. How far would I let him go? He started taunting me. "You liked all that attention tonight, didn't you?" "All those men couldn't stop looking at you. They saw your tits and they wanted to rip that dress off you. And you fucking loved it." I didn't answer him, but I didn't need to. I couldn't control the crimson flush that covered my skin. R went on. "I love having a woman other men want to fuck. You need to let this side of you out more often. I knew you were beautiful that first time we met. I could only guess how sexy you were. How dirty you were."

I whispered his name. I wanted him to touch me. I needed him to touch me. I was almost ready to beg, but I kept that piece of myself. I just whispered his name. He stopped behind me, and I jumped when he unzipped my dress. He peeled it away, then turned me to face the mirror. I wanted to watch him behind me, but R told me to look at myself. He wanted me to see how sexy I was. I wanted to hide. I was so self-conscious. But R made me see myself the way he sees me. It was revelatory. His hands rested on my rounded hips, then he touched my not-quite-flat tummy. R made them sexy. And then his hand dipped lower. R made me watch while he

made me come, even though it felt like my knees would buckle.

It's all a fog after that, but some details stood out. Somehow that bra came off. My garter belt and stockings stayed on. I worshipped his cock. And I do mean worshipped. I think it was because I wanted him so badly. I wanted him to need it as badly as I did. R became increasingly aggressive as I teased him with my mouth. He pushed me onto my back and straddled me. He told me, "I'm going to tit-fuck you." I didn't even know what that was, but I held my tits together and he shoved his cock between them. He's so big, he kept pushing into my mouth. It was hot to let him use me like that. And then he stopped messing around and just took my mouth. He came down my throat and I kept sucking him. He did not stay soft. His power was incredible.

R took me every way he could. I was on my knees, on my back. I screamed when I rode him. He was behind me, and I begged when he demanded it. I begged when he didn't. R had to have a system for holding out, because he seemed to stay hard all night after that first time. It felt like he took me for hours, even though I know that's silly. And when he was done, I fell into his arms, incredibly alive. I should have been exhausted, but all I wanted was for him to keep going. I tried sucking him, but he begged off. He promised he would take care of me in the morning. He didn't lie. R woke me up by sliding inside me.

It's like I was someone else that weekend. That sounds like I'm trying to avoid responsibility for my actions, but that's not it. I just wasn't me: Annie the mother and wife and professional. I wasn't a soccer mom or even a journalist. I was his. I was his woman. We were together in every way. We began developing our own language. I gave myself to R fully. He must have felt it. He must have known I was completely in thrall to him. That's why he knew I'd never stay away from

him when we returned home. And it was why I had to. As bad as the sex was—there was so much sex—that wasn't the worst betrayal to Travis. It was that I became someone else's woman. I don't know if I can live with how that feels in my lucid moments, and that's why I need to stay away from R.

But I already feel the pull. R won't let it go. He still wants me. And when he makes me think about it, I still want him too. I feel the pull of being his like it's a physical force. I don't know that I can resist much longer, because deep down, I don't really want to, no matter how wrong it is.

“I became someone else's woman.” That line, more than any other in the whole, crazy, wild entry, struck me most profoundly. I quaked, thinking about it. It wasn't just about sex. It wasn't just something physical. He was a force, a draw. He tapped something in her that I didn't. That I couldn't. Maybe never had. With me, Annie was the responsible woman she thought of herself as. With Rick, she could be the wild one she fantasized about.

What made me a cuckold—what still does—is that a normal man would be horrified by this, enraged by the betrayal and the jealousy of his wife going to another man to satisfy this dark side of her. Not me. I did feel the jealousy, of course, like the jittery restlessness that came with too much coffee. My stomach churned. But all that did was add to my out-of-control excitement. I couldn't get enough of it. Lucky for me, there was another entry, written last night.

Friday, October 4

I have proved once again that I am a shameless slut. My steadfast resolve to resist R lasted exactly 4 days. Sex with Travis every day, and some help from my new rabbit friend, wasn't enough. And just like in LA, I went to him. Part of me knows that R is probably playing me. Maybe he just wants me to prove he can get me, but it feels so good that I really don't care about his motives. It's not like I want anything more than what this is—a tawdry affair. And I'm doing this

for me, not for R. His motives can be anything he chooses. But R isn't the only person I should be thinking about. Travis.

I was relieved when I arrived home before Travis. I was filled with guilt and regret. Sadly, the regret was only because I knew what I'd done would hurt Travis, not because I regretted what I'd done. I couldn't honestly regret something that made me feel that way. I wanted to get upstairs and shower, wash away my sin, before Travis saw me. He'd have to know what I'd done just by looking at me. I stripped out of the outfit I'd chosen knowing it would make illicit sex easier, and took a long, hot shower. I changed into leggings and a loose, comfortable top afterward. I hoped if Travis saw me scrubbed clean and looking comfortable, with no make-up, he wouldn't sense anything.

Something is different, and it makes me think Travis must know something. Even though I was dressed down when he got home, he was still over all me. He's been all over me all week, since the moment I came back from LA. Travis is going out of his way to compliment me on how I look, and our sex life has quadrupled. I'm not complaining about more sex, but such a change makes me think Travis senses something. It makes me paranoid, and although it was exciting to fool around in the backyard this evening, I tried to put him off. The shower didn't help. I still felt dirty when my husband started touching me. How could I let him go down on me when I'd just had sex with another man hours before? How could he not tell? If Travis does sense something is going on, it only seems to make him want me more, not less. I don't understand.

Back to today's original sin. I'm all jumbled up tonight. I shouldn't try to write here when I've been drinking. I knew when I was getting dressed this morning I was going to give myself to R again. Have I ever worn that white shirt dress to

work before? I don't think so. It made it so easy for R to undress me in the confines of a backseat. All he had to do was open those snaps and undo my little belt. I made sure to wear a front hook bra too, and I knew the thong wouldn't offer R a problem.

R didn't pretend to be surprised when I asked him to lunch. On the way down in the elevator, R asked if I wanted to get a bite first. I just shook my head and we went straight to the garage. Turns out, I didn't need to make it easy for him to undress me. R told me to undress myself. I'm feeling a shiver just thinking about it.

Sex in the car is probably not a good idea. It was one thing to fool around in the backseat, but when R pulled me onto his lap and I rode him the Infiniti was rocking like crazy. And I kept hitting my head on the roof. It didn't stop me. Oh my god, it was so hot! The more I tried to be quiet, the more difficult it was. It felt so dangerous! Luckily, it's a monthly rental garage, so there's not a lot of midday foot traffic, but if anyone had passed by, we would have been discovered, even with the tinted windows. We need a better solution. Maybe one of the hotels downtown. I'm not deluding myself any longer. I'm having an affair.

And there it was, the damning admission I'd been fearing, hoping, fantasizing about, delivered in the final line of the diary post like a punch to the solar plexus. An affair. She admitted it. This wasn't a one time lapse. This wasn't a victim-of-circumstance sort of thing. She'd sought him out. She'd invited him down to the parking garage, to her SUV. To fuck him.

Then it hit me. They fucked in the car—and I had a recording of everything that happened in the car yesterday. I was a streak, flying down the stairs, headed for my briefcase. A part of me was skeptical that I'd hear anything. That this diary entry was a test, or a fake. That the recorder had malfunctioned. Something. Anything.

But no. It worked. It was there. I quickly scrubbed through the morning commute, watching the time stamp speed by. The car door shut.

The recording ended. And then...

And then a new recording started. Time stamped 12:07. A door thudded closed on the recording, followed by the rustling sounds of bodies moving around, breathing.

"We're right back where we started," I heard Annie say, her voice hushed. The audio was so clear, like she was sitting right next to me.

"It's more fun to have you in bed," Rick replied.

Annie sighed. *"Maybe next time."*

"I'm glad you're not pretending anymore."

"Pretending what?"

Rick's voice dropped in pitch, barely above a whisper, yet still clear as a pin. *"Pretending you don't want this. Pretending you can't do this. Pretending you're something you're not."*

"What am I?" Annie said, followed by a sharp gasp.

"What do you think you are?"

"What do you want me to be?"

Annie gasped again, this time followed by a moan.

I tried to imagine what was going on. I thought of her dress—the white shirt dress she'd written about. It was more casual than professional, but not anything overtly sexy. It ended just above her knees, had quarter length sleeves, with buttons all the way down the front. But she was right, as she'd written it. One thing it had going for it was how easy it was to take off in tight confines.

Is he touching her now? Does he have his hands up under that dress, her thong pushed to the side?

"What are you, Annie?"

"I'm yours. Oh god, I'm yours."

Rick's voice dropped so low, the recorder hardly registered it. I reached for a pair of headphones, not loving the fact that I couldn't hear what was going on around me—or be alerted to Annie's return—but not caring, either. I needed to hear this. I needed to be as close to this as I could.

"Yes, you're mine now, aren't you, Annie?"

"Oh god!" she whimpered. Yes, he must be fingering her.

"Aren't you, Annie?" His voice was sharper.

"I'm yours...oh god...I'm yours..."

"Undress for me, babe."

I shivered. He had so much command over her. So much control. I adjusted myself as I listened to the ruffling and shifting of cloth on cloth.

"What?" Annie asked.

"Every time I see you I just can't believe it. You're incredible, Annie. You're so fucking hot."

"Stop it." She sounded just as skeptical of his compliment as she was of mine.

"You know you're fucking hot." Rick's voice was more aggressive than I'd ever dare. He didn't like being contradicted. *"We both know you like being noticed. It's time you stop pretending otherwise."*

"Oh...mmm...Rick..."

"You dressed up today because you wanted me to notice you."

"Yesss..." Annie hissed.

His hands must be back on her, running across her full tits, squeezing her nipples. His voice is low, close to her. Kissing her neck? Behind her ear?

"You wanted me to want you."

"Mmm, yesss..."

"You wanted me to fuck you."

"Yesss...please..."

"Take it out. Feel how hard I am."

More rustling sounds followed.

"Oh, god..." Annie whispered. I could hear the awe in her voice.

"Fuck, your lips are soft, babe," Rick groaned. Now that I knew to listen for it, I heard it—soft, muffled sucking sounds, layered over with Rick's shallow panting. She was blowing him, right on audio. Like she was right next to me. And Rick didn't need to ask. *"Damn, babe... Fuck you can take it deep... Goddam it..."*

I groaned, shutting my eyes and giving into this dark world. I touched my cock through my pants, stroking it between my thumb and forefinger as the sounds on the recorder shifted. The sucking sounds gave way to lips smacking and heavy breathing. Annie's heavy breathing.

"You love those shaved balls, don't you, babe."

"I like it. It's fun," Annie cooed. *"Feels like I can do so much more with them like that."*

"You're doing fucking good, babe. Ohhh...fuck..."

She was sucking his balls. Oh, god! I tickled my own balls with my other hand as I listened to the wet sounds of my wife servicing another man's cock. Rick moaned, cursing quietly to himself, groaning Annie's name in encouragement. I thought of her blowjob from last night, and how deep she took me. Could she take Rick all the way to the root, too?

Finally, Annie took a deep breath. I couldn't tell what was happening—bodies being rearranged, more clothes coming off. Then Rick: *"Fuuuck, you're drenched, babe. You're always fucking ready to go, aren't you?"*

Annie's reply was tight and shallow. *"I can't help it. It's how you make me feel."*

"So this is all for me?"

"Yes!" she cried.

"You can't help yourself?"

"No! I...I...I need you...oh god!"

"You need that fat cock, don't you, babe?" There was a hint of cruelty to Rick's voice. He knew he had her. He'd played her, and got off on having played her.

"Yes! Oh god! Yes!"

And now they were fucking.

"I knew you fucking couldn't stay away."

"I couldn't. I need you."

The recording filled with the sounds of their heavy breathing, and the quieter, more subtle sounds of the rocking car. I heard the hollow bump of something striking the roof, followed by a moan and a sharp laugh.

"God, you're such a hot little slut, babe."

"Mmmhmm...yeah..."

"Yeah, you are. A dirty little slut who can't keep away."

"Mmm...Rick...please..."

"Ride that cock. Show me you want it. Show me what a dirty little slut you are, Annie," Rick growled.

"Oh god! Ohgodohgodohgod! Yes!" She's so loud. Much louder than when we're together. It's like Rick stripped away all her restraint, all the proper Annie she'd built up for so long.

"You're my little married slut who loves my cock, Annie. Say it!"

"Oh god! Rick...please..."

"Fucking say it, Annie!"

“Yes! I’m...I’m...I’m a married slut! Love...love...your cock...oh god! Rick!”

“Come on. Come on my cock, babe.”

“Oh god! Ohgodohgodohgod!”

Annie’s words shifted into a high, keening cry. That, I recognized—Annie’s orgasm, only amplified, intensified. Her climax times one thousand. Had she ever cried out like that with me? Had it ever been so intense? The questions landed on me like lashes across a masochist’s back, searing and painful, yet profoundly, devastatingly erotic. I was hearing it. Was getting a taste of what Rick did to my wife, and why she couldn’t stay away from him. I should have vomited. Instead, I exploded in my pants.

The sounds on the recording grew quiet as Rick grunted and gasped. Was he coming? Was he filling my wife with his seed, taking her bareback, as I knew they’d been doing all last week?

I listened, inert and slaked from my own orgasm, as their breathing grew calmer, quieter, so faint that it seemed like the recording might be over.

Then, the kisses returned, wet smacks and Annie’s soft, gentle moan. She giggled. *“Oh, wow.”*

“Yeah, you were on fire, babe. I guess that’s what a few days away will get you.”

More kissing followed, along with my rising erection. This time, I didn’t touch it. I just sat there, paralyzed.

“I really tried to hold out. You know how I feel about this.” I could hear the conviction in her voice. The guilt. But at the same time, there was an inevitability in that statement.

“Listen, Annie. I, of all people, am not going to judge you. I have no high horse to get on. People do what they do for a lot of reasons. You don’t have to tell me yours. I don’t need to know. I just want you.”

“I know, but that doesn’t make me feel better about this.”

“You seemed pretty okay with it a couple minutes ago.”

They both laughed. It sounded cruel, left out—because I was left out.

“My mind was on...other things...then.”

“Yeah, it was.” Rick sounded very pleased.

“I guess holding out, staying away is not going to work.”

“Then don’t do it. You don’t have to. But if going without for a couple days makes you like this...”

“Very funny. Was this hotter than last weekend?”

“Nothing could be hotter than that. After Saturday night...”

“I’ve never been like that before. It was just—”

“Like I said, you don’t owe me any explanations.”

“I just want you to know, I’m not normally like that.”

“Like what?”

Yeah, like what, I wondered.

“Stop teasing me.” Annie sounded playful.

“You like being teased. That was a lot of Sunday, wasn’t it?”

“Rick...”

Sunday. The final black box of her trip. What the hell had happened?

“Maybe I should tease you now.”

“Oh! Mmm...stop...we have to go back to work,” Annie half-heartedly complained.

“Well, you should be like that more often. You should be like that all the time.”

I had no clue what he was talking about, but found myself agreeing with Rick.

“How would I get anything done?” Annie laughed. *“I mean it. Stop.”*

“True. And I don’t know that I could keep up, not every day. I might need to call in reinforcements.”

“Haha. You’re what I need.” They kissed some more—the sound of betrayal. The sound that would haunt me in the proceeding months to come.

“You are a shameless slut, aren’t you, Mrs. Belmont.”

“I think you like it a little too much that I’m married.”

“I told you, married women are the best, at least for me. I find you to be an untapped resource. A mere girl couldn’t match your passion.”

“I’ll take that as a compliment, although I don’t like to think I’m the next in a line of conquests.”

“No one compares to you, babe.”

I wondered how honest he was being. In my eyes, it was 100% true, though, now more than ever. Annie bought into it, at least enough to kiss him some more.

“We really do need to get out of here. I need to get into a bathroom and straighten up before we go back,” Annie said.

“Don’t want to go back to work with that just fucked look?”

“Nooo...I don’t want to be an office cliché. Woman-of-a-certain-age falls for her powerful younger boss.”

“It’s a nice cliché!”

“Shut up!”

They exited the car. The recording ended.

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Interlude III

“So now that you heard them, were you satisfied?” Dr. Caroline asks. It’s rhetorical. She knows the answer.

“This fantasy isn’t the kind that can be satiated. It’s not like being hungry. More like a hunger. It wants more the more you feed it.”

“An addiction. You said that before.”

“And I don’t think I was the only one addicted.”

Dr. Caroline clicks her pen. “No, as you tell it, you’re not.” *As you tell it.* Very carefully worded. “So Annie has now admitted that she’s having an affair. You’ve heard it yourself. I have to ask, Travis—why didn’t you leave her? Why did you stay?”

“It’s a fair question.” One I’ve been kicking around for months and still didn’t quite understand. “Because we didn’t just meet the year before. Because we had history—over two decades of it. You are getting just a glimpse of our life together—the darkest part of it. But I can still remember all the times that came before. The joy we felt when we learned she was pregnant with Olivia. How supportive she was when my parents were in that accident. All those experiences traveling with her around the world, sharing the wonder of a new place.”

“Sure, but that still wouldn’t prevent most men from walking out on their wives if they learned about an affair.”

This feels like I’m being tested, but I try not to overthink my answer. “Right. I guess I’m not like most men?”

“So what do you think you’re like?”

“A...” I take a deep breath. I’d never said this next time aloud. I glance to Dr. Caroline’s left. “I’m a cuckold.”

Chapter 21

Sex the weekend that I listened to that first recording was wild. I fucked Annie like I'd just discovered that she was a pornstar in her past. In a way, it wasn't entirely inaccurate. I took her like I imagined Rick had, wanting to make her cry and scream the way he did. I didn't get there, but it was the most passionate sex we'd had since probably our honeymoon.

She was like a woman torn in two. At times, she'd stare out at nothing, lost in thought, a crease formed between her brows. Then she'd touch her face, and the worry would yield to a memory that seemed to take her breath away. Her lips would part. She'd pant a little before shaking her head, shutting her eyes, and clearing it away.

It pained me to see her like that, but this wasn't a dilemma that I could talk her through. I couldn't play therapist to a secret she couldn't share—and that, strangely, I didn't want her to share.

On Monday, I secured the audio recorder beneath the seat of her Infiniti and left, shakily, for work. I could barely think. I could barely focus. I spent most of my mental energy throwing myself into figuring out how I could reasonably listen to what was on that recorder. Annie texted me, letting me know that she needed to stay a little late as they wrapped up the preliminary story for the sanctuary city story. It was plausible, but immediately rose my suspicions.

I swung by a big box electronics store to pick up a second memory card, and toyed with getting some little security cameras before deciding against it. I had no idea how I'd plant those anywhere where I could watch, anyway.

I knew I had a problem. I knew this was all rapidly winding out of control. But I couldn't stop.

Annie got home around the same time that I did, due to my detour to get the memory card.

"Hey there," she said, a little frazzled. "I picked us up some Lebanese."

"Yum."

I tried to smell him on her as I kissed her, and I could. Faintly. A trace of musk beneath the tangy smell of her perspiration. Did they have another

quickie in the car after work?

“I’m going to jump in the shower real fast. I worked out at lunch and it’s been such a crazy day. I didn’t have a chance to shower.”

The lie was so good, so convincing, I almost believed it. Almost. But she smelled like him, and when I kissed her, I swear I *tasted* him, too. My cock hardened. “I’ll set the table,” I said.

That evening, through dinner and then into bedtime, she was withdrawn, even more than usual, receding back into the mysterious girl I’d met in class so many years ago, when all I knew of her were her eyes.

I got up early Tuesday morning, recklessly going into her study to check her diary. There was an entry there, from last Sunday. A short one. I read it without thinking, without worrying about Annie sleeping just down the hall.

Sunday, October 6

Leading a double life is exhausting. R kept messaging me all weekend. I told him to stop, that I would see him Monday, but he wouldn’t, and I ended up keeping my phone on silent. Every time I slipped my phone out to check a new message I felt a pang of guilt. I looked up at Travis to see if he noticed anything out of the ordinary, but for all he knew I was just checking Facebook or Instagram.

It’s too reckless for R to be doing that, but if I’m honest, the danger is exciting. Shooting back a message while Travis is sitting right on the other side of the room made me feel naughty in a way I like more than I should. The messages from R got dirtier and dirtier, pushing me to respond in kind. I’d never sexted before. It turned me on. I’m glad Travis is all over me these days, because I needed the release. The rabbit is fun, but it will never replace my husband. Or R. R pestered me for racy pictures, something I’ve adamantly refused up until now. I know how that sort of thing can go. But I finally relented and sent him a picture in my bra and panties from the bathroom on Sunday morning. I didn’t want to make my coming punishment worse. My face wasn’t in it,

of course. I thought about R getting hard when he saw it, and I wished I was there to take advantage. I can't wait to see him again Monday.

Travis is still strangely attentive. It could just be that he senses a change in me, and he's responding to it. But I can't help being paranoid about it. I won't ask about it, because I'm not sure I want to hear the answer.

Going to have to choose something convenient for car sex on Monday. We really need a better solution. I just don't know if lunch gives us enough time to check into a hotel.

So car sex happened. That's all I really got out of the diary at first. I went straight for the recorder in the garage, swapping out the memory cards before the full weight of the rest of the entry hit me.

Annie had sent a photo of herself in a bra and panties to Rick. It was so much against the woman I thought Annie was—and like every other time I'd had this realization, it was so hot. All Rick had to do was ask, something I'd never had the guts to do.

What I hadn't noticed was how much time she thought she'd spent on her phone, flirting via some third party messenger app with him. She was either sneakier than she thought she was, or she was inflating the amount of time she was spending in her head. Out of guilt. Most likely the second, because up until now, she wasn't particularly sneaky about anything.

I got into work early enough that no one else was in, and shut the door to my office. I rarely did this, but as soon as I stuck my earbuds in and loaded the messages from the card onto my computer, I realized it was a good move.

It began, like the last one, with the thud of her door being closed, followed by rustling sounds, bodies moving around and heavy breathing. No "hello." No "you look sexy." Just the sound of a kiss, wet and sloppy, and a gasp. Annie's gasp.

"I knew you'd be fucking wet," Rick said.

"Mmm, how?"

"You were on fire this weekend."

My chest tightened. Had she actually met up with him? I was so frazzled that I didn't remember how she'd written that she hadn't. Instead, I started reviewing all the times she'd left, wondering if she'd had time to meet up with her lover. I almost missed the next couple exchanges.

"...wouldn't leave me alone," Annie whimpered.

"You should have snuck out to see me."

"I can't do that. You know I can't. All that texting was dangerous."

"Did your hubby catch you?" Rick sounded so fucking cocky. I should have hated that, hated that she was with a guy like that. And I *did* hate it. But also, in the secret confines of my office, I had to admit that that was part of the appeal. If Rick was a good guy, a stand up guy, would either of us be as turned on?

"Please...don't..."

"Don't what?"

"You know I don't want to talk about Travis. Not with you."

"You don't have to feel guilty. And I don't have a problem with the guy."

"I mean it, Rick. Don't go there." There was an edge to Annie's voice that made me smile. Even though she was doing this awful and deceitful thing behind my back, she still defended me. She still cared about me in a weird way, I guess.

"Okay, okay. We're not here to talk anyway, are we babe?"

"Mmm...no..." Annie moaned.

"Why are we here, Annie?"

"You know why."

"And you know I want to hear it, babe."

The audio was filled with more sounds of bodies shifting in the backseat. Rick grunted, possessively, hungrily, followed by the sounds of aggressive kissing. Annie let out a moan, cut off immediately by another kiss, more rustling.

I leaned in, closer to the computer, like it would help me hear more. With my eyes shut, I tried to imagine it, to be there, to see these two lovers making out in the confines of her backseat.

Annie's voice came in next, low and sultry. So un-Annie-like. *"We're here because I want you to fuck me."*

The air went out of me. I gasped.

"I can tell. But not yet. I want to taste you."

I listened, but I couldn't figure out what was going on—something heavy hits the seat, then a clicking sound, like rings against a window.

"Oh!" Annie exclaimed.

"That dress Friday was a little easier to get you out of."

"Sorry, I can't always dress to make it easy for you to undress me."

Annie giggled. It made her sound years younger.

"The problem is this car. We need more room, babe."

"Do you want to sneak me into some hotel for a nooner? That's a terrible cliché."

A "nooner." Now that was Annie's language.

"For a reason. That's how grownups have affairs."

Affair. There was that word again, hitting me between the eyes, between the legs. It was like a gut punch, every time. I wondered if it would ever get old.

"We're having an affair now?" Annie sounded amused.

"What else would you call it, babe?"

"I'd...ohhh...mmm...Rick..." she moaned, her words cut off.

I listen as the sounds grow wet, syrupy.

"Oh god...oh god...mmm..."

I listened as Annie moaned, her rings rattling across the glass. She cried out. Their bodies shifted, but I can't imagine how. It's all I could do to listen and ride out the raw eroticism of what I was hearing. *"Rick! Oh god, Rick!"* she cried before losing herself into a deep, satisfied moan.

"Oh Rick...oh god...don't tease me..."

"You're so fun to tease."

"Please...please...PLEASE!"

Rick laughed.

"OH! PLEASE! Please! Please make me come! PLEASE!"

Her voice was almost a scream, loud enough that the audio distorted. Anyone walking by her car would have heard them, heard her. And she didn't seem to care. Wordless cries followed. Rick was giving her exactly what she wanted—to come at his hands, at his touch, at his mouth.

At last, her moans subsided, giving way to panting, to bodies shifting, to the distinctive sound of a zipper going down. Rick groaned. I knew what came next, but the sound of sucking still took my breath away.

"Fuck, babe, you're attacking that dick. I love how much you want it."

The sucking sounds were fast and rhythmic, the kind of blowjobs that Annie now gave. The kind that Rick had taught her to give.

"Ohhh...take it deep...that's it Annie...suck that fucking cock...you suck like a little whore..."

Muffled gagging sounds, but it doesn't sound like Annie stopped.

"Oh fuck...oh fuck...right down your throat, babe."

This went on for several minutes. I looked around, remembering that I was in the office. Outside, I could see movement. Others had come into the office. The day was beginning, normal and mundane. For them. For me, I was crammed into the backseat of a car, listening as my wife cheated on me, and getting off on it.

Rick's breathing grew heavier, more desperate. Listening to him grow close to the edge was intense, almost visceral. I was right there with him, barely able to breathe myself, and ready to explode. Then—

"Wha...why..." Rick gasped, confused.

"I need you inside me. Please fuck me," Annie cooed, her voice so low the recording barely picked it up.

I nearly came. Somehow I didn't. I actually had to turn the recording off and sit there, catching my bearings. A knock came at my office door.

"Yes?"

The day really had begun. Regretfully, I put the headphones away and tried to turn my mind to other things.

*

I didn't actually get back to the recording until the end of the day. I stayed behind, waiting for the last of the office to go home before plugging back in and picking up where I'd left off. Which was startling, because it began with a loud cry from my wife.

"Oh!"

Rick grunted as Annie's moans fell into a slow, yet aggressive rhythm, matched by the shifting springs of her Infiniti.

"That's what you wanted, babe?"

"Yes!"

"You waited all fucking weekend for it."

"Yes!"

"Fucking wet all weekend, waiting until I fucked you again..."

"Oh god YES!" Annie cried out.

"Just like the little married slut you are."

"Yes! Yes, I'm a slut. I'm your slut! Please...please fuck your slut!"

"That's it, Annie. You're off the hook. You miss it. You miss how it was in LA."

"Yes! God, yes!"

But what had she missed, I wondered—briefly, very briefly, before I was sucked back into the sounds of illicit sex.

"I should have come over and fucked you this weekend."

"Rick..."

"Fucked you in your bed..."

"Rick...please..."

"Fucked you in your house...your fucking bed...where you fuck your husband...like a whore..."

"Please...Rick...ohgodohgod!...please..."

"Married...fucking...whore..."

"Yes! I'm a marriedfuckingwhore! Make me your whore! PLEASE!"

"You'll be my whore in your husband's bed!" Rick growled.

"No!" Annie cried.

"Yes!"

"No! Please no!"

Strangely, as was everything about this fantasy of mine, I found myself rooting for Rick here. I wanted him to take her in our bed. I wanted him to convince her to do that, and the more she resisted it, the more I wanted it to happen.

A slapping sound joined the moans and cries, jarring me out of my jarring thoughts. Another slap followed, not hips on hips, but spanking.

"I'll fuck you where I want to fuck you, whore!"

"No!" Slap. *"No!"* Slap. *"Please...Rick..."* Slap. *"God yes! I'm your slut!"*

"I'll fuck you in your bed!"

"Yes! Yes! Ohgodohgodohgod! Yes!"

Annie's cries reached a pitch, but the sounds of their bodies moving together continue for a couple more minutes before Rick grunted and they suddenly stop. Breathing, bodies moving, and other sounds filled the recording. It was quiet for several more minutes, leaving me alone in my

office, touching my erection through my pants and wondering how the hell we got here.

When Annie finally spoke again, her voice was low, serious.

"That can never happen. You know that."

"Yeah," Rick agreed. He didn't believe it, and neither did I.

"I mean it. Tell me you understand. You can't ever come over, let alone be in my bed."

"I get it, Annie. Chill out."

"We were playing, that's all."

A sharp, spanking sound rang out.

Rick spoke, in command. *"We're playing, but remember who's in charge here, babe."*

"You are," Annie whispered.

"You don't want this to stop, do you?"

"No, Rick. You just have to understand..."

"When we're together, you're mine, got it?"

"Yes. I'm yours. I think I proved that today, didn't I?"

"Yeah, you did. Annie."

"You're right, though. We do need a better solution than this. I think I got a cramp."

"My place isn't too far from here. We could always swing by after work."

"I'd need a good excuse for being late."

"Just tell him we're going full throttle on the article."

"That'll do for now," Annie agreed.

"Text him, tell him you'll be late."

"But not too late. I can't stay at your place all night. It's got to be believable."

Rick laughed. *"I'll let you go when I'm done with you."*

"Yes, sir," she replied with mock sincerity.

The recording then skipped ahead, this time to the afternoon, to Annie driving. Because I was listening to this through my computer, I couldn't see the time stamp, but a squirming feeling in my gut told me that she wasn't headed home. Sure enough, after scrubbing forward, she was only in the car for about ten minutes before the door opened and closed again. It shut off, then on again. This time with NPR playing and a longer commute ahead of her.

I ended the recording, sat back in my chair, and stared up at the ceiling. Annie was in deep now, Rick wasn't going to let her go, and she wasn't putting up much fight either. This fire was going to burn hot and bright, and could burn everything around her in the process. Me. Her. Her career.

Yet I wanted that, as much as she did. Annie had lived such a careful, conservative life until now. She'd kept this woman repressed, and as much as a part of me wished that I could have unleashed her, I knew that I couldn't. Not even when we were younger. She wasn't going to marry a guy who could. It wasn't stable, and she craved stability first.

That night, she was home when I got there, dinner fixed and ready. We ate, chatting about our days, both of our minds elsewhere. I did my best to keep my hands off of her until we went to bed. I didn't want her to know that I knew, and I also knew that she suspected that I did—if only subconsciously. She'd been writing about it, noticing me being more into her than ever. Even still, that night, I couldn't resist her, and ended up taking her hard from behind.

Chapter 22

Annie worked late Wednesday, although not too late. She texted, telling me that a few of the people from the office were ordering food to get through all of their notes. I knew the truth of it, and when I scrubbed through the audio recordings the next morning, while there was nothing incriminating that was recorded, the time stamps were enough. In addition to the morning recording, there was one between 5:05 and 5:21, and another between 7:32 and 8:05.

That was over two hours of unaccounted time. She could have been out to dinner, but I also wasn't an idiot, and when she did come home that evening, just after eight, not only was she exhausted, but she seemed distant.

Not cold. Not unfriendly. She didn't look at me with the kind of expression that said, *I wish you were Rick*. But when she did look at me, I saw her guilt, plain as day, before she was able to raise her mask and put on her smile. She went to bed before we had sex, even though I was amped up to. She was just too tired. Whatever Rick had done to her had left her worn out.

The next day, though, we more than made up for it. We went to bed early, but were all over each other for close to an hour. Which was unheard of for the two of us, but apparently routine for her and Rick.

On Friday, she texted that she was joining some coworkers for happy hour and would be "a little late." This time, she got back closer to nine. She came home just as exhausted as before, and just as guilty.

Over the weekend, though, she did her best to be the old Annie. Or at least she played a version of herself, cheery and smart and loving. We cooked dinner together. Raked leaves in the yard and got it ready for the winter. Made love in the evenings—and mornings. If I didn't know better, I could almost be fooled.

But I did know better, and every time I thought of her with Rick, thought of her *affair*, it did something to me. Rage filled my veins. If we were together in bed, I'd suddenly go from making love to fucking. If we were out in the yard, I'd find myself raking harder, seeing red.

The jealousy was not good.

The jealousy was what I craved.

On Monday, she was a little late coming home, and Tuesday she had the built-in excuse of having to go to production. That evening, she came back at eleven, and I almost would have bought that she really had been doing work, except that after giving me a kiss and telling me she was surprised that I was still awake, she went right into the shower. Even in that brief kiss, as chaste as it was, I swore I could smell him on her, his cologne, his musk. His come?

Wednesday, Annie seemed distant again. More distant than normal, lost in thought, a burden on her shoulders. Twice, during a quiet dinner, she looked up at me with a serious look, the kind of look that *could* precede a major confession. My heart quickened as I thought, *She's going to confess.*

That's something I hadn't really thought through. How would *I* react if she did? Could I actually fake being surprised? Being angry? Not being turned on and want to throw her across the kitchen table and fuck her until she screamed?

"What's up, Annie?" I asked after the second time she did it.

It unnerved her. I saw her go white before she reached for her glass of wine. Her hand almost shook. She released a deep breath and shook her head. "Nothing. Just tired. We're getting some blowback from our story, too."

"So the story's up?"

She nodded. "This morning. I should have sent you a link. I'm sorry."

So she had been working some, anyway. It wasn't all hot and sweaty between the sheets. "It's okay. I'll check it out later tonight." I stirred my food. "So it's all been bad?"

She looked up at me, hearing more to my question than even I had intended. She shook her head, reminding herself that I didn't know about her affair. "No, not all bad. Just...controversial is all. And that's not what we wanted. We wanted to show something fair, from all sides. Not something politicized."

"Everything's politicized these days."

"I know."

And like that, we'd moved past the subject. Past the potential confession. The air was cleared, the tension eased, if not gone.

We got ready for bed, and Annie slipped into the shower. She'd shifted her shower schedule to the evenings—maybe to cover her tracks and

legitimize why she had to do it after Rick's, maybe just out of convenience. When she emerged, though, wrapped in a towel and glowing pink from her shower, the look was back in her eyes.

My heartbeat quickened. I pretended to not notice, looking up at her and smiling.

"Trav, I've got something to tell you."

My breath caught. "Okay," I said slowly.

She stood at the foot of the bed, wringing her hands. The pink in her face deepened. "It's a little, um, embarrassing."

Interesting. I nodded.

"So last night, when I came home and took my shower, I was pretty tired, you know. Not really paying much attention. My mind elsewhere."

"Sure."

She glanced up and away. A lie. Whatever came next was a lie. I steeled myself for it. "So I was touching up...things, and kind of slipped when I was doing it. And..." She shut her eyes. "Maybe I should just show you."

With that, she loosened the towel and let it fall damply to the floor. There she was, her full-frontal nudity offered, from her plump breasts to the hour-glass swell of her body to her...completely shaved pussy. Gone was the red landing strip she'd had since Paris. Gone were the red curls she'd had every single day that I'd ever known her. She was shaved completely, deliciously bare.

"Wow." He'd made her do this.

"It'll grow back." Her hands twitched, like she wanted to cover herself.

I tossed the sheets aside and stalked out of bed. Rick had made my Annie, who'd always scoffed at this pornstar look, shave the last bit of modesty away, and it was so fucking hot.

"I think it's sexy," I said, pulling her close and kissing her. She was stiff at first, as if not anticipating this reaction from me or something. I didn't understand that. Hadn't I proven to her that I was into this? Into her behaving badly?

"You don't think it's kind of weird?"

Trailing my hand down between her thighs, I traced my fingers across her sex, across her now buttery smooth skin. "No. I kissed her neck. "It's

naughty.” I kissed behind her ear. “It’s surprising.” With my lips touching her earlobe: “But definitely not weird.”

With that, I pushed two fingers into her. She was wet, despite her nerves, despite her fear. A part of her was excited at being caught, at the risk of this necessary confession. She could hide fucking in the car. She could hide her trips to Rick’s place. But this transgression she couldn’t.

“Uhhh, Trav...” she groaned.

I turned her, lowered her to the bed and onto her back. I was as gentle as I could be, although the beast inside of me awoke. Dipping down, knowing how much she liked oral sex and how naughty her new styling must have made her feel, I ate her bald, cheating pussy, using every trick I knew. I pushed two fingers into her, seeking out the knot of her g-spot and pressing until her body arched and her cries tumbled free. Satisfied that I’d found my mark, I didn’t relent as I sucked and lapped at her pussy. She was so smooth. So soft. I still hadn’t gotten used to the previous style, and yet this was even sexier. So unlike Annie. So out there. Such a slut.

She raked her fingers through my hair as she moaned. “So you like the...like the pornstar look?”

My ears burned. My cock swelled. It was not an Annie-like question. She didn’t tease like that. Not with me. When I tried to answer and she held me fast, pressing her thighs around me, that wasn’t like her, either.

“You like how I shaved it all off?”

I groaned against her pussy, and she gasped.

“It feels so different. So bad. All day today, at work, I felt like everyone was staring at me...ha, yes... Staring like they...like they knew my dirty...little...secret—NGH!”

One man did know her dirty little secret, and she wasn’t just talking about her bush. This was a glimpse into her world, the judgment she felt, and the excitement that came with being that woman.

Annie came hard, pushing her pussy into my face as her body seized and arched. She twisted her legs around me, muffling the cries that spilled from her throat and filled the charged air. It fueled my already boiling adrenaline.

I kicked my pajama pants down around my knees, too impatient to get them completely off, as I climbed up her body and kissed her hard. She didn’t balk at the taste of pussy juice. She didn’t pull back. Instead, she

helped me line my cock up, rubbing it along her smooth slit. Shuddering, she said, "That feels so... uh... good..."

I pushed forward, burying myself to my balls. Her fingernails raked along my back, just shy of leaving a mark. I wondered if she did that with Rick.

"Oh, baby," she cried.

"You're so hot, Annie." I gasped, taking her, fucking her as I imagined Rick did. He had her under a spell. If he could make her do something like this, something that forced her to lie to her husband, that she never would have done if I'd asked, what else could he get her to do?

"You like it?" It was a rhetorical question. She knew that now, and before I could answer, she added another: "You like the shaved look?"

"I like that you did it," I said. "It's so fucking hot that you did that."

I fucked her harder, spurred on by the way her heels dug into my back, riding me, urging me to take her harder.

"Yes, fuck me, Travis. Fuck me!"

I didn't last more than a few more thrusts, but I tried to make them count. I knew she was close. I tried to hold out, but I just couldn't. Not with my fried brain. Not with my world crashing down around me. Not with this hot woman beneath me, who still resembled my wife, but was so much more.

She moaned as I filled her, squeezing me close as she continued to thrust her hips up off the bed. Like she was trying to hump the last drop from me. She moaned like she was coming herself, but I wasn't so sure. Not anymore. Not with the things I'd read. I wondered if she'd sneak away later that night to play with her rabbit. To run the vibrator along a bare mound that she shouldn't have been excited about, but most definitely was.

I collapsed onto her, sweaty and heaving and completely spent.

"You should make more mistakes like that," I said as the last of my energy seeped away.

Annie didn't giggle. She was quiet. Contemplative. I fell asleep before I heard a response.

Chapter 23

Saturday, October 19

I know I've been neglecting writing in this diary, but it just feels like I don't have the time anymore, not with the double life I'm leading. I'm trying to be the perfect wife at home, to compensate for what I'm doing with R, while keeping up with my lover's demands. And still do my job. It's too much for one woman!

Travis is more amorous than ever. It's great, and I love him for it. I have to wonder if I would have started up with R if it had been like this between us before, but I'm not going to torture myself with what ifs. I never deny Travis, I'd feel too guilty, given what I'm doing, but it's tough sometimes. My sex drive has increased since the start of my affair, but R leaves me exhausted, so on the days I come back from his place I'm just not up for it with Travis. I know that's terrible. But I refuse R nothing so I cannot refuse Travis.

We've been going to R's place after work for a couple weeks now. It's not every evening, but at least 2-3 times a week. Sex in the backseat of the Infiniti was fun and exciting, but too limiting. R's king-sized bed is like a canvas where our imaginations can run wild. It turns out LA was only the start. R has me doing things I'd never dreamed I'd do, but as I said, I deny him nothing.

My journey of self-discovery has been a fun one, even if it scares me at times. I've always been drawn to strong men—I feel Travis was more assertive when we were younger—but I truly had no idea I harbored such a submissive streak. I was shocked when R first took control of me. Now I crave it. The first time he ordered me to strip, that night after the gala, I did it hesitantly. R likes to watch me reveal myself to him. I

know now that he likes to control other men's women. That's why he likes married women like me. I do not judge him for it.

That Saturday night was only the tip of the iceberg. After some sight-seeing in the morning, we stayed in that room for the rest of the day Sunday, and R took me at his pleasure. Not only that, he didn't allow me to dress, not really, and I obeyed. I knew what would happen if I didn't. I remember trembling inside when room service came and R only allowed me to wear a thin, tight t-shirt and panties. I was soaked. The second time, I was in bed, barely covered. Knowing that man saw my breasts—tits—drove me wild. I loved R exposing me like that. I loved being possessed. Part of me wanted to disobey, though, because to my shame, I've also learned I crave punishment.

The first time R spanked me, he was fucking me from behind, and it was exciting. It was thrilling, like when he pulled my hair. The second time was when I laughed when he ordered me to go down on him. I fought, but went right over his lap. I stopped fighting after the first couple stinging slaps, and then begged for more with his fingers inside of me. It's hard to write about. Wanting R to control me like that goes against everything I believe as an independent woman, but I also know it's my choice to consent to it.

I shouldn't have been surprised the first time R used his neckties to secure me in his bed. Our best sex in LA was when he held me down on the bed, pinning my wrists against the mattress. I loved when he held my wrists behind my back in the car. His power was intoxicating. My willing submission scared the hell out of me. I might not have let him tie me then, but by the time he introduced it in his bed at home, I trusted him. And he made it worth my while. When he's in control, teasing me, my orgasms are so intense. I'm starting to fear I'll never be able to go back.

There is only one thing I've denied R. He wants to come to our house. He wants me in my bed. My husband's bed. I tell him it's too far, too much. I told him no, told him there's no time to do it anyway. R insists it's going to happen. Luckily, there really isn't a time for it to happen, because I can't be sure I would deny him.

I keep wondering, does being submissive to R compound my sin? I am another man's slut, is it worse that I let him control me? I feel like being R's slut is so bad, it doesn't matter what happens after that, but how would Travis react if he saw how I am with R? It's not just sex. I'm R's willing, eager, compliant slut. Even if Travis could forgive a normal affair, could he forgive that?

I chewed on that last question for a long time after I read it. Gave it some serious thought. She was right, there was a difference between a run-of-the-mill affair, and what was going on with Rick. She was submissive to him. She *wanted* to be submissive to him. I'd never given much thought to the Dom/sub dynamic, but clearly Rick had tapped a part of Annie who had.

One thing she didn't seem to realize, though, was that in some ways, this was easier to deal with than an emotional affair. If her diary was filled with passages about how she's starting to fall for Rick, about how she sees a future with him, or how he's trying to convince her to leave me for him, then I would have had so much more to be scared of. That's what a "normal affair" could have been.

This? This was physical, psychological, emotional, yet in a self-discovery sort of way. How had she put it? "My journey of self-discovery has been a fun one, even if it scares me at times." She was having an affair, she was fucking another man, but I could tell myself that when this was over—and it *would* be over eventually—Annie would still be with me, not with Rick, more in touch with her awakened sexuality than ever.

Yet what would happen if, at the end of her thing with Rick, she realized that she wanted more. That she realized she *could* have more. She was an attractive woman in the prime of her sexual life. She could have anyone she wanted, any experience she wanted. With or without me. What

if she realized that it was easier without having the baggage of guilt that our marriage brought? She wouldn't need to look far to find someone with that freedom, with that life—her own sister, Lisa, was living that dream.

Not that all that rationalizing made any of this easier. She was still having an affair. Still sneaking around behind my back and shutting me out of that part of her life. I wanted back in. I wanted to walk this path with her, to explore with her. I just didn't know how to do that, and meanwhile, the gorilla on my back kept wanting more.

*

“Honey, I need to go out of town next week,” I told Annie one evening, the week after she'd written that diary entry. My plan, like all plans of late, was half-baked at best. I kept my eyes on her, fighting the urge to look away, to look guilty of lying. “You remember David Emery? He's asked me to come as a guest to lecture his class on evolutionary psychology.”

“Oh? Next week?” Annie asked. As always, she'd been lost in her thoughts until I made my announcement, and I wasn't sure she was fully with me. That worked in my favor; she wouldn't catch me in my lie.

“Yeah. I'll be gone Friday morning through Saturday afternoon.”

Her eyes came into focus, like she was seeing me for the first time. “An overnight?”

“Yeah, he's got a couple classes. One's Friday afternoon.” Heat crept up my neck, cooking me in my lie. I itched it, wincing at the look of guilt. “I can probably get out of it.”

She held my gaze just long enough to unnerve me, then shook her head. “No, it's not a problem. It's just a night.”

She was already thinking about Rick, about breaking her vow to have him over, to invite him into our bed. “Yeah, just a night.”

And that was that.

Well, sort of.

There was still over a week before my fake trip, and all the intensity that built up around that. I actually booked a round trip flight, forwarding my itinerary to Annie. I booked a room, although it was at a small boutique place just outside of town where I could sit and watch from afar.

The watching was the trickiest part, but in our age of technology, not all that hard. Small surveillance cameras weren't too expensive. I ordered three, and on the Saturday before my trip, while she was horseback riding, I hid them around the house. Two went in the bedroom—one just over our wardrobe, where it pointed down over our bed, and the other hidden on my nightstand, in a lamp that I never turned on. The third I placed in the living room, angled to catch the sofa and the front door in the background. I could watch them over WiFi from anywhere.

I retrieved Annie's iPad again, checking her messages out of habit. They were still sanitized, only a few between Rick and my wife, but all of them business. Looking at her app purchase history, I discovered that she'd added SnapChat right around her trip to California, and while I was tempted to download it to her iPad, I knew there was no way I'd be able to access her account.

Wasn't why I was on there, anyway. I brought up her Find My Phone app. A quick check located her out in the country, where we stabled Ruby. A part of me was relieved by the discovery. It hadn't even occurred to me that she could have been sneaking over to Rick's instead of going riding. This made sense, though. I still remembered how she'd written that riding her horse was one of the few things that cleared her head and made her feel sane. Maybe she wouldn't cave and let Rick come over, after all.

But was that really what I wanted? I knew I should have wanted that.

*

Friday arrived with the feverish excitement of Christmas as a kid. I couldn't sleep the night before, and I got up early, well before my 6:15 alarm. My "flight" took off at 9, so I needed to leave before normal. Which would give Annie the whole day, and a good part of tomorrow, to...be bad. My chest tightened.

"You don't need me to drop you off at the airport?" she asked, blinking sleepily from where she lay in bed. We'd made love last night, and she'd fallen asleep naked. As she turned to look at me, though, her bare leg emerged, along with the swell of her hip, and my cock came alive.

"Nah. I'll just park my car there. It's just a night, and I can expense it." I was getting pretty good at this lie, I thought to myself.

“I’ll miss you.” She still had sleep in her voice, giving her a husky, sexy sound.

I almost went over there, tempted to rip the sheets off the bed and throw her onto her back again. I watched her eyes come into focus, as if she was having the same fantasy. I didn’t, and you know why? It wasn’t because I didn’t want her, or that I didn’t have enough time. It was this fear that if I did, then maybe it would cool her off enough to resist Rick later that day.

This wasn’t a fear that I needed to worry about, apparently.

With my bag at my side, I kissed her one last time and rolled it on out of our house. I actually did drive toward the airport for a few miles, speeding along the highway to match the blistering pace of my heart beat.

I turned around and made a slower trip back to my hotel, careful to take roads that Annie wouldn’t use on her way to work—if she even *went* to work today. I was shaking by the time I pulled into the parking lot. It was just past seven in the morning by the time I checked in and was up in my room, windows drawn, laptop on the WiFi.

I had no idea what to expect on those cameras, but found it hard to breathe as I booted up my surveillance software. My stomach swarmed and fluttered. Heat crawled across my scalp. My cock was so, so hard.

The audio loaded before the video, and immediately my ears started burning.

“Ohhh... uhh...”

Was he there already? That was fast.

A second later, the video came through. Rick wasn’t there, but his proxy—her rabbit vibrator—definitely was. She was on her back, eyes closed, legs spread wide as she slid the pink, buzzing vibrator in and out of her pussy. Her free hand was pressed against the top of her mound, holding the skin around her clit taut as the clit-stimulator of the rabbit bounced against her.

Annie looked amazing. So sexual. So hardcore. She sank her teeth into her lower lip as she rocked her head back, her rich, copper locks splaying across her pillow. “Oh, yes,” she moaned, reaching a crescendo. “Oh—” Her breath caught, then: “FUCK!”

She came hard and loud, a private, unrestrained moment that I knew I shouldn’t be witnessing. She was alone—or thought that she was—and held nothing back. With the vibrator buried eight inches deep and the stimulator

right up against her clit, she arched up, thrusting her free hand behind her head, beneath her pillow, and nearly twisted with the fury of her orgasm.

When she came down, she rolled onto her side and released a satisfied laugh. For a moment, I thought that she might have gone back to sleep, but as the moment passed, she pulled the vibrator out, slipped out of bed, and wandered into the bathroom.

She took a long shower, preparing for Rick. I knew, because she'd left the door open. I could watch her move behind the steamed up curtain of the shower. I could imagine what she was doing, based on the vague shapes I was seeing. Washing her hair. Her body. Shaving her legs, her armpits. Her pussy.

She emerged, pink and naked, and didn't bother wrapping a towel around herself. No need for modesty. Not when she was alone. She slathered lotion over her pale, soft skin, paying particular attention to the smooth and sensitive rise of her hairless mound.

She spent a good deal of time picking out what to wear. I wondered if she did this every day—or maybe just the days when she knew that she was meeting Rick. The bra and panty set she settled on were new. Or at least new to me. Red lace, the bra was padded and the panties were a thong. She checked herself out in the mirror, going up onto her toes to check out her butt. She frowned at what she saw—something that I didn't see. Her ass looked fantastic.

After going through her closet, she settled on a dark brown sweater dress—snug, but not tight, with a loose, cowl neck and a hem that nearly reached her knees. It was professional, even if what she wore beneath was not. Just as I thought that, she went back to her lingerie closet and retrieved a pair of stockings—thigh highs, champagne colored and lace-topped.

After doing her makeup, she left the camera's view of the bedroom. I shifted to the living room one, and a moment later, she appeared, going into the hall closet to put on a pair of soft, brown boots.

With her hair loose, it occurred to me once again just how professional she looked, and how unprofessional she was being. I wondered if anyone else in the office knew what was going on. What a frightening thought.

I'd taken her iPad with me on my "trip," and once she was out the door, I followed the blip of her phone over GPS. I half-figured that she'd not even go to work. That she'd go straight to Rick's. As exciting as that

would be, it would also be crushing because they'd probably not make it back to the house, and all my preparation would be for nothing.

But she went to work. She spent almost all day there. I ate. Toiled. Checked email and actually did some work from the hotel room, obsessively keeping an eye on Annie's phone location. It barely moved.

Until just after three in the afternoon.

That's when she came home.

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Chapter 24

It's hard to describe how I felt as I watched that blip move down the highway. How I switched to the video feed from the living room, conscious of each, shallow breath and the acute sense of hyperventilation I seemed to keep just at bay. My fingertips were sweaty along the keyboard of my laptop. My whole body shook.

And then...

And then Annie entered the house. Alone.

The door shut behind her. She looked around the house. "Hello?" she called out. Which was weird. "Travis, you here?"

This was recon, I realized. She was being very careful. Which meant...what? She suspected that I knew? She actually went through the house—from what I could tell with my limited view—checking the rooms and calling out to see if I was there. I heard the basement door open and close.

Then, back in the front hallway, she was on her phone. To me.

[Annie]: Hey, honey, hope your sessions are going well.

She seemed to grimace, waiting there for my response. Before I could compose even an immediate response, though, she shook her head and stalked off camera, into the kitchen.

[Me]: It's fine. Kind of boring so far.

I almost added something like "missing you," but deleted it. It seemed like she was struggling, looking for an excuse not to do this. I wasn't going to give it to her.

[Annie]: I bet you could do those in your sleep now. Well, I may get together for dinner with Lisa tonight. Still not sure. Missing you already.

I read her guilt in the over-explaining. I actually saw it as she paced back out into the hall. She thumbed something into her phone, stopped

abruptly, shaking her head and whipping the phone to her side with a grimace.

“What are you doing, Annie?” The mics were good enough to pick it up, even though it was muttered from across the room. She stood there, motionless, for a long time, her eyes shut, conflict warring through her.

Then, she lifted the phone again, finished whatever she was writing, and appeared to hit send. This time, my phone didn’t rumble. The text wasn’t for me, and that realization landed with a throb.

Annie waited there for a response, but when one didn’t come immediately, she stormed back off camera, back into the kitchen. When she emerged next, she had a glass of white wine in her hand, and was reading something on her phone.

She went to the living room couch, sat down, crossed her legs, and began to formulate her response. I watched her carefully, her body language, her facial expressions. The guilt was still there, coming through in the occasional grimace or the knit in her brow, but it had been replaced by a playfulness that I associated with the side of Annie that Rick brought out. Like the Annie I’d met in her early twenties, free from the burdens of adulthood.

She rolled her eyes while giggling at the same time. *Giggling*. Going so far as to cover her mouth as she did so, like a schoolgirl. She typed a reply, got up—her wine glass mostly empty and left on the coffee table—and lifted her sweater dress up over her head, treating me once again to a view of her red bra and panties, her sheer stockings, her soft leather boots. Those boots came off next before she crossed the room, her ass to the camera, looking so delicious in just a thong.

At the closet beside the front door, she put her boots away and retrieved the black patent leather heels that she’d packed for California. The ones with the tall, slender heels and the bright red soles. Paired with the rest of her lingerie, and the way she tied her hair back into a high ponytail, she looked like a sex goddess. Or a porn star.

She went back out of the frame, her legs and ass looking even better with the lift from those heels. I heard the refrigerator door open and close, a beer open, and the doorbell ring.

I took a deep breath, leaning in to the video on my laptop. This was it. The moment I’d been waiting for.

It was hard to believe that the woman dressed in almost nothing, wearing heels and holding an open bottle of my craft beer as she answered the door, was my wife. My Annie.

Maybe she wasn't. Maybe not now, not in this tense moment as she gave another man the one thing she said she never would.

She took a deep, cleansing breath, eyes closed, and opened the door. At least she shielded her body behind it so the neighbors wouldn't see, but I had to wonder what they would think, seeing a strange man enter our house on a Friday afternoon. It made me queasy, but no less excited. I felt the thrill of the danger, just as surely as Annie must have.

Rick entered, a cocky swagger in his gait—shoulders back, his muscled chest prominent in his light blue button down, tucked into his Friday casual jeans. He looked like a venture capitalist, used to money and people laying the world at his feet.

"Nice home," he said, looking around. His eyes stopped on Annie, taking in her red bra, her thong, her stockings and heels. "Very nice home."

"I can't believe you talked me into this."

"Can't you?" He stepped close, putting his arms around her and pulling her against him. "I don't think there's anything you wouldn't let me talk you into."

It was so strange, seeing these two together after experiencing their affair through her words and the recordings for so long. As profound as the imagination can get, it didn't compare to watching this man, dark haired, tanned, fit, taller than Annie by almost a head, lean down and kiss her hard on the mouth. And watching her yield to that kiss so completely.

"So tell me, Annie, where do you want me to fuck you today?"

She started to shake her head when Rick reached behind her, grasped her ponytail, and pulled.

"Where, Annie? Deep down, where do you want me to violate you?"

She looked so vulnerable like that, head pulled back, the muscles in her neck as tight as piano wire. "Here. My house."

"Be more specific."

"My bed," she whispered, the mic barely catching it. Her shame was evident.

"Your marital bed?"

The breath went out of her as she confessed, "Yes. My marital bed."

It went out of me, too, as a great weight seemed to press down on my chest.

He reached down and took the beer from her. My beer. “This for me?” He didn’t wait for a response before taking a swig of it. “Now, be a good little slut and welcome me home.”

Annie knew what to do, even if I was momentarily confused. She dropped to her knees, her hands stroking down his muscled body as she did so. With her eyes on his the whole time, she unbuckled his belt and opened his pants. He just watched her, drinking my beer and willing her to be bad for him.

I had the perfect view, in profile, her chest rising and falling, her fingers pulling his shirt tails from his jeans.

“It’s been two whole days since you’ve had it in your mouth. I’ve missed your mouth.”

She didn’t reply. She focused on her slutty task, reaching into his briefs and pulling out his thick slab of meat.

It was in her mouth before she’d fished it all the way out.

“That’s it, baby. Suck my cock. Show me how deep you can take it.”

She showed him—and me—relaxing her jaw as she took him nearly all the way to his root before gagging and pulling back. Undeterred, she went right back in without having to be prompted, determined to swallow all of him, to show him what a good slut she was.

Rick looked around as my wife serviced him, sipping at the beer and taking in the life that we shared. That he was now violating. “It really is a nice place. You do the decorating, Annie? You’ve got great taste.”

She didn’t answer, seeming to know that it wasn’t a real question. Or maybe she was just too engrossed in the deep-throating blowjob. When he looked down at her again, he refocused on her, too, reaching down to wrap his free hand around her ponytail again.

“Mmm, that’s it, Annie. Take it all in. That feels so fucking good...”

When she tried to pull back and catch her breath, this time he held her close, preventing her. Her nostrils flared as she fought for breath, as she struggled against him. He leaned into her, pressing his hips forward until he lodged himself down her throat. Only then, as her eyes grew wide with panic, did he pull himself out. All the way. The full length and girth of him finally revealed to me.

“That’s enough for now, Annie. We’ve got all afternoon, and all night, to play. But right now, I want a tour.”

He kicked off his jeans, but pulled his black briefs back up, his still-hard cock not fitting back in.

Annie rose. In her heels, she was still shorter than him, but not so short that he had to bend much to kiss her. Her hands went to the buttons of his shirt, opening them one by one as they made out. He wore nothing beneath, and as he pulled it from his thick arms, she ran her fingers across his pecs, through the dark crop of hair that spread across his barrel of a chest.

“God, you’re sexy,” she purred, almost to herself.

But not to herself. It was to Rick, too, a sign of submission to him. This whole scene dripped of that submission. Like when she went back down to her knees to take off his shoes and socks. Or when he stroked her hair. Or when he said, “Did you shave for me this morning?”

“Of course.”

“Bare, just like I like it?”

“Totally bare.”

“Good, then I won’t have to punish you...for that.”

She shivered.

“Now, show me your bedroom.”

“I thought you wanted the tour of the house.”

“Your bedroom’s the only room I give a fuck about. Now show me.”

She nodded. Her guilt was gone. To Annie, I was gone. Forgotten. She was here for this man’s pleasure, and got off on that. As she turned away, he slapped her ass as he followed her up the stairs. She giggled softly, wiggling her butt at him and moved faster.

I switched cameras to the bedroom—the view from over her wardrobe and over the bed. I heard them down the hall, laughing and bantering.

“A king. Very nice,” I heard Rick say. “And you made it all nice for me?”

They appeared on screen, Annie in front, Rick just behind her, hugging her against him. “Wanted to look presentable.”

“God, I love taking something so clean and neat and messing it all up.” He pulled back and slapped her ass again. “Now get up there on the bed. I want to watch you.”

A strand of hair had escaped from her ponytail, catching in the gloss of her lips as she glanced back at him. “Watch me do what?” she asked coyly.

“I know you own a toy, remember?”

“I don’t need a toy. I want you. Come here, baby.”

“I wasn’t asking, Annie.” He swatted her ass again. She yelped. “Give me a show.”

She crawled onto the bed, going over to her nightstand to retrieve the toy from where she hid it beneath her papers. Rick stared at her ass, bisected by that red thong. “Love that ass.”

Annie looked back at him as she reached into her nightstand drawer, rolling her eyes at him. She was pleased. Pulling out the black velvet bag she kept it in, she opened the catch and drew out the pink vibrating rabbit that I’d just watched her play with that morning.

“When did you use it last?”

“This morning.”

“Didn’t I tell you not to play with yourself at all? Another strike against you.”

“I’m sorry.”

“You’re going to be more than sorry. You’ve been bad, Mrs. Belmont. Now show me what you did with that thing this morning.”

She nodded, sinking back into the pillows, lifting her hips, and sliding the thong off her body. Once again, I was treated with a glorious view of her pussy, glistening and spread open. Switching on the vibrator, she met Rick’s eyes as he sat on the edge of the bed, and ran the longer shaft of the toy along her slit.

Her eyelids grew heavy, but she kept on looking at her lover. The eye contact was actually more erotic to me than anything she did with the toy, though. This connection that these two had developed over the last few months was so tangible, so wrong, so illicit, but so real. She’d do anything for him, I realized. She already had.

Rick watched her orgasm build, watched her moan and sigh as she pushed the vibrator into her pussy and tickled her clit with the smaller arm of the rabbit. And just before she reached her peak, just as she started to nibble on her lower lip and roll back into her climax, he reached out and took the vibrator out of her hand.

“That’s enough.”

“No!”

“Don’t want you coming just yet, Annie. You’ve already done that once today.”

“But—”

“Don’t worry, Annie. I’ll make you come.” He set the vibrator aside as he crawled up onto the bed, up between her legs. He skimmed his palm across our bedspread. “I’ll make you scream, right in your own bed.”

Placing a hand on the inside of her thigh, he pushed her legs wider apart. I switched to the bedside camera as his head obscured her pussy.

“Take those tits out,” he said, staring up at her, his face just next to her pussy, so close, yet not touching. “Love the bra, but I love watching you play with your tits as I eat you even more.”

Annie did as she was told, without hesitation, arching her back and reaching behind her to pop the clasp. Her full tits tumbled free. The camera was so good that I could see her freckles and the beads of sweat that had gathered in her cleavage. I could see just how hard and swollen her nipples were, puffed out and longer than she normally got for me.

As she started playing with those swollen caps, that’s when Rick dove down between her thighs, running his tongue along her bare gash.

“So wet,” he mumbled, lapping at those engorged pussy lips, dodging her clit. The more he teased her, the harder she pinched her nipples, twisting and lifting her hips to his mouth. He didn’t give her what she wanted until she begged for it.

“Stop teasing me, Rick!” she cried out around her gasps. “Eat me. *Please!*”

“That’s a good slut. I wasn’t sure you were really into this.” He ran his thumb up her slit, brushing her clit. Annie shuddered.

“I do. I *dooo!*”

He dipped down, flicking her bud with the tip of his tongue, rapid and relentless, before clamping his whole mouth over her cunt and brushing the flat of his tongue over her.

She arched up, her tits thrust at the ceiling, mashing them together as she cried out. As she worked herself right up to the edge again.

And then Rick pulled away, giving her pussy one last lick before crawling higher.

“No!” she protested, panting hard. “I’m so close.”

“That’s the point, Annie. So close, yet so far. Only I get to tell you when you come, and you don’t get that until I have.”

Kicking his boxers off, he freed that thick and iron hard cock of his once again. The angle I had was devastating. I felt so inadequate—and

because of what I was, it only made me harder.

I held my breath as he wrapped his hand around his erection and laid it across Annie's pussy. This was it. This was the moment where I saw just how bad my wife was, where I got definitive proof that she was being unfaithful.

But no. He slid his cock along her smooth and glistening pussy, getting off on the friction as he went to work bathing her nipples with his tongue, but didn't penetrate her. Instead, he used her like a toy—or she used him like one.

“Just put it in me,” she cried.

“That what you want?”

“Yes!”

“You want my big cock, you cheating slut?”

“Yes, I want...want your big cock...so badly!”

“Maybe a taste,” Rick said, pulling back and pushing a couple inches into her.

Annie's body seized, her fingernails clawing down his back and shoulders as he split her.

“You're so tight, Annie. I can never get over that.”

“Because you're so...you're so...”

“Yes?” He thrust forward, burying more of himself into her.

“Big!”

“You like that?”

“Uhhhh... yes...”

“Tell me. Talk dirty for me.”

“I love how big your cock is. How...fffffull it makes me...makes me feel!”

She thrashed, once again on the cusp of a climax. And once again, Rick denied her, pulling out of her with a cruel grin.

“No, please no!”

Rick didn't give in, continuing to string her along. He caressed her body as he kissed up her neck and behind her ears. “Your skin is so soft, Annie. Like silk.”

They made out only a couple feet from my hidden camera. The mics picked up every smack, every sigh, every groan.

“You get to come after I come, remember?” He stared down at her, dominating as surely as a pair of handcuffs would. He didn't raise his voice.

He wasn't complaining or demanding or grumbling. He was unflinching in his confidence. In what he wanted. He dipped down, as if to kiss her again. She raised her lips to meet his, mouth already parted, but he held back just an inch. Whispered: "So make me come."

He moved up her body again, straddling her chest, his thick cock hard. He was shaved just as bare as she was, and his veiny erection curved upward, capped in a bulbous, circumcised crown.

Annie bent her neck as he fed it into her mouth again, going up onto his knees to slide it all the way back down her throat. "Fuck, my cock looks so good with your lips wrapped around it." He fucked her face for a few strokes before pulling back and letting her breath.

Annie knew what was expected now, though, and didn't need prompting. She reached out, circling his shaft with her fingers. Lifting it, she dipped low to lap at his shaved balls, swirling her tongue around his sac before swallowing them both into her mouth.

"Fuck yeah, baby. Don't hold back. Do your thing."

Releasing his balls, she ran zig-zags up his shaft before popping it back into her mouth, spit and saliva dripping from her mouth.

"That feel good?" she asked between sucks.

"You know it does."

"You like watching me blow your big cock?"

"Oh, fuck."

"How about when I do this?"

She slid up, higher on the bed, but still reclined, and pushed his cock into her cleavage. With her eyes on his, she wrapped her tits around his shaft and began to mash and massage them around him.

"You like fucking my tits, Rick?"

"Fuck."

"I like it, too, you know."

"You like being my slut, don't you?"

"I do. I love being your slut. Your whore."

"In your marital bed." He took control, thrusting in and out of the fleshy channel between her breasts. "Have you fucked your husband with these tits yet?"

"Rick," Annie said, warning in her voice.

"I bet you haven't. Still keeping this naughty side a secret." He reached back, snatching at something that I couldn't see. I didn't need to.

The buzzing gave it away. "I'm fine with it. I like being in on the secret." He rubbed the shaft of the vibrator along Annie's gash. "I like that you do things for me that you wouldn't dare do for him."

Annie didn't deny it. She couldn't. Not through her moans. Not when all she could do was push her chest higher, squeeze her tits tighter around his shaft, and open her legs.

"I bet you'd have a threesome with me. I bet I could get you to do that."

"I don't... I couldn't..."

"You know how I feel about that word, Annie. There's nothing you *can't* do."

With one hand on her shoulder, his hips rutting up and down her chest, he drove her vibrator into her cunt. Annie cried out, squeezing her titflesh even tighter around his shaft as she fought back her orgasm.

"I want you to imagine this isn't a vibrator, but another man. Think you could handle it?"

"Noooo!"

"Want to try?"

"Oh! Oh! Oh my... fuck!"

"You know you do. You know you want it. Deep down, there's the slut in there who wants...*this!*"

Annie moaned louder, her words losing meaning beyond raw excitement.

"Think of two live cocks in you, baby. Think of two hard bodies wanting you, using you. Filling you. Pulling your hair and tossing you around like the whore you really want to be."

His words burned through me, as much as they burned through my wife. She'd do it. She would. She'd do it for Rick. And would it stop there? How far would she go? How much would she lose herself before this affair burned out? And why didn't I want it to stop, even then?

"I'm close, baby," he said.

"Please," she moaned, her voice nearly a squeal. "Come, Rick. Please come!"

He fucked her tits faster, spurred on when she bent her head forward to lap at his cockhead with each forward thrust. "Yes, yes. I'm nearly...nearly..."

Yanking back, he lifted up onto his knees, grabbed his cock, and sprayed his come all over Annie's chest and face, coating her in more sperm than I thought possible.

I nearly came myself. I don't know how I didn't. I'd been touching myself through my slacks as I watched, but my hand was cramping up. I grabbed the laptop and moved to my own bed, positioning it at my side, almost like looking through a window.

When I did look again, Rick was flipping Annie over, her come-coated tits pillowed beneath her, her ass raised. "I should clean up," she protested. "Stains—"

"Exactly," Rick said, shoving her down against our comforter. "Rub my come into your sheets. Things are only going to get dirtier before I leave."

He pulled her hips up, lifting her ass off the bed, into the air.

"Rick—" she began, before Rick spanked her ass. Hard. She yelped. I jumped. This was too far. Too much.

"What's that, my married slut?"

"I just think that I should clean up—"

SLAP!

"It's fine. I don't mind getting a little messy, either." Rick rose up behind her, his hands grabbing her reddening ass cheeks, and lined himself up against her pussy. I didn't know where to look—between Rick's mounted position and Annie's face, still spattered with his pearly juices. As he thrust forward, it was her face that I finally focused on, watching her tense up, eyes shut tight, mouth slack, as he drove his cock balls deep.

What I saw there was complete and total surrender to the man fucking her. To being used in a way that even she'd written she shouldn't love, but couldn't get enough of.

"I love this ass, Annie. From the day we first met, I knew I had to have it." He spanked her again, drawing a sharp moan from my wife. "Love the jiggle. Love the meatiness."

Annie kept moaning and gasping, and I wasn't sure if she was even listening to him. "Fuck me," she cried. "Oh, you feel so good."

"So do you, babe. So fucking tight."

"Yes, yes! Fuck my tight pussy."

Rick slapped her again, this time grabbing a chunk of her ass cheek and squeezing. Annie cried out in pleasure more than pain. "You like it

rough, don't you?"

Annie didn't answer. Couldn't answer. She'd snaked her hands down beneath her, to play with her pussy as Rick drove himself deep.

He reached out with his free hand and grabbed her by the ponytail, pulling back. "*Don't you?*"

"Yes!"

"I knew you had a wild side, but you still surprise me, Mrs. Belmont." He slapped her as he took her, as he rode her to her wild conclusion. "Such a pleasant surprise, too!"

"Fuck...*meee!*"

Pulling on her hair hard enough to lift her chin from the pillows and thrust her body into a taut bow, he obliged, fucking her in long, hard thrusts.

I switched angles, watching them fuck from above, Rick's muscled back and buttocks clenching with each stroke. When she was close, her quick gasps so shallow that even I felt like I was hyperventilating, Rick pushed his thumb against Annie's asshole, hard enough to push the tip in.

"Oh! Oh my—oh my—" The rest of it was lost in a scream so loud it distorted the sensitive mics of my cameras. She screamed *Rick* and *fuck* and *yes!* all at once, the words jumbling together in a pleading cacophony.

And that was only the beginning. Rick flipped her over before she'd recovered, bleary and drunk on her orgasm. He used my pillow to wipe the last of his come from her body as he opened her legs, hooking them over his shoulders, and entered her again.

They fucked for hours. I lost track of the time, but couldn't take my eyes off the monitor. At some point, they paused to take a break and jump in the shower, but even that led to a slippery shower fuck. I knew because they left the bathroom door open, and I could watch their blurred shapes through the shower curtain enough to know that he held her against the wall, fucking her standing up.

After that, they emerged like a couple, toweling off in front of one another, completely at ease with their nudity. Rick pulled her in for a kiss that she returned without hesitation. When he went to pull open her towel, though, she spun away.

"Slow down there. I'm starving." He grabbed for her one last time and she giggled. "Let's order some food."

"Let's go out somewhere."

“No way. You can’t be seen with me. Everyone in Kingston knows everyone else. They’ll talk.”

“Thought you liked the risk.”

Annie shook her head. “Not that much risk.”

Rick groaned.

Annie said, “Come on, let’s go order pizza.”

“Put on one of his dress shirts. I want you to answer the door like that.”

Annie rolled her eyes, but when she crawled off the bed, she went to my closet and removed a white Oxford. The tails covered her, but only barely.

“Like this?”

Rick put an arm behind his head, his biceps flexing impressively. “Hm... throw on some stockings, too. The ones from earlier would be perfect.”

“But this shirt won’t cover the tops.”

“Exactly.”

And again, she followed instructions as he grabbed his phone and ordered pizza. Maybe she didn’t have limits after all. Maybe he’d make her blow the pizza man. She’d fuck him. She’d fuck them both, at the same time, right in my own living room, in my own bed.

When I imagined that, I was hard again. The anxiety that had filled the vacuum left by my last orgasm was gone, replaced by this rabid and all-consuming lust. This was just as unhealthy as Annie’s submission, as her inability to resist Rick. Just as destructive. Worse, we both knew it.

Maybe that’s why I pulled my pants on and grabbed my keys. Maybe that’s why I stuffed my laptop back into my bag, splashed a little water on my face, and headed home. I couldn’t watch from afar anymore. I didn’t want to view things through a screen, or any other medium. I needed to see it with my own eyes. To hear it with my own ears. I needed to be there, to witness first hand Annie’s affair.

Chapter 25

I hadn't planned to do this. When I set up this fake trip, I'd fully intended to stay in my hotel room and watch from afar, playing voyeur from a safe spot. It was exciting, the way porn was exciting. This was on another level. By the time I pulled into our neighborhood, my heart was beating so fast that I was shaking.

I parked a couple blocks away, so that there would be no chance I'd be seen, then just sat there in the car, trying to control my breathing. My phone buzzed, and I nearly jumped out of my skin.

[Annie]: Hey, honey. How did it go?

I wondered what she was doing as she sent his. Were they sitting around, having that pizza? Or was he fucking her again? God, how much he'd already fucked her was insane.

[Me]: Went very well, actually. But I'm pretty beat. You get together with Lisa?

[Annie]: No, decided just to stay in tonight.

Uh huh.

[Me]: Sounds like a good idea.

[Annie]: Love you, Travis. Have a good night. xo

[Me]: I love you, too. See you tomorrow.

I wasn't going to get any calmer than this. With my laptop bag at my side, I got out of the car, pulled my coat around me, and started on my way toward our house. It was only 8 o'clock, but it felt *late*. When I saw people driving along our street, and the lights on in the houses along Belvedere, it seemed strange. Like they were encroaching into my fantasy world.

I cut along a path through the trees and out onto my street, the street I'd lived on for so many years. It seemed so strange that it existed in the

same space as the surreal one I felt I'd entered. There was the tree that Olivia had fallen out of as a kid. There was the bench we'd sat on when Annie told me that she was pregnant.

And there was my house, just at the bend, where Annie was fucking another man. Even just seeing his little sports coupe parked on the street out front sent a jolt through me.

I still had no plan, even as I walked up to the house. I couldn't just walk in through the front door. I didn't know where they were inside. If they were still eating in the kitchen, or cuddling on the sofa. They could have been anywhere.

Luckily, I had cameras inside. I ducked along the side of the house, doing so as casually as I could. Anyone looking would just see me, the owner of this house, heading into his own backyard. Right?

There, though, I crouched down beneath our deck, out of sight, and pulled out my laptop. Plugging earphones in before booting up—something I almost forgot—I got onto our WiFi network and loaded my video feeds.

I didn't know what to expect. It had been just under an hour since I'd left the hotel, and only about ten minutes since she'd texted me. Even still, I half-expected them to be going at it again. Instead, I stumbled upon what seemed to be a serious scene.

"You're not good for me, Rick. I'm not going to keep doing this."

They were sitting on the sofa, Rick behind Annie, holding her as she worked through her thing. It was intimate, but not sexual. She still wore just my shirt, her leg propped against her chest, most of it bare. He was still naked, it appeared, but his hands just rested on her.

Annie glanced back at him, her hair slightly curled and falling half out of her face. "We've got to stop doing this."

"You keep saying that, and you keep coming back. I don't think you really want that." And then, quieter and less certain than I thought him capable of, he added, "I know I don't want it."

Annie gasped, ever-so-quietly. "Why me? You could have anyone out there. You've *had* many. Why do you want some old, forty-year-old married woman?"

Again, Rick surprised me by not answering with quick bravado. He contemplated his answer, like he wanted to give a thoughtful one. "I've told you before, I really...like that you're not a girl. You're a woman. A

particularly gorgeous woman at that. I think you know that, too, but pretend that you're not. And that's hot, too."

"Gorgeous. I don't—"

"You do. You *do* know. Remember how all those men looked at you in LA? Remember how I pointed out how they couldn't keep their eyes from you? Because I remember. And I remember how excited it made you."

"That was all you."

But Rick was already shaking his head. "No. Not just me. You say I could have anyone I want. You can, too. I'm not the only guy at the Herald who's noticed."

"You haven't told anyone—"

"Of course not, no. They don't know, which may be why they feel comfortable telling me when you're wearing a nice skirt one day, or how good a pair of pants look on you."

"Are all men pigs?"

"All men look. And they like what they see." He played with the button of the shirt without undoing it. "It actually makes me wonder about you."

"Wonder what?"

"Why me?" he said. I couldn't quite tell if Rick was teasing her or was genuine. "You're attractive, smart, compassionate. You seem to love your husband, despite, you know...me. So why *are* you with me?"

"I...don't know."

"Come on, Mrs. Belmont. You can do better than that. I've seen you get into the heads of some very guarded people. Can't get into your own?"

"With Travis..." She began slowly, picking through her thoughts. I leaned in, interested. "I'm this very established persona. Mrs. Annie Belmont. Prestigious. Responsible. Respectable. Did you know I'm a deacon at our church?"

"I'm not surprised, but is it weird that that turns me on?"

Annie glanced back at him, but moved past it without comment. "I like that Annie. A lot. I love the life she lives, the family she has."

"But she's boring," Rick finished.

"No. Not at all." Annie sighed. "You can't understand what it's like until you live it. I may not go out to fancy restaurants all the time, or live in the city, or do whatever you Millennials do for fun these days, but my life, my family, is so rewarding."

“But?”

Annie sighed again. “I don’t know.”

“I think you do.”

Annie was quiet. For a long time. So long that I thought she might have gotten fed up with Rick’s insistence. Then: “That Annie is the way she is because she made herself that way. She always did the right thing. Got the best grades. Dated the right boys. Followed the rules. It’s like everything in my life, I’ve planned out. I’m exactly where I want to be. Right now.”

“Right now?”

Annie seemed to realize that she was in the arms of another man, in our living room. “Okay, so not *right now*—”

“And that’s the point,” Rick finished. “You need someone who takes you out of your comfort zone. You need someone to push you to do things that you wouldn’t have the courage to do.”

“I’m not sure ‘need’ is the right—”

“But it is a need, right? A want. A craving. *You* told me that your husband was traveling today. You didn’t have to. You could be having an affair with anyone, but it’s me you keep coming back to.” Rick slipped his hand beneath her shirt tails, and Annie stiffened, her mouth parting. “You want me because I can give you a taste of that other Annie without fear of losing the first.”

Annie shook her head, but talk was getting difficult with his undulating hand. “People aren’t...aren’t so simple. We aren’t made up of this...” She groaned. “This side and that. I’m... I’m not going to blame a darker, naughtier Annie. I’m me. The same.”

“No,” Rick said. “Not the same. The woman I met last spring is different from the one now. The woman who told me how hot it makes her when she shaves her pussy.” Annie released a loud cry. “Or the woman who loves feeling my cock in her throat, gagging her.”

“Okay, okay. Not the same. But...more like evolved.”

“Forever evolved,” Rick agreed. “Freed, I’d even say.”

She arched her back, thrusting her chest forward as Rick twisted open the buttons of the shirt, one at a time.

“Let’s go upstairs,” Rick said, once her shirt was open. “Time to keep evolving.”

Annie giggled, getting up out of his lap and shucking her shirt dramatically. Beneath, she wore nothing but her pale stockings, and walked away from Rick and the camera with a playful swing in her hips.

Rick hopped up, too, his dick semi-hard, and followed her with a grin. He did grab something from his coat, which he'd left by the front door, before they went upstairs.

I waited until I saw them on the bedroom camera before closing my laptop up. Taking a deep breath, I figured that now was the time. Now or never. I felt like a walking ball of flame. Everything burned as I crept toward the basement door and snuck in through our utility room.

It was eerily quiet down here, only the hum of the heater filling the dead space. I stashed my bag in the basement bedroom, figuring there was no reason for them to go down there, then turned to face the door that lead upstairs.

I could just stay down here and watch them from my laptop. If anything, I'd get a better view through those little devices than I would through a crack in the bedroom door—if there even was a crack.

But I'd come this far. I couldn't not go all the way. Here was this fantasy—this ultimate fantasy that I didn't know I even had until a few months ago—happening right above me, just two stories up. My wife, Annie, was cheating on me. Was cuckolding me. And I was so very, painfully hard because of it. I needed to go up. I needed to at least try and see.

With my shoes off and my jacket and bag stowed away, I snuck upstairs.

I felt like smoke rising through the house, both choking and foreboding, yet lighter than air. Everything about this was dangerous, destructive, and yet I didn't care. Especially when I heard Annie's cries.

“Yes! Yes! That feels so...uhhhh...sooo good!”

And the slapping. SPANK! “Uh!” SPANK! “Yes!” SPANK!

Hearing it through the computer was so very different than hearing it in real life. It didn't prepare me for the aural assault. Like playing simulations of war, before actually being in it. Like watching porn before actually having sex.

They hadn't shut the door. They hadn't even half-shut it. It stood wide open at the end of the upstairs hall, the sounds of sex pouring out.

“Ready for my new surprise, Annie?” Rick asked the question like a threat, and Annie responded with a cry of yes.

I listened, floating down the hallway, pressed up against the wall so that I wouldn’t be seen. I listened and heard the click of metal on metal, then something harsh, rasping. Annie gasped. The metal clicked again, this time unmistakable. Handcuffs being tightened. I shut my eyes, wanting to imagine it. Needing to see it.

“There. Now I can do whatever I want to you.” SLAP!

“Oh, Rick,” Annie moaned. “You feel so big in me. So huge!”

“You like a big dick.”

“I *love* your big dick.”

“Remember the first time? When you didn’t think you could take it? Look at you now.”

I looked, too, standing back from the wide open door, and peering around the side. They were on the bed, facing away from me, yet profiled enough that I could see Annie’s breasts pressed down into the mattress and her knees tucked up under her. Her wrists were bound behind her with a pair of black, fuzzy handcuffs and her ass was raised and red, marred by Rick’s spanks.

He was balls deep in her pussy, thrusting hard enough to fill the room with the wet, slapping skin and Annie’s rising moans.

“Tell me you want this,” Rick ordered.

“I want—this! Want your cock. Want your... hghhh...” She gnashed her teeth, her knuckles going white. “Want your come!”

“Where?”

“Inside me. I want to feel you fill me up.”

Her submission to Rick tore at me, but in all the good ways. Sweet torture, landing harder than I could have ever imagined.

“Oh, sweet Annie. Such a naughty, naughty girl for me. You know what naughty girls need.” He spanked her, and Annie grunted out a moan. “Such a fantastic ass. God bless your horseback riding routine. I need to buy Ruby a bag of oats.”

That he knew Annie’s horse’s name landed almost as hard as watching him have unprotected sex with her. I pondered that for only a moment, though, rubbing my erection through my pants as I watched Rick build up speed.

And he really did pick up speed. This wasn't a gentle fuck. He fucked her with long, powerful thrusts. She struggled against the cuffs, helpless and face down as he drove her wild. As he drove her through two screaming, torrid orgasms.

Pulling out of her, I caught a glimpse of her gaping pussy before rolling her on her side and sliding up behind her. He entered her again, although my angle wasn't good enough that I could see much more than the man's ass, thrusting and muscular as he spoon-fucked Annie, her wrists still bound.

"You ready for my come, slut? You ready to feel me explode inside of you?"

"Yes! Do it. Come. Come inside of me!"

Rick rammed forward, thrusting deep as he nudged her vibrator against her clit. Like a bull, he grunted and roared, filling her, filling my wife's pussy full of his come. In my own bed.

She came with him, caught between cock and sex toy, losing herself in a sweaty, moaning mess.

Rick pulled out of her, once again treating me to a view of her gaping, red pussy, dripping with his come. He patted her hip before rolling away and sitting on the edge of the bed. I remembered myself just in time to duck around the corner, out of sight.

"I'm going to take a shower. Clean up," he announced.

"Aren't you going to uncuff me?"

"I don't think so. I like the idea of you bound." He did something that made Annie squeal. "But you can still be bound and join me. They're waterproof."

"Don't let me slip," Annie said.

"Of course not. You'll be on your knees the whole time."

I snuck away, back down into the basement, where I'd stashed my laptop. My computer. My secret view into their room. On the feed, I could see them in the shower. They hadn't bothered to shut the curtain, and I could see Annie, on her knees, her wrists still cuffed behind her back, bobbing on Rick's once again swelling cock.

I pulled my cock out and beat off to that vision of submission. It didn't take long for me to come. I was so wound up, so on edge since sneaking in, that the orgasm was a relief.

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Chapter 26

After the shower, they fell back into bed, once again kissing, once again making out. I was prepared to settle in for a long night when Annie said, “You can’t stay the night.”

“Why not? Your husband’s not back until tomorrow afternoon.”

“You can’t stay. You can’t sleep in the bed I share with him.”

Rick slid his hand between Annie’s thighs, pushing his fingers deep. “I don’t plan on sleeping much.”

Annie moaned, but held her ground. “I’m serious, Rick. This...” She sighed, her eyes fluttering shut, before finding her resolve again. “...this can’t go on.”

“I’ve heard that before,” Rick said. He kissed along her jaw, up to her ear. “And every time you just can’t resist.”

Annie’s head lolled to the side as he worked her body. I watched her fingers caress his muscled chest and the taut cords of his triceps. She was so into him. So enamored by him. But—

“My contract’s up with the Herald at the end of the month. I didn’t renew.”

Her words seemed to finally sink in for Rick. He pulled away from her, staring down at her. I saw confusion there. Here was a man who got whatever he wanted—who wasn’t used to any woman turning him down. And here was Annie, dumping him.

I’m not sure what I felt. Relief, yes, and pride that she hadn’t completely lost herself to another man. But there was also disappointment. That bittersweet sensation that all good things must come to an end—even self-destructive, emotionally ruinous good things.

“You’re not serious,” Rick said.

Annie reached up, touching his face tenderly. “You’re not used to this. I’m sorry it’s hard for you.”

I heard the sarcasm in her voice, subtle and so Annie. Rick did not. “I can talk to them. Get them to offer it again. We’ve got that podcast series —”

“Which I’ve given the Herald the rights to. They can have all the audio we recorded. It’s theirs, after all. But my involvement is over. It needs to

be.”

Rick looked stunned, blinking and speechless, his hand resting forgotten on her hip. I watched him process it in fluid, rapid succession—disbelief, realization, then something like anger. His handsome features hardened. The bull in him emerging. His jaw tightened as he rolled her onto her back and opened her legs.

“You’re not quitting. You know you need me.”

Fear leaped into my throat. I rose up on the bed, prepared to go upstairs if I needed to, already thinking about what objects I could grab on the way if I needed to defend Annie. But Annie just smiled up at him, sliding her hand around his neck.

“And that’s exactly why I need to quit. And why you can’t stay the night.”

“But—”

“Stop spoiling the moment, Rick, and fuck me. Make this last time count..”

When they coupled that final time—for it was their final time—there was an urgency to it that even I could feel. She didn’t cry out or talk dirty, and Rick didn’t make her. Instead, she clung to him tightly as he took her, caressing him with her long limbs and longer sighs.

They were kissing when they came—deep, passionate kisses that finally broke as Rick buried himself balls deep in Annie and unleashed himself. Annie wrapped a leg over his back, pushing into his buttocks with her heel as she joined him. The most startling thing was that they didn’t have their eyes closed, lost in their thoughts and fantasies as they came. Their eyes were open, their gaze unwavering as they panted and sighed through the mutual climax.

It haunted me, that look. It was a wakeup call. I could see their future unfold along this dangerous fantasy’s track, and one day, it wouldn’t involve me.

Most messed up of all? I wasn’t sure how I felt about that. If this is what made Annie happy, what she really wanted—

Interlude IV

“It’s not,” she tells me, interrupting my story and breaking me from the chains of my cuckold thoughts.

“Annie...” Dr. Caroline warns, acknowledging my wife’s presence in the room for the first time. Where she’s been sitting all along, listening to this tale as I did my best to ignore her.

“I’m sorry, Caroline, but I can’t just sit here anymore and stay quiet.”

Our doctor offers her a patient smile. “I understand, Annie, but this is what we agreed to. You need to hear his side of things. You wanted to understand him.”

Annie nods, her focus going back to her own, wringing hands. “I just need him to know that despite how things looked...” She glances up at me, hesitant. “It’s not what I really wanted, not really.”

Dr. Caroline looks at her, brows up. The two women exchange a conversation in that look. Annie nods, understanding. She says, “I’m sorry. I...did want him. That was the problem.”

Even now, after I’ve had all this time to process her affair, the confession still surges through me like electricity. My pants tighten. My chest does, too.

Annie finishes. “I wanted him, but I didn’t want to *be* with him. I didn’t love who I was with him. It was exciting, but I was scared to be out of control like that. I knew there was no future with him. My only future is with you, Travis. That’s never changed.”

I stare at her for a good long time. She’s beautiful, although she’s done her best to hide that fact. Her hair is drawn back into a tight ponytail. She’s wearing a loose sweater and a pair of mom-jeans that I didn’t even know she owned. But to me, she glows, just as she did when I first met her, when all I could see was her eyes.

“Travis?” Dr. Caroline says softly.

Annie and I share a tense smile. She nods.

“Would you like to finish up your story? I have a feeling it’s almost done.”

I blink. I want nothing more than to hold her, to hug her. But I have to finish this story. I’m so close. “Okay. Yes. The ending. Here goes...”

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Chapter 27

Rick left shortly after they made love that last time—and that’s what it was. Or the prelude to making love, at the very least. He didn’t try to insist that he stay, although as he kissed her at the door, I also was pretty sure he didn’t think things were really over.

When he was gone and Annie was alone in the house, she looked lost. She just stood there, staring at the closed door. She’d pulled her short robe on and it hung sexy and loose around her, but there was nothing sexual about this scene anymore.

She turned, looking around the darkness of the house as if it were a stranger’s. She drifted over to the mantle, right beneath my camera, and looked at the family photos we’d lined it with. Every few moments, she’d shut her eyes and shake her head angrily. I saw her work her jaw. Saw how upset she was.

After, she went upstairs and reappeared on the bedroom cameras with her diary in hand. Cross-legged on the bed, she wrote a long entry—an entry that I still haven’t read to this day. Tears filled her eyes as she wrote it. Most didn’t escape the perimeter of her lashes, but a few did, rolling in shimmering trails down her freckled cheeks.

Shutting the diary, she sank back into the piled pillows behind her and shut her eyes, breathing slowly. Deliberately. I watched from the basement, wondering what I should do, and knowing what I certainly should not—to go up there and comfort her. To be with her.

Yet that’s all I wanted to do. Despite everything—the lies, the betrayals, and infidelity. Or maybe that’s exactly why I wanted to go her.

I watched as she picked up her phone and considered it. She was debating something in her head. To text Rick to come back? My heart skipped. She tapped something on her phone, and a moment later, my own phone rang.

“Annie?”

I watched her respond to my voice through my cameras—that smile of relief, that desperate need to hear something familiar. Suddenly, all this voyeurism sunk in as creepy. Looking back, it’s insane that it took me so long to realize that.

“Travis...” Annie sighed. “You...how’s everything going there?”

I didn’t know what to say. I was tired of the lying, and maybe it was just projecting, but it looked like Annie was, too.

“It’s going,” I said.

She was quiet for a long moment. I watched her breathing, growing heavier and heavier. She was working herself up to something. “Trav?”

My own breath felt short. “Yes, Annie?”

“I...” My whole body felt squeezed. “...love you.”

Not a confession, but I felt the weight of her apology in the statement. She wasn’t just saying the words. There was meaning behind it. Sorrow and regret and sadness. Relief. I felt it too. Felt it rise through me as I ascended the stairs, phone in hand.

“Annie, there’s something I need to tell you,” I said.

“What?” she asked, hesitant. Afraid.

“I know.”

I was away from my computer, but didn’t need to see her face to know she was stricken. To know that those large, blue eyes were wide, her face as white as a ghost.

“But there’s more,” I went on. I needed to confess my own sins. I needed to get them off my chest.

“I’m so sorry, Travis,” Annie said, her voice on the verge of breaking. “I’m so, so sorry.”

I entered the bedroom, phone by my side. “It’s okay, Annie. I think we’re going to be okay.”

Annie blinked, looking up at me from her bed like I was a ghost. A stranger. “Travis? What are you—”

I was on her before she could say more. I don’t even remember crossing the room, or pulling my shirt off. I don’t remember much beyond seeing her there on the bed, in the flesh, and the feeling of my mouth on hers, devouring her lips. I could smell Rick on her—his cologne, his musk, even traces of his come. I could smell her excitement, her sweat, her tears.

“Travis, what are you doing here?” Annie said when she could pull back, could breathe again.

I wasn’t having it. She’d been someone else’s all night—more than that. They call this reclaiming, when the cuckold comes back home after a wife’s been bad and takes back what’s his.

Only Annie wasn't a possession, and she was also too confused. She pushed me away. "Travis, stop. What's going on here?"

The sad Annie was gone. The regretful, guilty one falling away to something more rational. To the Annie of old. The Annie I knew.

"I've known for a long time. I've known about Rick. About your...affair." Saying that word felt like a grenade had been dropped at our feet. It made me rush on. "I knew he'd come here tonight."

She looked at me like I'd grown a second head. "How?" Her eyes darted as she thought, making connections faster than I could follow. "That's why you came home early?"

My face blossomed with heat. I almost went with her misinterpretation, but we needed to be honest now. "I never went."

"You..." She clamored back, sitting up straight and putting some space between us. "You knew, but didn't stop us? Didn't say anything?" She jumped to the next obvious conclusion, her eyes wide and watering. "Do you want a divorce?"

"No," I blurted. "God no."

"Then why?"

I shut my eyes. This was harder than I thought it would be. An alcoholic admitting his addiction. "Because I... it..." When I opened my eyes, she was looking at me with confusion. "Because it turns me on."

Her jaw actually dropped. "What?"

"I have this fantasy. Always have, I guess, since way back before we even got married, about you...and other men."

Annie blinked. I'm sure she had theories about what was going on, but this clearly wasn't one of them. It looked like I'd short-circuited her brain.

"It probably started during our year apart, as a coping method. When you were with Brian Hoffman—"

"You knew about that?"

"I suspected. I didn't know until I read it in your—" I froze, suddenly realizing that maybe this was something I should keep to myself. Too late. I looked at her, watching her brow fall and her breath catch.

"Read my what, Travis?" she asked. She sounded calm, but I knew she wasn't. There was hurt there, welling up with her tears.

I hung my head. "Your diary."

Annie just stared at me without speaking, and I wanted to crawl into myself, into my shame. I managed to say, "I'm sorry," but I wasn't even

sure if she heard me.

“You read my diary?” she said, more to herself. When she fixed her gaze back on me, she asked plainly, “Why would you do that? What possessed you to invade my privacy?”

Her voice quaked.

“I...I’m sorry. I couldn’t help it. When I suspected that something was going on—”

“So you read my diary? That’s where you went? It never occurred to you to ask me?” She didn’t yell, but her interruption rang in my ears.

And she was right. I could have asked. *Should* have asked. How many times had I wondered how different this would have played out had we talked. But we hadn’t, and I why was I the one on my heels, anyway? I hadn’t cheated. She had.

“How do I know you’d tell me the truth? You were the one cheating on me,” I said, louder and more angry than I’d intended.

“And you were getting off reading about it, apparently.” She pushed her hand through her thick hair as she got out of bed, shaking her head. The tears were streaming down her cheeks now. “God, this is so fucked up. I can’t even... I don’t know...”

“I’m sorry, Annie—”

“You knew. This whole time, you knew. And here I was, so guilty for doing it—”

“Not too guilty, apparently.”

Her voice rose. “If this was all some kind of thrill for you, I don’t know why I should feel guilty at all!”

“That’s not fair,” I argued, confused how this was turning so hard on me.

“I’m not feeling too fair right now, Travis. I’m so fucking confused, I don’t know what to feel.”

Her head snapped in my direction, her face crumpling. Turning away from me, she yanked some sweats from her dresser.

I wanted to go to her. Put my hand on her back and comfort her. But I was torn. Now that this was all out in the open, I felt the anger over this affair that I’d been suppressing, that my fantasy had somehow held in check. The betrayal finally landed with its full, heavy weight.

“What else did you do? Tap my phone? Break into my emails? Hire a PI? Did he give you a video of us?”

Automatically, my eyes slid to the hidden camera above the dresser behind her. Annie followed. She found it, grabbing it and staring at the little surveillance camera like a live snake. Her focus shifted between it and me, betrayal and disbelief playing across her face.

“Oh my god! I can’t—” She shook her head, closing her eyes. She tossed the camera onto the bed, limply, and took a deep breath. “I can’t *believe this. You watched us?*” The anger and rage she packed caught me by surprise. “I feel so...” She shivered, clutching herself in a defensive, tight hug. “So violated.”

“Annie, I’m sorry. But it’s not like either of us are innocent.” It came out more aggressively than I intended. Annie came alive.

“You know, you’re absolutely right. I cheated on you. I’m a whore. I was tempted, and I should have fought it harder. But you... *you...* You spied on me. You *wanted* me to cheat. You watched me fuck another man... Did you jerk off? Who does that? Who wants that?” The tears flowed freely.

She looked at the camera beside me and shook her head. “Our marriage is broken, and I don’t know how to fix it. Not right now, and right now, I can’t stay here. I can’t be in this house, feeling like you’re watching me.”

I should have gotten up to stop her. We could still fix this. All we needed to do was calm down and we could work this out. We had so much history between us. Only, as I stared up at her from the bed, all I could think about was the distance, vast and deep and overwhelming.

So I just said the first thing to pop into my head. “Where are you going?”

“Just follow me on your GPS!,” she spat. Grabbing her diary, she marched down the stairs.

“Annie...” I followed her out the door, intending to say something constructive. Restorative. To extend my olive branch, but I was angry too. Why was I the villain in this situation? *She* cheated, not *me*. Instead, what came out of my mouth was something I’d regret for a long time after. “You know what? Go. That’s fine. Run to your boyfriend’s. I’m sure he’ll be happy to have you back.”

She rounded on me at the base of the stairs, fury and fire in her eyes. But when she spoke, her voice was soft. Pitying. “I should...” She stopped, and just shook her head. She left with the slam of the door that echoed

endlessly through the now-empty house. And when it stopped, the silence was equally deafening.

“Fuck,” I said to myself.

I drifted downstairs, a ghostly shell of myself. Of course it would end this way. Of course she’d be angry.

Why didn’t you just ask?

Why hadn’t I? Why hadn’t I talked to her about this fantasy? Why had it consumed me?

Our marriage is broken.

Nothing underlined that sentiment more than when I picked up her iPad and watched her GPS blip move out onto the highway, a part of me hoped she was heading for Rick’s. And that part was turned on.

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Chapter 28

She didn't go to Rick's. She went to Lisa's. Of course she did. That registered with a mixture of relief and disappointment—mostly relief, though. My body was still ringing like a struck bell after our confrontation. Reality had finally arrived, and it wasn't pretty. All things come to an end, right?

I drove back to the hotel and checked out, bringing my things home. There, I went through the house and dismantled my amateur surveillance system. When it came to all the video that I'd recorded onto my laptop, though, I couldn't delete it. I tried. I came close. At one point, it was in the digital trash bin. But in the end, I couldn't do it. I zipped it up, put a password on it, and hid it away. I needed it there. I needed to be able to look back on it and remind myself that it had all happened.

Which is what I did—many times—during the long stint of our separation. That was the hardest month of my life, being apart from Annie. But it was necessary. We were broken, as she said. And only time could fix it. It couldn't be forced.

She stayed with Lisa, needing the space. I understood. We both needed it. There was so much to wrap our heads around, and we both needed to get our heads in the right place before coming back together. Otherwise, things would end the way they had in the house.

We spoke mostly through Lisa. Lisa, who knew the truth now and was suddenly the most saintly one of the three of us.

"She still loves you, you know. Despite the fact that you're an idiot."

"How am I the idiot?" Lisa fixed me with a flat stare. I groaned. "I know I shouldn't have invaded her privacy and spied on her, but *she was cheating on me*—"

"And you liked that. Don't play dumb with me. I may be blonde, but you've never thought of me as a bimbo, right?" It was true. Sometimes, with all her antics, it was easy to pretend that she wasn't just as sharp as Annie. She sighed. "And besides, that's not why you're an idiot."

"So tell me, oh wise one." But really, I knew.

"Because if you'd have played your cards right, you probably could have spied on her and watched her have her fling *with* her, not behind her

back.”

“Uh, she was the one doing things behind my back—”

“You both were.”

“And I really don’t think she would have done any of it if she knew I knew.”

“How do you know that? She tell you that?” She looked at me smugly. “She write about it in her diary?”

“Well, no. Not exactly.” I considered it a moment. “She tell you something?”

Lisa shook her head. “No, and even if she did, anything she’d say is in hindsight. But my point is that you need to start talking to her. Opening up. Tell her the truth.”

“She walked out on me.”

“And you haven’t attempted to reach out to her,” Lisa shot back.

I groaned. “So you have a plan?”

“No, but I have a therapist’s name. She specializes in stuff like this.”

“A marriage counselor? I know a few myself. Remember what I do for a living?”

“Caroline isn’t just any marriage counselor. She specializes in the cuckold thing.”

My body began to buzz, just at the mention of the word. Lisa picked up on it too. “It really gets to you, doesn’t it?”

“So my actions suggest.”

“Annie’s been talking to her. You should, too. Tell her your story. She may surprise you. She frequently surprises me.”

“Okay. Give me this Dr. Caroline’s number. At this point, what do I have to lose?”

Epilogue

“And that brings us to the present,” I finish.

It’s hard to look at Annie, so I keep my focus on Dr. Caroline. Annie and I have been meeting with Dr. Caroline for the past month, separately. Only recently, in these last couple sessions, has Dr. Caroline invited us together, with the explicit instruction that Annie is just an observer.

“She needs to hear your story,” Dr. Caroline explained before we underwent it. “All of it. The easy stuff, but also the hard stuff. She needs to understand.”

So here we are, at the end of all the story, the easy and the hard.

“How do you feel, Travis?” Dr. Caroline asks.

“Like a weight’s been lifted off my chest.” It’s true. I hate the cliché, but for the first time in months, I can actually breathe.

“It’s quite a story.”

Color and heat flood my face. I finally look at Annie, sitting off to the side, looking thoughtful. She’s beautiful. I swear, she’s more beautiful than ever. Her copper hair shimmering, falling around her in loose, effortless curls. When she feels my stare on her, she looks up, locking on to me with those luminous, intelligent, empathetic blue eyes. I’m transported back to our first meeting, when everything was new and mysterious and fresh.

In a way, things feel just like that. I have no idea what comes next. I have no idea where we go from here. But I want to go somewhere. With her. I realize now just how much I fucked up. How we both fucked up.

“Annie, I’m sorry for doing that to you.”

A tear trickles down her freckled cheek. She shakes her head. “I...” She stops, bites her lip, and looks at Dr. Caroline. The marriage counselor nods her head, allowing her to speak.

“I’ve spent a long time struggling with all of this. For the first couple weeks, I couldn’t feel anything but anger. I’ll admit, I was using my anger with you to avoiding facing what I’d done to you—to us. I just couldn’t understand why you’d do that, why you felt entitled to do that. I felt betrayed. It’s been hard to get over being spied on, it still creeps me out, but I’m trying to get past it.” She meets my eyes.

“But when I got past all that, I had to face what I’d done. What you did, it didn’t alter the fact that I’d betrayed you. Your behavior was in reaction to what I did, you didn’t do any of this in a vacuum. I can’t be a hypocrite. I violated our marriage, and you didn’t make me pay for that. You dealt with it in your own way, and I love you, I owe it to you to try to understand why you reacted how you did. So I’ve been trying.” She takes a deep, steadying breath. “It’s hard, but I’ve made it my life’s work to understand people, and no one is more important than you.” Annie’s voice shakes with raw emotion, and she has to pause. I want to reach out to her.

It begins to dawn on me, after nearly twenty years of marriage, just how special Annie is. I begin to tell her that, but Dr. Caroline holds her hand up, silencing me. Letting Annie continue. I talked for so long, I’m happy to yield.

“I’m not claiming to understand what drives it, but I do understand that you were just trying to find a way in, however twisted and unorthodox.” She allows a smile. “I put a space between us. I was excluding you, and you were trying to find a way to be part of it. Instead of rejecting me for my behavior, you wanted me even more. I see that it was an act of love.”

“Put like that,” I say, to lighten the mood, “it does sound a little strange.”

“Travis,” Dr. Caroline warns.

Annie continues. “I was terribly unfair. We both did awful things, but I tried to make what you did worse than my behavior. I tried to claim a moral high ground by saying I was normal and you weren’t. It was wrong. After a lot of work, I can admit that. I’ve done my research on cuckolding and hotwives. Sure, it’s not common, but to say it’s not normal is an unfair moral judgment. People we would call normal are into it. Lisa’s even dated a few guys like that.”

“Of course she has.”

“Our therapist is one,” Annie says, looking at Dr. Caroline.

I turn my eyes on the prim therapist, her blond hair in a bun, her thick-rimmed glasses shielding her rich, brown eyes. She says, “It’s why I wanted to start helping couples such as yourselves. It can be a hard and confusing lifestyle. Certainly not for everyone.”

“And for us?” I ask.

“That’s up to the two of you. You two need to repair your relationship first. Rebuild the trust you once had. After that?” She shrugs. “I’ll be here

to work with you after that, if you want me to.”

Annie slides out of her seat, moving into the space at my side. Our hips touch. She reaches out and takes my hands. Looks me in the eyes, and in those eyes, I see all the hurt that I brought on her, just how deeply I violated her. And I hate myself for doing that. “I’m so sorry I...did what I did,” I say.

Annie shakes her head. “I’m sorry, too,” she says. “About Rick. That I felt like I needed him when I had you.”

“I should have talked to you, not snuck around.”

She sniffles. “Ditto.”

“Who knows how it would have all worked out if I had? I was just so caught up I couldn’t think straight.”

Annie smiled through her tears. “I think that was both of us. Neither of us was thinking clearly.”

“I’ll never betray your trust again.”

“And I promise I’ll never give you a reason to want to. And if you’ll have me back, I’m ready to start rebuilding what we had.”

“Of course I’ll have you. I never wanted you to leave.” My vision blurs. I wipe my tears away with the back of my hand.

“I don’t deserve you, Travis Belmont.”

“I believe the good Dr. Caroline there is about to tell you that we need to get past who deserves who, right?” Caroline is smiling when we look at her, nodding. “So let’s leave that behind, okay? We have each other, if we want it. ‘For better, or for worse’, right?”

The tears come fast for Annie, rolling in glistening trails down her cheeks. “Don’t those vows also come with something about being ‘true’ to one another?”

“Well, we start working on truth next.”

She nods, but pulls back. I want to grab her. Hug her. Hold her against me. But let her go. She doesn’t go far, though, twisting to reach into her bag. She pulls out a blue, faux leather diary. The golden lock is unclasped. She opens it to a page in the middle and hands it to me.

“I want you to read this. Then we can start on the next phase of our lives. Okay?”

“I don’t need to—”

“I want you to. And from now on, if you ever need to know what’s going on in here...” She taps her temple. “Just ask. I’ll even let you read

from here. Just... ask.”

“I will. Of course I will.” My hands tremble as I take the diary from her. I turn my eyes to the page, to her beautiful, handwritten script.

“I love you, Travis.”

I read.

Friday, October 25

It's over. Really over this time. I can't go on leading a double life, and I can't go on pretending that I can have an affair and it doesn't impact my marriage. I can't be Rick's whore and Travis's wife. I have to choose, and I'll choose my husband every time.

Being with Rick is fun and exciting and dangerous, but I don't like who I am when I am with him. I'm weak. I don't want to be a woman who doesn't stick to her word. Rick has been badgering me to come over so he could fuck me in my “marital bed”. Of course I've told him no every time, but I slipped and let him know that Travis would be out of town. Rick didn't ask this time. He told me he was coming over, and God help me, I didn't stop him. Rick fucked me in my bed tonight. The bed I share with my husband. It was everything Rick wanted. I was his wanton whore in the bed I share with my husband, and it's just wrong. I don't want to be a woman who would do that.

I told the Herald this week I won't be renewing my contract again, and they couldn't talk me out of it. The only way I can stay away from Rick is to physically stay away from him. I told Rick tonight after we had sex. He didn't take it well, which told me everything I needed to know about him. He'll never be the man Travis is. I could never be with a man like that, and while I'm not going to lie here and say that I don't already feel the loss, I'll get by. I have to.

To tell Travis, or not tell him? Even if I confess my affair, do I tell Travis all of it? Do I tell him what I became with Rick? I don't want to hurt Travis, but I don't know if I can just put aside who I was with Rick. He awakened something inside me, and I want to explore that with Travis. I want to give myself to my husband the way I gave myself to my lover. I want to be Travis's whore.

How can I tell Travis that? I don't want to lose him, but how can he ever accept what I became for Rick?

But what's my alternative? To live this lie? To keep it bottled up inside me? To keep writing in this damn journal, hoping that it's enough? No. I'm so scared of losing Travis, but if I'm not honest, I'll lose him anyway, slowly, inevitably. Telling him is the only way forward. I can't shut this awakened part of me away, even though it would be so much easier. She's a part of me now—the slut, the whore, the woman who shudders just thinking about being spanked.

I am so scared of losing Travis, but I have to be honest with him. It's the least I owe him. I don't know what my life is without him. Crazy it took an affair for me to realize that.

I don't know what the future will bring, but I know that I want Travis to be a part of it. And if he's going to be a part of it, he needs to know.

Wish us luck.

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Six months later...

Annie is leaning against the veranda on the second story of the white-washed building, her long white dress billowing in the breeze. I catch the sun through it, seeing the outline of her long legs through the loose material. She turns away from me and when the light plays across her dress again, I swear I see her white thong beneath.

I pull out my phone and snap a photo—an encapsulation of our trip to the Greek Isles—just as a man steps into the frame. He's older than her, the scuff on his jaw gray, his hair more salt than pepper. He hands her a glass of wine, which she takes, and laughs at whatever he says.

My heart skips a beat. My pants tighten. I'd already watched them flirting earlier, when they thought I wasn't looking. It's why I made an excuse to step out. Why I left her alone with him, despite it being the eve of our twenty year anniversary. I wanted to see what she'd do.

Now, I watch her flirt. Watch her drink the wine he bought her and touch his arm when she makes a point. And I think of Rick. I'll never not think of Rick. He's now a part of us and who we are as a couple.

The man leans in, whispering something to Annie. I freeze, my chest tightening as I watch from the terrace below. Does she know I'm there? Does she know that I've come back?

Annie pulls away, covering her mouth as she shakes her head, laughing. Shocked. Amused. The man persists, stepping closer still. Whispering again, this time right up against her ear. She nods, and he looks pleased. He presses something into her hand, then leaves her with her thoughts.

She turns back to the edge of the veranda, facing me, but looking out at the water beyond, where the sun sets on the Santorini caldera. It's a postcard view, I know, but I'm more enthralled with the view of my wife.

I make my way up the stairs and back into the restaurant and bar. Back to Annie. She's still there, still looking out at the sea. The burning sky beyond her sets off the red highlights in her hair, which billows in the soft, evening breeze.

I step up beside her. She speaks without turning in my direction. "Did you enjoy the show?"

“You saw me.”

She smiles to herself. She didn’t know, but now does. When she turns to me, she tucks a strand of hair behind her ear. “I thought we talked about this. No more secrets.”

“You’re right.” I pull her into my arms. “So tell me... what did he want?”

Her pale face is awash with the sunset. This vacation and all the beach time we’ve had has brought her freckles out, once again, and I want to kiss every one of them.

“He invited me back to his room.”

My cock twitches. “Very forward.”

“Very.”

“What did you say?”

“I told him to give me an hour.”

My stomach fluttered. It is suddenly hard to breathe. “Did you?”

“It’s what he wanted to hear.” She brushes her hand across the front of my pants, finding me hard. “What you want to hear, too, it seems.”

“Are you sure?”

Annie laughs, finishing off her wine. She sets it on the edge of the veranda and spins away. “Come on, let’s get out of here. Time’s ticking.”

In the months since my big confession, we’ve talked a lot. We revisited Rick and her time with him. We talked about the woman she became when she was with him, and how attracted I was to that version of her, even though she’d hidden that side from me.

But I was careful not to push things, not to suggest we jump right back into some kind of...hotwife arrangement or something. Everything was still too raw. The trust still wasn’t back. For either of us. Not like it was before. Maybe it never would be again.

I’d be at work and wonder if she was with someone else. She’d go to ride Ruby and I’d wonder if maybe she was meeting a lover. She let me read her diary. She even offered to keep her location services on so I could know where she was at any given time. I told her not to do that. That I trusted her, and that if things ever got to where they were with Rick, that she should talk to me about it.

She hasn’t. Not even in a teasing way. Not until now, here in Santorini.

We don’t even make it back to our room. Neither of us can wait, but it’s actually Annie who pulls me into the alcove beneath a little, arched

bridge. It's private. No one else walks this path, and hidden in the shadows, now that the sun has set, we can't be seen. But we can still hear others around, using the bridge above or murmuring from a cafe less than a few hundred feet away. There's risk, which makes this exciting.

"I can't wait," she whispers as she pulls me close. "I need you right now."

Our lips meet, deeply, passionately. It's a kiss as fresh as our first, only shared two decades later. As I touch her, running my hand down her hip to find the high slit of her billowing, white dress, my heart hammers with need.

"Tell me what made you so excited?" I ask between kisses.

She doesn't deny or play coy. She knows what I want to hear—the truth. "Christos."

"That's his name?" I would have laughed at how Greek it was if I wasn't so turned on.

She nods.

I push my hand beneath her dress and up the smooth back of her thigh. "A little old for you, don't you think?"

Christos was probably in his early fifties.

"I actually like that."

"Really? Because Rick..."

"Rick just happened."

My stomach squirms as I follow the implication. "If you were to have your own affair, you'd pick someone older."

"I like them distinguished," Annie says. "Confident."

"Dominant," I add, remembering her time with her younger lover. "You think Christos will make you get on your knees?"

I push at her shoulders, and she goes down with only a quick glance behind her. She brushes her hands along my crotch, grabbing my erection through my linen pants. "I think he would."

"Suck my cock like you're going to suck his."

It's not something I could have said before the big confession. Before the affair. But now, it comes easily. That Annie responds so well to the dirty talk still amazes me, though. She looks up at me, her blue eyes filled with need as she opens my pants and fishes out my cock.

Since Rick, she's become a master at blow jobs. She takes me to the root now, swallowing me into the back of her throat with little warmup. Her

lips touch my pubic hair, which I've started to keep trimmed for Annie. I wonder if Christos trims. I wonder if he's got a big cock. I wonder if Annie will be able to deep throat him as easily as she does me.

She pulls off me, gasping, her mouth red, her face flushed. "You're so hard."

"Can't help it."

"Thinking about me with him, are you?"

"And you?"

She looks at me slyly, then nods before going back to sucking my cock. But I want to hear more about it. I want to fill my imagination with her dirty words. So I push her back and pull her up onto her feet.

Reaching beneath her dress, I pull off her thong. Annie helps, just as desperate for it as I am. She laughs at how crazy this is as I push her back against the whitewashed walls and pull her dress up around her hips.

"We really doing this?" she asks.

"Shh," I whisper as I pull one of her legs up against my hip. "Don't want anyone to find us."

She guides me against her pussy, rubbing my cockhead against her clit just to show me how wet she is. And how smooth. When we got back together, I was surprised that she'd kept up the clean shaven look. She told me that she liked the look and feel of it, which is probably true. But nevertheless makes me wonder if anything happened during our separation—a mystery I've deliberately not explored. Yet. Some habits die hard.

How did she write it in her diary, about her gap year? She didn't seek it out, didn't put herself out there, because she didn't have to. Because guys were easy. Was that what happened?

I lifted her up off her heels as I thrust forward, sinking into her wet pussy.

"So did Christos just walk up to you?"

"With a drink in hand," she says, gasping.

"How does that make you feel? To have guys approach you like that?"

"It...it makes me..." She moans quietly. "...feel good...sexy...desired."

I help her out. "Especially with someone as good looking as Christos."

"Yes. It's always—" She gasps, fingers tightening in my hair. "Always nice."

"Is that how it worked, back when you were finishing up school and we were apart?"

I swear, I feel her pussy tighten. I fuck her harder, my arms burning as I lift and hold her against the wall and pound her.

“Yes. I never...never went looking.”

“You just let the guys do all the work.” Adrenaline pumps through me. I want to punish her. Anger rises with my lust. Anger that it’s so easy for her. Almost inevitable.

“Oh, no... I did plenty of...work.” She stares down at me, red hair stuck on her sweaty forehead. “Just not until we got into the bedroom.”

I almost lose it. I fuck her furiously, clenching her buttocks in my hand. We kiss, tongues diving and swirling and fighting. Her fist clutches in my hair, pain searing. I ignore it. Pull back.

“How many times? Back then?” I stare at her, finally asking the question I’ve been so curious about for so many years. “How many men did you fuck while you weren’t looking for it?”

I hold her face as I ask, forcing her to look at me. She meets my eyes without answering at first, drawing the moment out. Then: “Three.”

“Including your professor.”

“Yes.”

“Do I know the others?”

She shakes her head. “They were just some fun.”

My balls tighten. My come builds, desperate for release. I thrust into her, staring into Annie’s brilliant blue eyes. “And...” I hesitate, even though I want to ask. Even though it’s the perfect time. “And when we were separated?”

Annie stares at me, amused. “Did I fuck anyone while during our separation?”

My stomach drops. Like the floor fell out beneath me. “Did you?” I’m already coming. I can’t stop the flood. Even the possibility feels like a detonation, deep inside of me. “Oh, fuck, Annie. Oh—”

She covers my mouth with her hand, having sense enough to quiet me even as her own orgasm rolls through her, tightening her face, her eyes, her whole body.

We come down from our high, clutching at one another as the world around us returns. We’re still alone, still hidden. But we need to move before that changes.

“Wow,” Annie says, uncovering my mouth. “You like that idea.”

“Did you?” I ask, the gag off.

She bats her lashes, but shakes her head. I feel some disappointment, but mostly relief. "I was fighting for my marriage, Travis. Still am. And I swear to you, if I ever do something like that again, it won't be behind your back."

We get dressed quickly. She hooks her arm in mine and guides us out of the alcove. The sun's fully set, and the moon glitters on the sea before us. We wander down the street, stopping at a vista to enjoy the view.

"So what about tonight?" I ask.

She looks confused. I help her out. "Christos?"

"Oh, right. Christos." She looks sheepish.

"He didn't actually ask you to his room," I say.

"He did. But I told him I was with my husband, and that tonight was just for us." She kisses my lips lightly. Whispers, "Sorry if that's disappointing."

I feel like she's lifted me off my feet. I want to dance across the sky. Instead, I hold her close. "Never, sweetheart."

"But you liked the idea."

"I did," I agree.

"And now I know."

I pull back. "The last year didn't prove that to you?"

"The last year's been fluid. A lot's happened since then. I needed to make sure." Such a typical Annie response.

"Now what?"

"I don't know." We hold one another. "But it'll be fun."

More from Kenny Wright

For a full list of books by Kenny Wright (and where to buy them), go Hotwifebooks.com or checkout his website at kennywriter.com.

If you enjoyed the "cheating wife" theme and are looking for more from Kenny Wright, check out:

Separated, With Benefits

Ethan and Nicole met, dated, got married, a job took Ethan away, and they separated. And that's how it would have ended had circumstances not brought Ethan home a year later.

When he sees his wife again after so long, he realizes just how much he lost. When they fall into a physical, friends-with-benefits arrangement, he realizes that he wants more. And when he begins to suspect that he's not the only man in her life anymore, his reaction shocks him.

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The Woman She Was (A Naughty Wife Short)

Bryce King was his wife's college boyfriend during her "bad boy phase," whatever that means. That, and a single photo, are all that Chris knew about the guy. So naturally, he's curious. When Chris finds himself seated next to Bryce King on a plane, headed back home to Philly, he realizes that he's got a golden opportunity.

But when he does learn more about the kind of man Bryce was, and the wild and dirty women he dated, can Chris handle it? Is that his wife that Bryce is talking about, and did she do all of those things? And when he finally gets home, will he ever be able to look at her the same way again?

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Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time he thinks of Erin with AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

***The Forbidden series* ([Something Forbidden](#) and the follow-up, [Nothing Forbidden](#))**

Wife-watching. Swinging. Consensual infidelity. These are not concepts that Maxwell Callahan understands, let alone fantasizes about. Max has a great life: husband, father, successful bar owner. He has no plans to shake it up.

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Smart, successful, yet a little conservative, he never thought Katie would entertain such an idea...until she does. This suburban couple is about to

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Kenny Wright also regularly contributes to the Best Hotwife Books anthology:

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About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at @kennywriter. I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.

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